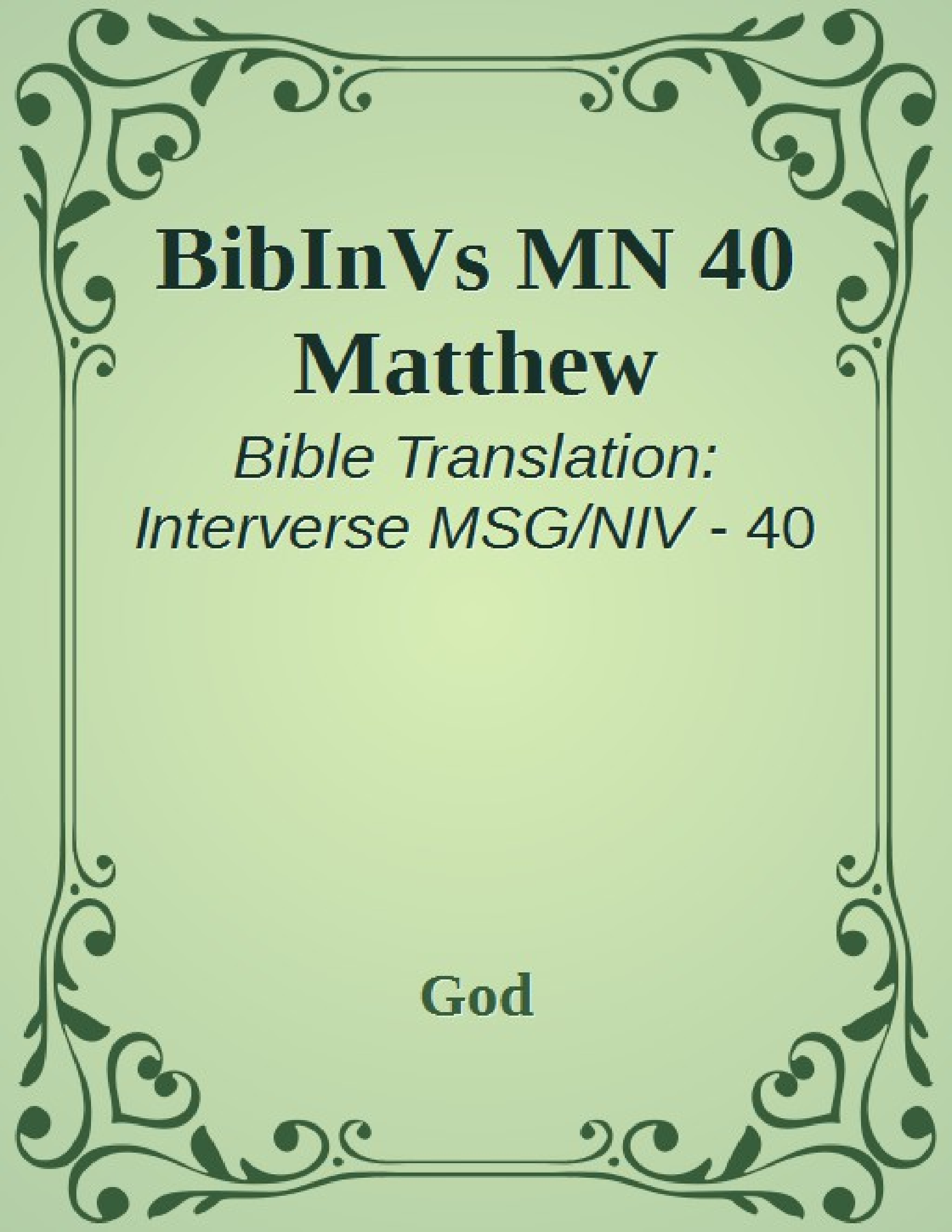


A decorative border with intricate floral and scrollwork patterns in a dark green color, framing the central text.

BibInVs MN 40

Matthew

*Bible Translation:
Interverse MSG/NIV - 40*

God

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Interversed Message/NIV Bible

Matthew

Matthew 1

MSG

NIV

- 1 The family tree of Jesus Christ, David's son, Abraham's son:
- 1 A record of the genealogy of Jesus Christ the son of David, the son of Abraham:
- 2 Abraham had Isaac, Isaac had Jacob, Jacob had Judah and his brothers,
- 2 Abraham was the father of Isaac, Isaac the father of Jacob, Jacob the father of Judah and his brothers,
- 3 Judah had Perez and Zerah (the mother was Tamar), Perez had Hezron, Hezron had Aram,
- 3 Judah the father of Perez and Zerah, whose mother was Tamar, Perez the father of Hezron, Hezron the father of Ram,
- 4 Aram had Amminadab, Amminadab had Nahshon, Nahshon had Salmon,
- 4 Ram the father of Amminadab, Amminadab the father of Nahshon, Nahshon the father of Salmon,
- 5 Salmon had Boaz (his mother was Rahab), Boaz had Obed (Ruth was the mother), Obed had Jesse,
- 5 Salmon the father of Boaz, whose mother was Rahab, Boaz the father of Obed, whose mother was Ruth, Obed the father of Jesse,
- 6 Jesse had David, and David became king. David had Solomon (Uriah's wife was the mother),
- 6 and Jesse the father of King David. David was the father of Solomon, whose mother had been Uriah's wife,
- 7 Solomon had Rehoboam, Rehoboam had Abijah, Abijah had Asa,
- 7 Solomon the father of Rehoboam, Rehoboam the father of Abijah, Abijah the father of Asa,
- 8 Asa had Jehoshaphat, Jehoshaphat had Joram, Joram had Uzziah,
- 8 Asa the father of Jehoshaphat, Jehoshaphat the father of Jehoram, Jehoram the father of Uzziah,

- 9 Uzziah had Jotham, Jotham had Ahaz, Ahaz had Hezekiah,
9 Uzziah the father of Jotham, Jotham the father of Ahaz, Ahaz the father of Hezekiah,
10 Hezekiah had Manasseh, Manasseh had Amon, Amon had Josiah,
10 Hezekiah the father of Manasseh, Manasseh the father of Amon, Amon the father of Josiah,
11 Josiah had Jehoiachin and his brothers, and then the people were taken into the Babylonian exile.
11 and Josiah the father of Jeconiah and his brothers at the time of the exile to Babylon.
12 When the Babylonian exile ended, Jehoiachin had Shealtiel, Shealtiel had Zerubbabel,
12 After the exile to Babylon: Jeconiah was the father of Shealtiel, Shealtiel the father of Zerubbabel,
13 Zerubbabel had Abiud, Abiud had Eliakim, Eliakim had Azor,
13 Zerubbabel the father of Abiud, Abiud the father of Eliakim, Eliakim the father of Azor,
14 Azor had Zadok, Zadok had Achim, Achim had Eliud,
14 Azor the father of Zadok, Zadok the father of Akim, Akim the father of Eliud,
15 Eliud had Eleazar, Eleazar had Matthan, Matthan had Jacob,
15 Eliud the father of Eleazar, Eleazar the father of Matthan, Matthan the father of Jacob,
16 Jacob had Joseph, Mary's husband, the Mary who gave birth to Jesus, the Jesus who was called Christ.
16 and Jacob the father of Joseph, the husband of Mary, of whom was born Jesus, who is called Christ.
17 There were fourteen generations from Abraham to David, another fourteen from David to the Babylonian exile, and yet another fourteen from the Babylonian exile to Christ.
17 Thus there were fourteen generations in all from Abraham to David, fourteen from David to the exile to Babylon, and fourteen from the exile to the Christ.
18 The birth of Jesus took place like this. His mother, Mary, was engaged to be married to Joseph. Before they came to the marriage bed, Joseph

discovered she was pregnant. (It was by the Holy Spirit, but he didn't know that.)

18 This is how the birth of Jesus Christ came about: His mother Mary was pledged to be married to Joseph, but before they came together, she was found to be with child through the Holy Spirit.

19 Joseph, chagrined but noble, determined to take care of things quietly so Mary would not be disgraced.

19 Because Joseph her husband was a righteous man and did not want to expose her to public disgrace, he had in mind to divorce her quietly.

20 While he was trying to figure a way out, he had a dream. God's angel spoke in the dream: "Joseph, son of David, don't hesitate to get married. Mary's pregnancy is Spirit-conceived. God's Holy Spirit has made her pregnant.

20 But after he had considered this, an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said, "Joseph son of David, do not be afraid to take Mary home as your wife, because what is conceived in her is from the Holy Spirit.

21 She will bring a son to birth, and when she does, you, Joseph, will name him Jesus--'God saves'--because he will save his people from their sins."

21 She will give birth to a son, and you are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins."

22 This would bring the prophet's embryonic sermon to full term:

22 All this took place to fulfill what the Lord had said through the prophet:

23 Watch for this--a virgin will get pregnant and bear a son; They will name him Emmanuel (Hebrew for "God is with us").

23 The virgin will be with child and will give birth to a son, and they will call him Immanuel --which means, "God with us."

24 Then Joseph woke up. He did exactly what God's angel commanded in the dream: He married Mary.

24 When Joseph woke up, he did what the angel of the Lord had commanded him and took Mary home as his wife.

25 But he did not consummate the marriage until she had the baby. He named the baby Jesus.

25 But he had no union with her until she gave birth to a son. And he gave him the name Jesus.

Matthew 2

MSG

NIV

- 1 After Jesus was born in Bethlehem village, Judah territory--this was during Herod's kingship--a band of scholars arrived in Jerusalem from the East.
- 1 After Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea, during the time of King Herod, Magi from the east came to Jerusalem
- 2 They asked around, "Where can we find and pay homage to the newborn King of the Jews? We observed a star in the eastern sky that signaled his birth. We're on pilgrimage to worship him."
- 2 and asked, "Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? We saw his star in the east and have come to worship him."
- 3 When word of their inquiry got to Herod, he was terrified--and not Herod alone, but most of Jerusalem as well.
- 3 When King Herod heard this he was disturbed, and all Jerusalem with him.
- 4 Herod lost no time. He gathered all the high priests and religion scholars in the city together and asked, "Where is the Messiah supposed to be born?"
- 4 When he had called together all the people's chief priests and teachers of the law, he asked them where the Christ was to be born.
- 5 They told him, "Bethlehem, Judah territory. The prophet Micah wrote it plainly:
- 5 In Bethlehem in Judea, they replied, "for this is what the prophet has written:
- 6 It's you, Bethlehem, in Judah's land, no longer bringing up the rear. From you will come the leader who will shepherd-rule my people, my Israel."
- 6 'But you, Bethlehem, in the land of Judah, are by no means least among the rulers of Judah; for out of you will come a ruler who will be the shepherd of my people Israel.'
- 7 Herod then arranged a secret meeting with the scholars from the East. Pretending to be as devout as they were, he got them to tell him exactly when the birth-announcement star appeared.

- 7 Then Herod called the Magi secretly and found out from them the exact time the star had appeared.
- 8 Then he told them the prophecy about Bethlehem, and said, "Go find this child. Leave no stone unturned. As soon as you find him, send word and I'll join you at once in your worship."
- 8 He sent them to Bethlehem and said, "Go and make a careful search for the child. As soon as you find him, report to me, so that I too may go and worship him."
- 9 Instructed by the king, they set off. Then the star appeared again, the same star they had seen in the eastern skies. It led them on until it hovered over the place of the child.
- 9 After they had heard the king, they went on their way, and the star they had seen in the east went ahead of them until it stopped over the place where the child was.
- 10 They could hardly contain themselves: They were in the right place! They had arrived at the right time!
- 10 When they saw the star, they were overjoyed.
- 11 They entered the house and saw the child in the arms of Mary, his mother. Overcome, they knelt and worshiped him. Then they opened their luggage and presented gifts: gold, frankincense, myrrh.
- 11 On coming to the house, they saw the child with his mother Mary, and they bowed down and worshiped him. Then they opened their treasures and presented him with gifts of gold and of incense and of myrrh.
- 12 In a dream, they were warned not to report back to Herod. So they worked out another route, left the territory without being seen, and returned to their own country.
- 12 And having been warned in a dream not to go back to Herod, they returned to their country by another route.
- 13 After the scholars were gone, God's angel showed up again in Joseph's dream and commanded, "Get up. Take the child and his mother and flee to Egypt. Stay until further notice. Herod is on the hunt for this child, and wants to kill him."
- 13 When they had gone, an angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream. "Get up," he said, "take the child and his mother and escape to Egypt. Stay there until I tell you, for Herod is going to search for the child to kill him."

- 14 Joseph obeyed. He got up, took the child and his mother under cover of darkness. They were out of town and well on their way by daylight.
- 14 So he got up, took the child and his mother during the night and left for Egypt,
- 15 They lived in Egypt until Herod's death. This Egyptian exile fulfilled what Hosea had preached: "I called my son out of Egypt."
- 15 where he stayed until the death of Herod. And so was fulfilled what the Lord had said through the prophet: "Out of Egypt I called my son."
- 16 Herod, when he realized that the scholars had tricked him, flew into a rage. He commanded the murder of every little boy two years old and under who lived in Bethlehem and its surrounding hills. (He determined that age from information he'd gotten from the scholars.)
- 16 When Herod realized that he had been outwitted by the Magi, he was furious, and he gave orders to kill all the boys in Bethlehem and its vicinity who were two years old and under, in accordance with the time he had learned from the Magi.
- 17 That's when Jeremiah's sermon was fulfilled:
- 17 Then what was said through the prophet Jeremiah was fulfilled:
- 18 A sound was heard in Ramah, weeping and much lament. Rachel weeping for her children, Rachel refusing all solace, Her children gone, dead and buried.
- 18 A voice is heard in Ramah, weeping and great mourning, Rachel weeping for her children and refusing to be comforted, because they are no more.
- 19 Later, when Herod died, God's angel appeared in a dream to Joseph in Egypt:
- 19 After Herod died, an angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to Joseph in Egypt
- 20 "Up, take the child and his mother and return to Israel. All those out to murder the child are dead."
- 20 and said, "Get up, take the child and his mother and go to the land of Israel, for those who were trying to take the child's life are dead."
- 21 Joseph obeyed. He got up, took the child and his mother, and reentered Israel.
- 21 So he got up, took the child and his mother and went to the land of Israel.

- 22 When he heard, though, that Archelaus had succeeded his father, Herod, as king in Judea, he was afraid to go there. But then Joseph was directed in a dream to go to the hills of Galilee.
- 22 But when he heard that Archelaus was reigning in Judea in place of his father Herod, he was afraid to go there. Having been warned in a dream, he withdrew to the district of Galilee,
- 23 On arrival, he settled in the village of Nazareth. This move was a fulfillment of the prophetic words, "He shall be called a Nazarene."
- 23 and he went and lived in a town called Nazareth. So was fulfilled what was said through the prophets: "He will be called a Nazarene."

Matthew 3

MSG

NIV

- 1 While Jesus was living in the Galilean hills, John, called "the Baptizer," was preaching in the desert country of Judea.
- 1 In those days John the Baptist came, preaching in the Desert of Judea
- 2 His message was simple and austere, like his desert surroundings: "Change your life. God's kingdom is here."
- 2 and saying, "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near."
- 3 John and his message were authorized by Isaiah's prophecy: Thunder in the desert! Prepare for God's arrival! Make the road smooth and straight!
- 3 This is he who was spoken of through the prophet Isaiah: "A voice of one calling in the desert, 'Prepare the way for the Lord, make straight paths for him.' "
- 4 John dressed in a camel-hair habit tied at the waist by a leather strap. He lived on a diet of locusts and wild field honey.
- 4 John's clothes were made of camel's hair, and he had a leather belt around his waist. His food was locusts and wild honey.
- 5 People poured out of Jerusalem, Judea, and the Jordanian countryside to hear and see him in action.
- 5 People went out to him from Jerusalem and all Judea and the whole region of the Jordan.
- 6 There at the Jordan River those who came to confess their sins were baptized into a changed life.

- 6 Confessing their sins, they were baptized by him in the Jordan River.
- 7 When John realized that a lot of Pharisees and Sadducees were showing up for a baptismal experience because it was becoming the popular thing to do, he exploded: "Brood of snakes! What do you think you're doing slithering down here to the river? Do you think a little water on your snakeskins is going to make any difference?"
- 7 But when he saw many of the Pharisees and Sadducees coming to where he was baptizing, he said to them: "You brood of vipers! Who warned you to flee from the coming wrath?"
- 8 It's your life that must change, not your skin!
- 8 Produce fruit in keeping with repentance.
- 9 And don't think you can pull rank by claiming Abraham as father. Being a descendant of Abraham is neither here nor there. Descendants of Abraham are a dime a dozen.
- 9 And do not think you can say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father.' I tell you that out of these stones God can raise up children for Abraham.
- 10 What counts is your life. Is it green and blossoming? Because if it's deadwood, it goes on the fire.
- 10 The ax is already at the root of the trees, and every tree that does not produce good fruit will be cut down and thrown into the fire.
- 11 "I'm baptizing you here in the river, turning your old life in for a kingdom life. The real action comes next: The main character in this drama--compared to him I'm a mere stagehand--will ignite the kingdom life within you, a fire within you, the Holy Spirit within you, changing you from the inside out.
- 11 I baptize you with water for repentance. But after me will come one who is more powerful than I, whose sandals I am not fit to carry. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and with fire.
- 12 He's going to clean house--make a clean sweep of your lives. He'll place everything true in its proper place before God; everything false he'll put out with the trash to be burned."
- 12 His winnowing fork is in his hand, and he will clear his threshing floor, gathering his wheat into the barn and burning up the chaff with unquenchable fire."

- 13 Jesus then appeared, arriving at the Jordan River from Galilee. He wanted John to baptize him.
- 13 Then Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan to be baptized by John.
- 14 John objected, "I'm the one who needs to be baptized, not you!"
- 14 But John tried to deter him, saying, "I need to be baptized by you, and do you come to me?"
- 15 But Jesus insisted. "Do it. God's work, putting things right all these centuries, is coming together right now in this baptism." So John did it.
- 15 Jesus replied, "Let it be so now; it is proper for us to do this to fulfill all righteousness." Then John consented.
- 16 The moment Jesus came up out of the baptismal waters, the skies opened up and he saw God's Spirit--it looked like a dove--descending and landing on him.
- 16 As soon as Jesus was baptized, he went up out of the water. At that moment heaven was opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and lighting on him.
- 17 And along with the Spirit, a voice: "This is my Son, chosen and marked by my love, delight of my life."
- 17 And a voice from heaven said, "This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased."

Matthew 4

MSG

NIV

- 1 Next Jesus was taken into the wild by the Spirit for the Test. The Devil was ready to give it.
- 1 Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the desert to be tempted by the devil.
- 2 Jesus prepared for the Test by fasting forty days and forty nights. That left him, of course, in a state of extreme hunger,
- 2 After fasting forty days and forty nights, he was hungry.
- 3 which the Devil took advantage of in the first test: "Since you are God's Son, speak the word that will turn these stones into loaves of bread."
- 3 The tempter came to him and said, "If you are the Son of God, tell these stones to become bread."

- 4 Jesus answered by quoting Deuteronomy: "It takes more than bread to stay alive. It takes a steady stream of words from God's mouth."
- 4 Jesus answered, "It is written: 'Man does not live on bread alone, but on every word that comes from the mouth of God.' "
- 5 For the second test the Devil took him to the Holy City. He sat him on top of the Temple and said,
- 5 Then the devil took him to the holy city and had him stand on the highest point of the temple.
- 6 "Since you are God's Son, jump." The Devil goaded him by quoting Psalm 91: "He has placed you in the care of angels. They will catch you so that you won't so much as stub your toe on a stone."
- 6 If you are the Son of God, he said, "throw yourself down. For it is written: " 'He will command his angels concerning you, and they will lift you up in their hands, so that you will not strike your foot against a stone.' "
- 7 Jesus countered with another citation from Deuteronomy: "Don't you dare test the Lord your God."
- 7 Jesus answered him, "It is also written: 'Do not put the Lord your God to the test.' "
- 8 For the third test, the Devil took him on the peak of a huge mountain. He gestured expansively, pointing out all the earth's kingdoms, how glorious they all were.
- 8 Again, the devil took him to a very high mountain and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor.
- 9 Then he said, "They're yours--lock, stock, and barrel. Just go down on your knees and worship me, and they're yours."
- 9 All this I will give you, he said, "if you will bow down and worship me."
- 10 Jesus' refusal was curt: "Beat it, Satan!" He backed his rebuke with a third quotation from Deuteronomy: "Worship the Lord your God, and only him. Serve him with absolute single-heartedness."
- 10 Jesus said to him, "Away from me, Satan! For it is written: 'Worship the Lord your God, and serve him only.' "
- 11 The Test was over. The Devil left. And in his place, angels! Angels came and took care of Jesus' needs.
- 11 Then the devil left him, and angels came and attended him.

- 12 When Jesus got word that John had been arrested, he returned to Galilee.
- 12 When Jesus heard that John had been put in prison, he returned to Galilee.
- 13 He moved from his hometown, Nazareth, to the lakeside village Capernaum, nestled at the base of the Zebulun and Naphtali hills.
- 13 Leaving Nazareth, he went and lived in Capernaum, which was by the lake in the area of Zebulun and Naphtali--
- 14 This move completed Isaiah's sermon:
- 14 to fulfill what was said through the prophet Isaiah:
- 15 Land of Zebulun, land of Naphtali, road to the sea, over Jordan, Galilee, crossroads for the nations.
- 15 Land of Zebulun and land of Naphtali, the way to the sea, along the Jordan, Galilee of the Gentiles--
- 16 People sitting out their lives in the dark saw a huge light; Sitting in that dark, dark country of death, they watched the sun come up.
- 16 the people living in darkness have seen a great light; on those living in the land of the shadow of death a light has dawned."
- 17 This Isaiah-propheesied sermon came to life in Galilee the moment Jesus started preaching. He picked up where John left off: "Change your life. God's kingdom is here."
- 17 From that time on Jesus began to preach, "Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is near."
- 18 Walking along the beach of Lake Galilee, Jesus saw two brothers: Simon (later called Peter) and Andrew. They were fishing, throwing their nets into the lake. It was their regular work.
- 18 As Jesus was walking beside the Sea of Galilee, he saw two brothers, Simon called Peter and his brother Andrew. They were casting a net into the lake, for they were fishermen.
- 19 Jesus said to them, "Come with me. I'll make a new kind of fisherman out of you. I'll show you how to catch men and women instead of perch and bass."
- 19 Come, follow me, Jesus said, "and I will make you fishers of men."
- 20 They didn't ask questions, but simply dropped their nets and followed.
- 20 At once they left their nets and followed him.

- 21 A short distance down the beach they came upon another pair of brothers, James and John, Zebedee's sons. These two were sitting in a boat with their father, Zebedee, mending their fishnets. Jesus made the same offer to them,
- 21 Going on from there, he saw two other brothers, James son of Zebedee and his brother John. They were in a boat with their father Zebedee, preparing their nets. Jesus called them,
- 22 and they were just as quick to follow, abandoning boat and father.
- 22 and immediately they left the boat and their father and followed him.
- 23 From there he went all over Galilee. He used synagogues for meeting places and taught people the truth of God. God's kingdom was his theme--that beginning right now they were under God's government, a good government! He also healed people of their diseases and of the bad effects of their bad lives.
- 23 Jesus went throughout Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, preaching the good news of the kingdom, and healing every disease and sickness among the people.
- 24 Word got around the entire Roman province of Syria. People brought anybody with an ailment, whether mental, emotional, or physical. Jesus healed them, one and all.
- 24 News about him spread all over Syria, and people brought to him all who were ill with various diseases, those suffering severe pain, the demon-possessed, those having seizures, and the paralyzed, and he healed them.
- 25 More and more people came, the momentum gathering. Besides those from Galilee, crowds came from the "Ten Towns" across the lake, others up from Jerusalem and Judea, still others from across the Jordan.
- 25 Large crowds from Galilee, the Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judea and the region across the Jordan followed him.

Matthew 5

MSG

NIV

- 1 When Jesus saw his ministry drawing huge crowds, he climbed a hillside. Those who were apprenticed to him, the committed, climbed with him.

Arriving at a quiet place, he sat down

- 1 Now when he saw the crowds, he went up on a mountainside and sat down. His disciples came to him,
- 2 and taught his climbing companions. This is what he said:
- 2 and he began to teach them, saying:
- 3 "You're blessed when you're at the end of your rope. With less of you there is more of God and his rule.
- 3 Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.
- 4 "You're blessed when you feel you've lost what is most dear to you. Only then can you be embraced by the One most dear to you.
- 4 Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.
- 5 "You're blessed when you're content with just who you are--no more, no less. That's the moment you find yourselves proud owners of everything that can't be bought.
- 5 Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth.
- 6 "You're blessed when you've worked up a good appetite for God. He's food and drink in the best meal you'll ever eat.
- 6 Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be filled.
- 7 "You're blessed when you care. At the moment of being 'carefull,' you find yourselves cared for.
- 7 Blessed are the merciful, for they will be shown mercy.
- 8 "You're blessed when you get your inside world--your mind and heart--put right. Then you can see God in the outside world.
- 8 Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.
- 9 "You're blessed when you can show people how to cooperate instead of compete or fight. That's when you discover who you really are, and your place in God's family.
- 9 Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called sons of God.
- 10 "You're blessed when your commitment to God provokes persecution. The persecution drives you even deeper into God's kingdom.
- 10 Blessed are those who are persecuted because of righteousness, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.
- 11 "Not only that--count yourselves blessed every time people put you down or throw you out or speak lies about you to discredit me. What it

means is that the truth is too close for comfort and they are uncomfortable.

- 11 Blessed are you when people insult you, persecute you and falsely say all kinds of evil against you because of me.
- 12 You can be glad when that happens--give a cheer, even!--for though they don't like it, I do! And all heaven applauds. And know that you are in good company. My prophets and witnesses have always gotten into this kind of trouble.
- 12 Rejoice and be glad, because great is your reward in heaven, for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.
- 13 "Let me tell you why you are here. You're here to be salt-seasoning that brings out the God-flavors of this earth. If you lose your saltiness, how will people taste godliness? You've lost your usefulness and will end up in the garbage.
- 13 You are the salt of the earth. But if the salt loses its saltiness, how can it be made salty again? It is no longer good for anything, except to be thrown out and trampled by men.
- 14 "Here's another way to put it: You're here to be light, bringing out the God-colors in the world. God is not a secret to be kept. We're going public with this, as public as a city on a hill.
- 14 You are the light of the world. A city on a hill cannot be hidden.
- 15 If I make you light-bearers, you don't think I'm going to hide you under a bucket, do you? I'm putting you on a light stand.
- 15 Neither do people light a lamp and put it under a bowl. Instead they put it on its stand, and it gives light to everyone in the house.
- 16 Now that I've put you there on a hilltop, on a light stand--shine! Keep open house; be generous with your lives. By opening up to others, you'll prompt people to open up with God, this generous Father in heaven.
- 16 In the same way, let your light shine before men, that they may see your good deeds and praise your Father in heaven.
- 17 "Don't suppose for a minute that I have come to demolish the Scriptures--either God's Law or the Prophets. I'm not here to demolish but to complete. I am going to put it all together, pull it all together in a vast panorama.
- 17 Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets; I have not come to abolish them but to fulfill them.

- 18 God's Law is more real and lasting than the stars in the sky and the ground at your feet. Long after stars burn out and earth wears out, God's Law will be alive and working.
- 18 I tell you the truth, until heaven and earth disappear, not the smallest letter, not the least stroke of a pen, will by any means disappear from the Law until everything is accomplished.
- 19 "Trivialize even the smallest item in God's Law and you will only have trivialized yourself. But take it seriously, show the way for others, and you will find honor in the kingdom.
- 19 Anyone who breaks one of the least of these commandments and teaches others to do the same will be called least in the kingdom of heaven, but whoever practices and teaches these commands will be called great in the kingdom of heaven.
- 20 Unless you do far better than the Pharisees in the matters of right living, you won't know the first thing about entering the kingdom.
- 20 For I tell you that unless your righteousness surpasses that of the Pharisees and the teachers of the law, you will certainly not enter the kingdom of heaven.
- 21 "You're familiar with the command to the ancients, 'Do not murder.'
- 21 You have heard that it was said to the people long ago, 'Do not murder, and anyone who murders will be subject to judgment.'
- 22 I'm telling you that anyone who is so much as angry with a brother or sister is guilty of murder. Carelessly call a brother 'idiot!' and you just might find yourself hauled into court. Thoughtlessly yell 'stupid!' at a sister and you are on the brink of hellfire. The simple moral fact is that words kill.
- 22 But I tell you that anyone who is angry with his brother will be subject to judgment. Again, anyone who says to his brother, 'Raca, ' is answerable to the Sanhedrin. But anyone who says, 'You fool!' will be in danger of the fire of hell.
- 23 "This is how I want you to conduct yourself in these matters. If you enter your place of worship and, about to make an offering, you suddenly remember a grudge a friend has against you,
- 23 Therefore, if you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you,

- 24 abandon your offering, leave immediately, go to this friend and make things right. Then and only then, come back and work things out with God.
- 24 leave your gift there in front of the altar. First go and be reconciled to your brother; then come and offer your gift.
- 25 "Or say you're out on the street and an old enemy accosts you. Don't lose a minute. Make the first move; make things right with him. After all, if you leave the first move to him, knowing his track record, you're likely to end up in court, maybe even jail.
- 25 Settle matters quickly with your adversary who is taking you to court. Do it while you are still with him on the way, or he may hand you over to the judge, and the judge may hand you over to the officer, and you may be thrown into prison.
- 26 If that happens, you won't get out without a stiff fine.
- 26 I tell you the truth, you will not get out until you have paid the last penny.
- 27 "You know the next commandment pretty well, too: 'Don't go to bed with another's spouse.'
- 27 You have heard that it was said, 'Do not commit adultery.'
- 28 But don't think you've preserved your virtue simply by staying out of bed. Your heart can be corrupted by lust even quicker than your body. Those leering looks you think nobody notices--they also corrupt.
- 28 But I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart.
- 29 "Let's not pretend this is easier than it really is. If you want to live a morally pure life, here's what you have to do: You have to blind your right eye the moment you catch it in a lustful leer. You have to choose to live one-eyed or else be dumped on a moral trash pile.
- 29 If your right eye causes you to sin, gouge it out and throw it away. It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to be thrown into hell.
- 30 And you have to chop off your right hand the moment you notice it raised threateningly. Better a bloody stump than your entire being discarded for good in the dump.
- 30 And if your right hand causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away. It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body

to go into hell.

31 "Remember the Scripture that says, 'Whoever divorces his wife, let him do it legally, giving her divorce papers and her legal rights'?

31 It has been said, 'Anyone who divorces his wife must give her a certificate of divorce.'

32 Too many of you are using that as a cover for selfishness and whim, pretending to be righteous just because you are 'legal.' Please, no more pretending. If you divorce your wife, you're responsible for making her an adulteress (unless she has already made herself that by sexual promiscuity). And if you marry such a divorced adulteress, you're automatically an adulterer yourself. You can't use legal cover to mask a moral failure.

32 But I tell you that anyone who divorces his wife, except for marital unfaithfulness, causes her to become an adulteress, and anyone who marries the divorced woman commits adultery.

33 "And don't say anything you don't mean. This counsel is embedded deep in our traditions.

33 Again, you have heard that it was said to the people long ago, 'Do not break your oath, but keep the oaths you have made to the Lord.'

34 You only make things worse when you lay down a smoke screen of pious talk, saying, 'I'll pray for you,' and never doing it, or saying, 'God be with you,' and not meaning it. You don't make your words true by embellishing them with religious lace. In making your speech sound more religious, it becomes less true.

34 But I tell you, Do not swear at all: either by heaven, for it is God's throne;

35 (SEE 5:34)

35 or by the earth, for it is his footstool; or by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the Great King.

36 (SEE 5:34)

36 And do not swear by your head, for you cannot make even one hair white or black.

37 Just say 'yes' and 'no.' When you manipulate words to get your own way, you go wrong.

37 Simply let your 'Yes' be 'Yes,' and your 'No,' 'No'; anything beyond this comes from the evil one.

- 38 "Here's another old saying that deserves a second look: 'Eye for eye, tooth for tooth.'
- 38 You have heard that it was said, 'Eye for eye, and tooth for tooth.'
- 39 Is that going to get us anywhere? Here's what I propose: 'Don't hit back at all.' If someone strikes you, stand there and take it.
- 39 But I tell you, Do not resist an evil person. If someone strikes you on the right cheek, turn to him the other also.
- 40 If someone drags you into court and sues for the shirt off your back, giftwrap your best coat and make a present of it.
- 40 And if someone wants to sue you and take your tunic, let him have your cloak as well.
- 41 And if someone takes unfair advantage of you, use the occasion to practice the servant life.
- 41 If someone forces you to go one mile, go with him two miles.
- 42 No more tit-for-tat stuff. Live generously.
- 42 Give to the one who asks you, and do not turn away from the one who wants to borrow from you.
- 43 "You're familiar with the old written law, 'Love your friend,' and its unwritten companion, 'Hate your enemy.'
- 43 You have heard that it was said, 'Love your neighbor and hate your enemy.'
- 44 I'm challenging that. I'm telling you to love your enemies. Let them bring out the best in you, not the worst. When someone gives you a hard time, respond with the energies of prayer,
- 44 But I tell you: Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,
- 45 for then you are working out of your true selves, your God-created selves. This is what God does. He gives his best--the sun to warm and the rain to nourish--to everyone, regardless: the good and bad, the nice and nasty.
- 45 that you may be sons of your Father in heaven. He causes his sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous.
- 46 If all you do is love the lovable, do you expect a bonus? Anybody can do that.
- 46 If you love those who love you, what reward will you get? Are not even the tax collectors doing that?

- 47 If you simply say hello to those who greet you, do you expect a medal?
Any run-of-the-mill sinner does that.
- 47 And if you greet only your brothers, what are you doing more than
others? Do not even pagans do that?
- 48 "In a word, what I'm saying is, Grow up. You're kingdom subjects. Now
live like it. Live out your God-created identity. Live generously and
graciously toward others, the way God lives toward you.
- 48 Be perfect, therefore, as your heavenly Father is perfect.

Matthew 6

MSG

NIV

- 1 "Be especially careful when you are trying to be good so that you don't
make a performance out of it. It might be good theater, but the God who
made you won't be applauding.
- 1 Be careful not to do your 'acts of righteousness' before men, to be seen by
them. If you do, you will have no reward from your Father in heaven.
- 2 "When you do something for someone else, don't call attention to
yourself. You've seen them in action, I'm sure--'playactors' I call them--
treating prayer meeting and street corner alike as a stage, acting
compassionate as long as someone is watching, playing to the crowds.
They get applause, true, but that's all they get.
- 2 So when you give to the needy, do not announce it with trumpets, as the
hypocrites do in the synagogues and on the streets, to be honored by
men. I tell you the truth, they have received their reward in full.
- 3 When you help someone out, don't think about how it looks.
- 3 But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what
your right hand is doing,
- 4 Just do it--quietly and unobtrusively. That is the way your God, who
conceived you in love, working behind the scenes, helps you out.
- 4 so that your giving may be in secret. Then your Father, who sees what is
done in secret, will reward you.
- 5 "And when you come before God, don't turn that into a theatrical
production either. All these people making a regular show out of their
prayers, hoping for stardom! Do you think God sits in a box seat?

- 5 And when you pray, do not be like the hypocrites, for they love to pray standing in the synagogues and on the street corners to be seen by men. I tell you the truth, they have received their reward in full.
- 6 "Here's what I want you to do: Find a quiet, secluded place so you won't be tempted to role-play before God. Just be there as simply and honestly as you can manage. The focus will shift from you to God, and you will begin to sense his grace.
- 6 But when you pray, go into your room, close the door and pray to your Father, who is unseen. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.
- 7 "The world is full of so-called prayer warriors who are prayer-ignorant. They're full of formulas and programs and advice, peddling techniques for getting what you want from God.
- 7 And when you pray, do not keep on babbling like pagans, for they think they will be heard because of their many words.
- 8 Don't fall for that nonsense. This is your Father you are dealing with, and he knows better than you what you need.
- 8 Do not be like them, for your Father knows what you need before you ask him.
- 9 With a God like this loving you, you can pray very simply. Like this: Our Father in heaven, Reveal who you are.
- 9 This, then, is how you should pray: 'Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name,
- 10 Set the world right; Do what's best-- as above, so below.
- 10 your kingdom come, your will be done on earth as it is in heaven.
- 11 Keep us alive with three square meals.
- 11 Give us today our daily bread.
- 12 Keep us forgiven with you and forgiving others.
- 12 Forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors.
- 13 Keep us safe from ourselves and the Devil. You're in charge! You can do anything you want! You're ablaze in beauty! Yes. Yes. Yes.
- 13 And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one. '
- 14 "In prayer there is a connection between what God does and what you do. You can't get forgiveness from God, for instance, without also forgiving others.

- 14 For if you forgive men when they sin against you, your heavenly Father will also forgive you.
- 15 If you refuse to do your part, you cut yourself off from God's part.
- 15 But if you do not forgive men their sins, your Father will not forgive your sins.
- 16 "When you practice some appetite-denying discipline to better concentrate on God, don't make a production out of it. It might turn you into a small-time celebrity but it won't make you a saint.
- 16 When you fast, do not look somber as the hypocrites do, for they disfigure their faces to show men they are fasting. I tell you the truth, they have received their reward in full.
- 17 If you 'go into training' inwardly, act normal outwardly. Shampoo and comb your hair, brush your teeth, wash your face.
- 17 But when you fast, put oil on your head and wash your face,
- 18 God doesn't require attention-getting devices. He won't overlook what you are doing; he'll reward you well.
- 18 so that it will not be obvious to men that you are fasting, but only to your Father, who is unseen; and your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.
- 19 "Don't hoard treasure down here where it gets eaten by moths and corroded by rust or--worse!--stolen by burglars.
- 19 Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy, and where thieves break in and steal.
- 20 Stockpile treasure in heaven, where it's safe from moth and rust and burglars.
- 20 But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moth and rust do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal.
- 21 It's obvious, isn't it? The place where your treasure is, is the place you will most want to be, and end up being.
- 21 For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.
- 22 "Your eyes are windows into your body. If you open your eyes wide in wonder and belief, your body fills up with light.
- 22 The eye is the lamp of the body. If your eyes are good, your whole body will be full of light.
- 23 If you live squinty-eyed in greed and distrust, your body is a dank cellar. If you pull the blinds on your windows, what a dark life you will have!

- 23 But if your eyes are bad, your whole body will be full of darkness. If then the light within you is darkness, how great is that darkness!
- 24 "You can't worship two gods at once. Loving one god, you'll end up hating the other. Adoration of one feeds contempt for the other. You can't worship God and Money both.
- 24 No one can serve two masters. Either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve both God and Money.
- 25 "If you decide for God, living a life of God-worship, it follows that you don't fuss about what's on the table at mealtimes or whether the clothes in your closet are in fashion. There is far more to your life than the food you put in your stomach, more to your outer appearance than the clothes you hang on your body.
- 25 Therefore I tell you, do not worry about your life, what you will eat or drink; or about your body, what you will wear. Is not life more important than food, and the body more important than clothes?
- 26 Look at the birds, free and unfettered, not tied down to a job description, careless in the care of God. And you count far more to him than birds.
- 26 Look at the birds of the air; they do not sow or reap or store away in barns, and yet your heavenly Father feeds them. Are you not much more valuable than they?
- 27 "Has anyone by fussing in front of the mirror ever gotten taller by so much as an inch?
- 27 Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?
- 28 All this time and money wasted on fashion--do you think it makes that much difference? Instead of looking at the fashions, walk out into the fields and look at the wildflowers. They never primp or shop,
- 28 And why do you worry about clothes? See how the lilies of the field grow. They do not labor or spin.
- 29 but have you ever seen color and design quite like it? The ten best-dressed men and women in the country look shabby alongside them.
- 29 Yet I tell you that not even Solomon in all his splendor was dressed like one of these.
- 30 "If God gives such attention to the appearance of wildflowers--most of which are never even seen--don't you think he'll attend to you, take pride

- in you, do his best for you?
- 30 If that is how God clothes the grass of the field, which is here today and tomorrow is thrown into the fire, will he not much more clothe you, O you of little faith?
- 31 What I'm trying to do here is to get you to relax, to not be so preoccupied with getting, so you can respond to God's giving.
- 31 So do not worry, saying, 'What shall we eat?' or 'What shall we drink?' or 'What shall we wear?'
- 32 People who don't know God and the way he works fuss over these things, but you know both God and how he works.
- 32 For the pagans run after all these things, and your heavenly Father knows that you need them.
- 33 Steep your life in God-reality, God-initiative, God-provisions. Don't worry about missing out. You'll find all your everyday human concerns will be met.
- 33 But seek first his kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well.
- 34 "Give your entire attention to what God is doing right now, and don't get worked up about what may or may not happen tomorrow. God will help you deal with whatever hard things come up when the time comes.
- 34 Therefore do not worry about tomorrow, for tomorrow will worry about itself. Each day has enough trouble of its own.

Matthew 7

MSG

NIV

- 1 "Don't pick on people, jump on their failures, criticize their faults-- unless, of course, you want the same treatment.
- 1 Do not judge, or you too will be judged.
- 2 That critical spirit has a way of boomeranging.
- 2 For in the same way you judge others, you will be judged, and with the measure you use, it will be measured to you.
- 3 It's easy to see a smudge on your neighbor's face and be oblivious to the ugly sneer on your own.

- 3 Why do you look at the speck of sawdust in your brother's eye and pay no attention to the plank in your own eye?
- 4 Do you have the nerve to say, 'Let me wash your face for you,' when your own face is distorted by contempt?
- 4 How can you say to your brother, 'Let me take the speck out of your eye,' when all the time there is a plank in your own eye?
- 5 It's this whole traveling road-show mentality all over again, playing a holier-than-thou part instead of just living your part. Wipe that ugly sneer off your own face, and you might be fit to offer a washcloth to your neighbor.
- 5 You hypocrite, first take the plank out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to remove the speck from your brother's eye.
- 6 "Don't be flip with the sacred. Banter and silliness give no honor to God. Don't reduce holy mysteries to slogans. In trying to be relevant, you're only being cute and inviting sacrilege.
- 6 Do not give dogs what is sacred; do not throw your pearls to pigs. If you do, they may trample them under their feet, and then turn and tear you to pieces.
- 7 "Don't bargain with God. Be direct. Ask for what you need.
- 7 Ask and it will be given to you; seek and you will find; knock and the door will be opened to you.
- 8 This isn't a cat-and-mouse, hide-and-seek game we're in.
- 8 For everyone who asks receives; he who seeks finds; and to him who knocks, the door will be opened.
- 9 If your child asks for bread, do you trick him with sawdust?
- 9 Which of you, if his son asks for bread, will give him a stone?
- 10 If he asks for fish, do you scare him with a live snake on his plate?
- 10 Or if he asks for a fish, will give him a snake?
- 11 As bad as you are, you wouldn't think of such a thing. You're at least decent to your own children. So don't you think the God who conceived you in love will be even better?
- 11 If you, then, though you are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father in heaven give good gifts to those who ask him!
- 12 "Here is a simple, rule-of-thumb guide for behavior: Ask yourself what you want people to do for you, then grab the initiative and do it for them.

Add up God's Law and Prophets and this is what you get.

- 12 So in everything, do to others what you would have them do to you, for this sums up the Law and the Prophets.
- 13 "Don't look for shortcuts to God. The market is flooded with surefire, easygoing formulas for a successful life that can be practiced in your spare time. Don't fall for that stuff, even though crowds of people do.
- 13 Enter through the narrow gate. For wide is the gate and broad is the road that leads to destruction, and many enter through it.
- 14 The way to life--to God!--is vigorous and requires total attention.
- 14 But small is the gate and narrow the road that leads to life, and only a few find it.
- 15 "Be wary of false preachers who smile a lot, dripping with practiced sincerity. Chances are they are out to rip you off some way or other. Don't be impressed with charisma; look for character.
- 15 Watch out for false prophets. They come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ferocious wolves.
- 16 Who preachers are is the main thing, not what they say. A genuine leader will never exploit your emotions or your pocketbook. These diseased trees with their bad apples are going to be chopped down and burned.
- 16 By their fruit you will recognize them. Do people pick grapes from thornbushes, or figs from thistles?
- 17 (SEE 7:16)
- 17 Likewise every good tree bears good fruit, but a bad tree bears bad fruit.
- 18 (SEE 7:16)
- 18 A good tree cannot bear bad fruit, and a bad tree cannot bear good fruit.
- 19 (SEE 7:16)
- 19 Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire.
- 20 (SEE 7:16)
- 20 Thus, by their fruit you will recognize them.
- 21 "Knowing the correct password--saying 'Master, Master,' for instance--isn't going to get you anywhere with me. What is required is serious obedience--doing what my Father wills.
- 21 Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter the kingdom of heaven, but only he who does the will of my Father who is in heaven.

- 22 I can see it now--at the Final Judgment thousands strutting up to me and saying, 'Master, we preached the Message, we bashed the demons, our God-sponsored projects had everyone talking.'
- 22 Many will say to me on that day, 'Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name, and in your name drive out demons and perform many miracles?'
- 23 And do you know what I am going to say? 'You missed the boat. All you did was use me to make yourselves important. You don't impress me one bit. You're out of here.'
- 23 Then I will tell them plainly, 'I never knew you. Away from me, you evildoers!'
- 24 "These words I speak to you are not incidental additions to your life, homeowner improvements to your standard of living. They are foundational words, words to build a life on. If you work these words into your life, you are like a smart carpenter who built his house on solid rock.
- 24 Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock.
- 25 Rain poured down, the river flooded, a tornado hit--but nothing moved that house. It was fixed to the rock.
- 25 The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house; yet it did not fall, because it had its foundation on the rock.
- 26 "But if you just use my words in Bible studies and don't work them into your life, you are like a stupid carpenter who built his house on the sandy beach.
- 26 But everyone who hears these words of mine and does not put them into practice is like a foolish man who built his house on sand.
- 27 When a storm rolled in and the waves came up, it collapsed like a house of cards."
- 27 The rain came down, the streams rose, and the winds blew and beat against that house, and it fell with a great crash."
- 28 When Jesus concluded his address, the crowd burst into applause. They had never heard teaching like this.
- 28 When Jesus had finished saying these things, the crowds were amazed at his teaching,

29 It was apparent that he was living everything he was saying--quite a contrast to their religion teachers! This was the best teaching they had ever heard.

29 because he taught as one who had authority, and not as their teachers of the law.

Matthew 8

MSG

NIV

1 Jesus came down the mountain with the cheers of the crowd still ringing in his ears.

1 When he came down from the mountainside, large crowds followed him.

2 Then a leper appeared and went to his knees before Jesus, praying, "Master, if you want to, you can heal my body."

2 A man with leprosy came and knelt before him and said, "Lord, if you are willing, you can make me clean."

3 Jesus reached out and touched him, saying, "I want to. Be clean." Then and there, all signs of the leprosy were gone.

3 Jesus reached out his hand and touched the man. "I am willing," he said. "Be clean!" Immediately he was cured of his leprosy.

4 Jesus said, "Don't talk about this all over town. Just quietly present your healed body to the priest, along with the appropriate expressions of thanks to God. Your cleansed and grateful life, not your words, will bear witness to what I have done."

4 Then Jesus said to him, "See that you don't tell anyone. But go, show yourself to the priest and offer the gift Moses commanded, as a testimony to them."

5 As Jesus entered the village of Capernaum, a Roman captain came up in a panic and said,

5 When Jesus had entered Capernaum, a centurion came to him, asking for help.

6 "Master, my servant is sick. He can't walk. He's in terrible pain."

6 Lord, he said, "my servant lies at home paralyzed and in terrible suffering."

7 Jesus said, "I'll come and heal him."

- 7 Jesus said to him, "I will go and heal him."
- 8 "Oh, no," said the captain. "I don't want to put you to all that trouble. Just give the order and my servant will be fine."
- 8 The centurion replied, "Lord, I do not deserve to have you come under my roof. But just say the word, and my servant will be healed."
- 9 I'm a man who takes orders and gives orders. I tell one soldier, 'Go,' and he goes; to another, 'Come,' and he comes; to my slave, 'Do this,' and he does it."
- 9 For I myself am a man under authority, with soldiers under me. I tell this one, 'Go,' and he goes; and that one, 'Come,' and he comes. I say to my servant, 'Do this,' and he does it."
- 10 Taken aback, Jesus said, "I've yet to come across this kind of simple trust in Israel, the very people who are supposed to know all about God and how he works."
- 10 When Jesus heard this, he was astonished and said to those following him, "I tell you the truth, I have not found anyone in Israel with such great faith."
- 11 This man is the vanguard of many outsiders who will soon be coming from all directions--streaming in from the east, pouring in from the west, sitting down at God's kingdom banquet alongside Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob."
- 11 I say to you that many will come from the east and the west, and will take their places at the feast with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven."
- 12 Then those who grew up 'in the faith' but had no faith will find themselves out in the cold, outsiders to grace and wondering what happened."
- 12 But the subjects of the kingdom will be thrown outside, into the darkness, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth."
- 13 Then Jesus turned to the captain and said, "Go. What you believed could happen has happened." At that moment his servant became well."
- 13 Then Jesus said to the centurion, "Go! It will be done just as you believed it would." And his servant was healed at that very hour."
- 14 By this time they were in front of Peter's house. On entering, Jesus found Peter's mother-in-law sick in bed, burning up with fever."

- 14 When Jesus came into Peter's house, he saw Peter's mother-in-law lying in bed with a fever.
- 15 He touched her hand and the fever was gone. No sooner was she up on her feet than she was fixing dinner for him.
- 15 He touched her hand and the fever left her, and she got up and began to wait on him.
- 16 That evening a lot of demon-afflicted people were brought to him. He relieved the inwardly tormented. He cured the bodily ill.
- 16 When evening came, many who were demon-possessed were brought to him, and he drove out the spirits with a word and healed all the sick.
- 17 He fulfilled Isaiah's well-known sermon: He took our illnesses, He carried our diseases.
- 17 This was to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah: "He took up our infirmities and carried our diseases."
- 18 When Jesus saw that a curious crowd was growing by the minute, he told his disciples to get him out of there to the other side of the lake.
- 18 When Jesus saw the crowd around him, he gave orders to cross to the other side of the lake.
- 19 As they left, a religion scholar asked if he could go along. "I'll go with you, wherever," he said.
- 19 Then a teacher of the law came to him and said, "Teacher, I will follow you wherever you go."
- 20 Jesus was curt: "Are you ready to rough it? We're not staying in the best inns, you know."
- 20 Jesus replied, "Foxes have holes and birds of the air have nests, but the Son of Man has no place to lay his head."
- 21 Another follower said, "Master, excuse me for a couple of days, please. I have my father's funeral to take care of."
- 21 Another disciple said to him, "Lord, first let me go and bury my father."
- 22 Jesus refused. "First things first. Your business is life, not death. Follow me. Pursue life."
- 22 But Jesus told him, "Follow me, and let the dead bury their own dead."
- 23 Then he got in the boat, his disciples with him.
- 23 Then he got into the boat and his disciples followed him.
- 24 The next thing they knew, they were in a severe storm. Waves were crashing into the boat--and he was sound asleep!

24 Without warning, a furious storm came up on the lake, so that the waves swept over the boat. But Jesus was sleeping.

25 They roused him, pleading, "Master, save us! We're going down!"

25 The disciples went and woke him, saying, "Lord, save us! We're going to drown!"

26 Jesus reprimanded them. "Why are you such cowards, such faint-hearts?" Then he stood up and told the wind to be silent, the sea to quiet down: "Silence!" The sea became smooth as glass.

26 He replied, "You of little faith, why are you so afraid?" Then he got up and rebuked the winds and the waves, and it was completely calm.

27 The men rubbed their eyes, astonished. "What's going on here? Wind and sea come to heel at his command!"

27 The men were amazed and asked, "What kind of man is this? Even the winds and the waves obey him!"

28 They landed in the country of the Gadarenes and were met by two madmen, victims of demons, coming out of the cemetery. The men had terrorized the region for so long that no one considered it safe to walk down that stretch of road anymore.

28 When he arrived at the other side in the region of the Gadarenes, two demon-possessed men coming from the tombs met him. They were so violent that no one could pass that way.

29 Seeing Jesus, the madmen screamed out, "What business do you have giving us a hard time? You're the Son of God! You weren't supposed to show up here yet!"

29 What do you want with us, Son of God? they shouted. "Have you come here to torture us before the appointed time?"

30 Off in the distance a herd of pigs was browsing and rooting.

30 Some distance from them a large herd of pigs was feeding.

31 The evil spirits begged Jesus, "If you kick us out of these men, let us live in the pigs."

31 The demons begged Jesus, "If you drive us out, send us into the herd of pigs."

32 Jesus said, "Go ahead, but get out of here!" Crazy, the pigs stampeded over a cliff into the sea and drowned.

32 He said to them, "Go!" So they came out and went into the pigs, and the whole herd rushed down the steep bank into the lake and died in the

water.

33 Scared to death, the swineherds bolted. They told everyone back in town what had happened to the madmen and the pigs.

33 Those tending the pigs ran off, went into the town and reported all this, including what had happened to the demon- possessed men.

34 Those who heard about it were angry about the drowned pigs. A mob formed and demanded that Jesus get out and not come back.

34 Then the whole town went out to meet Jesus. And when they saw him, they pleaded with him to leave their region.

Matthew 9

MSG

NIV

1 Back in the boat, Jesus and the disciples recrossed the sea to Jesus' hometown.

1 Jesus stepped into a boat, crossed over and came to his own town.

2 They were hardly out of the boat when some men carried a paraplegic on a stretcher and set him down in front of them. Jesus, impressed by their bold belief, said to the paraplegic, "Cheer up, son. I forgive your sins."

2 Some men brought to him a paralytic, lying on a mat. When Jesus saw their faith, he said to the paralytic, "Take heart, son; your sins are forgiven."

3 Some religion scholars whispered, "Why, that's blasphemy!"

3 At this, some of the teachers of the law said to themselves, "This fellow is blaspheming!"

4 Jesus knew what they were thinking, and said, "Why this gossiping whispering?"

4 Knowing their thoughts, Jesus said, "Why do you entertain evil thoughts in your hearts?"

5 Which do you think is simpler: to say, 'I forgive your sins,' or, 'Get up and walk'?

5 Which is easier: to say, 'Your sins are forgiven,' or to say, 'Get up and walk'?

6 Well, just so it's clear that I'm the Son of Man and authorized to do either, or both. . . ." At this he turned to the paraplegic and said, "Get up. Take

- your bed and go home."
- 6 But so that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins. . . ." Then he said to the paralytic, "Get up, take your mat and go home."
- 7 And the man did it.
- 7 And the man got up and went home.
- 8 The crowd was awestruck, amazed and pleased that God had authorized Jesus to work among them this way.
- 8 When the crowd saw this, they were filled with awe; and they praised God, who had given such authority to men.
- 9 Passing along, Jesus saw a man at his work collecting taxes. His name was Matthew. Jesus said, "Come along with me." Matthew stood up and followed him.
- 9 As Jesus went on from there, he saw a man named Matthew sitting at the tax collector's booth. "Follow me," he told him, and Matthew got up and followed him.
- 10 Later when Jesus was eating supper at Matthew's house with his close followers, a lot of disreputable characters came and joined them.
- 10 While Jesus was having dinner at Matthew's house, many tax collectors and "sinners" came and ate with him and his disciples.
- 11 When the Pharisees saw him keeping this kind of company, they had a fit, and lit into Jesus' followers. "What kind of example is this from your Teacher, acting cozy with crooks and riff-raff?"
- 11 When the Pharisees saw this, they asked his disciples, "Why does your teacher eat with tax collectors and 'sinners'?"
- 12 Jesus, overhearing, shot back, "Who needs a doctor: the healthy or the sick?"
- 12 On hearing this, Jesus said, "It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.
- 13 Go figure out what this Scripture means: 'I'm after mercy, not religion.' I'm here to invite outsiders, not coddle insiders."
- 13 But go and learn what this means: 'I desire mercy, not sacrifice.' For I have not come to call the righteous, but sinners."
- 14 A little later John's followers approached, asking, "Why is it that we and the Pharisees rigorously discipline body and spirit by fasting, but your followers don't?"

- 14 Then John's disciples came and asked him, "How is it that we and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples do not fast?"
- 15 Jesus told them, "When you're celebrating a wedding, you don't skimp on the cake and wine. You feast. Later you may need to pull in your belt, but not now. No one throws cold water on a friendly bonfire. This is Kingdom Come!"
- 15 Jesus answered, "How can the guests of the bridegroom mourn while he is with them? The time will come when the bridegroom will be taken from them; then they will fast.
- 16 He went on, "No one cuts up a fine silk scarf to patch old work clothes; you want fabrics that match.
- 16 No one sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment, for the patch will pull away from the garment, making the tear worse.
- 17 And you don't put your wine in cracked bottles."
- 17 Neither do men pour new wine into old wineskins. If they do, the skins will burst, the wine will run out and the wineskins will be ruined. No, they pour new wine into new wineskins, and both are preserved."
- 18 As he finished saying this, a local official appeared, bowed politely, and said, "My daughter has just now died. If you come and touch her, she will live."
- 18 While he was saying this, a ruler came and knelt before him and said, "My daughter has just died. But come and put your hand on her, and she will live."
- 19 Jesus got up and went with him, his disciples following along.
- 19 Jesus got up and went with him, and so did his disciples.
- 20 Just then a woman who had hemorrhaged for twelve years slipped in from behind and lightly touched his robe.
- 20 Just then a woman who had been subject to bleeding for twelve years came up behind him and touched the edge of his cloak.
- 21 She was thinking to herself, "If I can just put a finger on his robe, I'll get well." Jesus turned--caught her at it. Then he reassured her: "Courage, daughter. You took a risk of faith, and now you're well."
- 21 She said to herself, "If I only touch his cloak, I will be healed."
- 22 The woman was well from then on.
- 22 Jesus turned and saw her. "Take heart, daughter," he said, "your faith has healed you." And the woman was healed from that moment.

23 By now they had arrived at the house of the town official, and pushed their way through the gossips looking for a story and the neighbors bringing in casseroles.

23 When Jesus entered the ruler's house and saw the flute players and the noisy crowd,

24 Jesus was abrupt: "Clear out! This girl isn't dead. She's sleeping." They told him he didn't know what he was talking about.

24 he said, "Go away. The girl is not dead but asleep." But they laughed at him.

25 But when Jesus had gotten rid of the crowd, he went in, took the girl's hand, and pulled her to her feet--alive.

25 After the crowd had been put outside, he went in and took the girl by the hand, and she got up.

26 The news was soon out, and traveled throughout the region.

26 News of this spread through all that region.

27 As Jesus left the house, he was followed by two blind men crying out, "Mercy, Son of David! Mercy on us!"

27 As Jesus went on from there, two blind men followed him, calling out, "Have mercy on us, Son of David!"

28 When Jesus got home, the blind men went in with him. Jesus said to them, "Do you really believe I can do this?" They said, "Why, yes, Master!"

28 When he had gone indoors, the blind men came to him, and he asked them, "Do you believe that I am able to do this?" "Yes, Lord," they replied.

29 He touched their eyes and said, "Become what you believe."

29 Then he touched their eyes and said, "According to your faith will it be done to you";

30 It happened. They saw. Then Jesus became very stern. "Don't let a soul know how this happened."

30 and their sight was restored. Jesus warned them sternly, "See that no one knows about this."

31 But they were hardly out the door before they started blabbing it to everyone they met.

31 But they went out and spread the news about him all over that region.

- 32 Right after that, as the blind men were leaving, a man who had been struck speechless by an evil spirit was brought to Jesus.
- 32 While they were going out, a man who was demon-possessed and could not talk was brought to Jesus.
- 33 As soon as Jesus threw the evil tormenting spirit out, the man talked away just as if he'd been talking all his life. The people were up on their feet applauding: "There's never been anything like this in Israel!"
- 33 And when the demon was driven out, the man who had been mute spoke. The crowd was amazed and said, "Nothing like this has ever been seen in Israel."
- 34 The Pharisees were left sputtering, "Hocus pocus. It's nothing but hocus pocus. He's probably made a pact with the Devil."
- 34 But the Pharisees said, "It is by the prince of demons that he drives out demons."
- 35 Then Jesus made a circuit of all the towns and villages. He taught in their meeting places, reported kingdom news, and healed their diseased bodies, healed their bruised and hurt lives.
- 35 Jesus went through all the towns and villages, teaching in their synagogues, preaching the good news of the kingdom and healing every disease and sickness.
- 36 When he looked out over the crowds, his heart broke. So confused and aimless they were, like sheep with no shepherd.
- 36 When he saw the crowds, he had compassion on them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd.
- 37 "What a huge harvest!" he said to his disciples. "How few workers!"
- 37 Then he said to his disciples, "The harvest is plentiful but the workers are few.
- 38 On your knees and pray for harvest hands!"
- 38 Ask the Lord of the harvest, therefore, to send out workers into his harvest field."

Matthew 10

MSG

NIV

- 1 The prayer was no sooner prayed than it was answered. Jesus called twelve of his followers and sent them into the ripe fields. He gave them power to kick out the evil spirits and to tenderly care for the bruised and hurt lives.
- 1 He called his twelve disciples to him and gave them authority to drive out evil spirits and to heal every disease and sickness.
- 2 This is the list of the twelve he sent: Simon (they called him Peter, or "Rock"), Andrew, his brother, James, Zebedee's son, John, his brother,
- 2 These are the names of the twelve apostles: first, Simon (who is called Peter) and his brother Andrew; James son of Zebedee, and his brother John;
- 3 Philip, Bartholomew, Thomas, Matthew, the tax man, James, son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus,
- 3 Philip and Bartholomew; Thomas and Matthew the tax collector; James son of Alphaeus, and Thaddaeus;
- 4 Simon, the Canaanite, Judas Iscariot (who later turned on him).
- 4 Simon the Zealot and Judas Iscariot, who betrayed him.
- 5 Jesus sent his twelve harvest hands out with this charge: "Don't begin by traveling to some far-off place to convert unbelievers. And don't try to be dramatic by tackling some public enemy.
- 5 These twelve Jesus sent out with the following instructions: "Do not go among the Gentiles or enter any town of the Samaritans.
- 6 Go to the lost, confused people right here in the neighborhood.
- 6 Go rather to the lost sheep of Israel.
- 7 Tell them that the kingdom is here.
- 7 As you go, preach this message: 'The kingdom of heaven is near.'
- 8 Bring health to the sick. Raise the dead. Touch the untouchables. Kick out the demons. You have been treated generously, so live generously.
- 8 Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse those who have leprosy, drive out demons. Freely you have received, freely give.
- 9 "Don't think you have to put on a fund-raising campaign before you start.
- 9 Do not take along any gold or silver or copper in your belts;
- 10 You don't need a lot of equipment. You are the equipment, and all you need to keep that going is three meals a day. Travel light.
- 10 take no bag for the journey, or extra tunic, or sandals or a staff; for the worker is worth his keep.

- 11 "When you enter a town or village, don't insist on staying in a luxury inn. Get a modest place with some modest people, and be content there until you leave.
- 11 Whatever town or village you enter, search for some worthy person there and stay at his house until you leave.
- 12 "When you knock on a door, be courteous in your greeting.
- 12 As you enter the home, give it your greeting.
- 13 If they welcome you, be gentle in your conversation.
- 13 If the home is deserving, let your peace rest on it; if it is not, let your peace return to you.
- 14 If they don't welcome you, quietly withdraw. Don't make a scene. Shrug your shoulders and be on your way.
- 14 If anyone will not welcome you or listen to your words, shake the dust off your feet when you leave that home or town.
- 15 You can be sure that on Judgment Day they'll be mighty sorry--but it's no concern of yours now.
- 15 I tell you the truth, it will be more bearable for Sodom and Gomorrah on the day of judgment than for that town.
- 16 "Stay alert. This is hazardous work I'm assigning you. You're going to be like sheep running through a wolf pack, so don't call attention to yourselves. Be as cunning as a snake, inoffensive as a dove.
- 16 I am sending you out like sheep among wolves. Therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves.
- 17 "Don't be naive. Some people will impugn your motives, others will smear your reputation--just because you believe in me.
- 17 Be on your guard against men; they will hand you over to the local councils and flog you in their synagogues.
- 18 Don't be upset when they haul you before the civil authorities. Without knowing it, they've done you--and me--a favor, given you a platform for preaching the kingdom news!
- 18 On my account you will be brought before governors and kings as witnesses to them and to the Gentiles.
- 19 And don't worry about what you'll say or how you'll say it. The right words will be there;
- 19 But when they arrest you, do not worry about what to say or how to say it. At that time you will be given what to say,

- 20 the Spirit of your Father will supply the words.
- 20 for it will not be you speaking, but the Spirit of your Father speaking through you.
- 21 "When people realize it is the living God you are presenting and not some idol that makes them feel good, they are going to turn on you, even people in your own family.
- 21 Brother will betray brother to death, and a father his child; children will rebel against their parents and have them put to death.
- 22 There is a great irony here: proclaiming so much love, experiencing so much hate! But don't quit. Don't cave in. It is all well worth it in the end.
- 22 All men will hate you because of me, but he who stands firm to the end will be saved.
- 23 It is not success you are after in such times but survival. Be survivors! Before you've run out of options, the Son of Man will have arrived.
- 23 When you are persecuted in one place, flee to another. I tell you the truth, you will not finish going through the cities of Israel before the Son of Man comes.
- 24 "A student doesn't get a better desk than her teacher. A laborer doesn't make more money than his boss.
- 24 A student is not above his teacher, nor a servant above his master.
- 25 Be content--pleased, even--when you, my students, my harvest hands, get the same treatment I get. If they call me, the Master, 'Dungface,' what can the workers expect?
- 25 It is enough for the student to be like his teacher, and the servant like his master. If the head of the house has been called Beelzebub, how much more the members of his household!
- 26 "Don't be intimidated. Eventually everything is going to be out in the open, and everyone will know how things really are.
- 26 So do not be afraid of them. There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known.
- 27 So don't hesitate to go public now.
- 27 What I tell you in the dark, speak in the daylight; what is whispered in your ear, proclaim from the roofs.
- 28 "Don't be bluffed into silence by the threats of bullies. There's nothing they can do to your soul, your core being. Save your fear for God, who holds your entire life--body and soul--in his hands.

- 28 Do not be afraid of those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather, be afraid of the One who can destroy both soul and body in hell.
- 29 "What's the price of a pet canary? Some loose change, right? And God cares what happens to it even more than you do.
- 29 Are not two sparrows sold for a penny? Yet not one of them will fall to the ground apart from the will of your Father.
- 30 He pays even greater attention to you, down to the last detail--even numbering the hairs on your head!
- 30 And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered.
- 31 So don't be intimidated by all this bully talk. You're worth more than a million canaries.
- 31 So don't be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows.
- 32 "Stand up for me against world opinion and I'll stand up for you before my Father in heaven.
- 32 Whoever acknowledges me before men, I will also acknowledge him before my Father in heaven.
- 33 If you turn tail and run, do you think I'll cover for you?
- 33 But whoever disowns me before men, I will disown him before my Father in heaven.
- 34 "Don't think I've come to make life cozy. I've come to cut--
- 34 Do not suppose that I have come to bring peace to the earth. I did not come to bring peace, but a sword.
- 35 make a sharp knife-cut between son and father, daughter and mother, bride and mother-in-law--cut through these cozy domestic arrangements and free you for God.
- 35 For I have come to turn " 'a man against his father, a daughter against her mother, a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law--
- 36 Well-meaning family members can be your worst enemies.
- 36 a man's enemies will be the members of his own household.'
- 37 If you prefer father or mother over me, you don't deserve me. If you prefer son or daughter over me, you don't deserve me.
- 37 Anyone who loves his father or mother more than me is not worthy of me; anyone who loves his son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me;
- 38 "If you don't go all the way with me, through thick and thin, you don't deserve me.

- 38 and anyone who does not take his cross and follow me is not worthy of me.
- 39 If your first concern is to look after yourself, you'll never find yourself. But if you forget about yourself and look to me, you'll find both yourself and me.
- 39 Whoever finds his life will lose it, and whoever loses his life for my sake will find it.
- 40 "We are intimately linked in this harvest work. Anyone who accepts what you do, accepts me, the One who sent you. Anyone who accepts what I do accepts my Father, who sent me.
- 40 He who receives you receives me, and he who receives me receives the one who sent me.
- 41 Accepting a messenger of God is as good as being God's messenger. Accepting someone's help is as good as giving someone help. This is a large work I've called you into, but don't be overwhelmed by it. It's best to start small.
- 41 Anyone who receives a prophet because he is a prophet will receive a prophet's reward, and anyone who receives a righteous man because he is a righteous man will receive a righteous man's reward.
- 42 Give a cool cup of water to someone who is thirsty, for instance. The smallest act of giving or receiving makes you a true apprentice. You won't lose out on a thing."
- 42 And if anyone gives even a cup of cold water to one of these little ones because he is my disciple, I tell you the truth, he will certainly not lose his reward."

Matthew 11

MSG

NIV

- 1 When Jesus finished placing this charge before his twelve disciples, he went on to teach and preach in their villages.
- 1 After Jesus had finished instructing his twelve disciples, he went on from there to teach and preach in the towns of Galilee.
- 2 John, meanwhile, had been locked up in prison. When he got wind of what Jesus was doing, he sent his own disciples

- 2 When John heard in prison what Christ was doing, he sent his disciples
3 to ask, "Are you the One we've been expecting, or are we still waiting?"
3 to ask him, "Are you the one who was to come, or should we expect
someone else?"
- 4 Jesus told them, "Go back and tell John what's going on:
4 Jesus replied, "Go back and report to John what you hear and see:
5 The blind see, The lame walk, Lepers are cleansed, The deaf hear, The
dead are raised, The wretched of the earth learn that God is on their side.
5 The blind receive sight, the lame walk, those who have leprosy are cured,
the deaf hear, the dead are raised, and the good news is preached to the
poor.
- 6 "Is this what you were expecting? Then count yourselves most blessed!"
6 Blessed is the man who does not fall away on account of me."
- 7 When John's disciples left to report, Jesus started talking to the crowd
about John. "What did you expect when you went out to see him in the
wild? A weekend camper?
- 7 As John's disciples were leaving, Jesus began to speak to the crowd about
John: "What did you go out into the desert to see? A reed swayed by the
wind?
- 8 Hardly. What then? A sheik in silk pajamas? Not in the wilderness, not
by a long shot.
- 8 If not, what did you go out to see? A man dressed in fine clothes? No,
those who wear fine clothes are in kings' palaces.
- 9 What then? A prophet? That's right, a prophet! Probably the best prophet
you'll ever hear.
- 9 Then what did you go out to see? A prophet? Yes, I tell you, and more
than a prophet.
- 10 He is the prophet that Malachi announced when he wrote, 'I'm sending
my prophet ahead of you, to make the road smooth for you.'
- 10 This is the one about whom it is written: " 'I will send my messenger
ahead of you, who will prepare your way before you.'
- 11 "Let me tell you what's going on here: No one in history surpasses John
the Baptizer; but in the kingdom he prepared you for, the lowliest person
is ahead of him.
- 11 I tell you the truth: Among those born of women there has not risen
anyone greater than John the Baptist; yet he who is least in the kingdom

of heaven is greater than he.

12 For a long time now people have tried to force themselves into God's kingdom.

12 From the days of John the Baptist until now, the kingdom of heaven has been forcefully advancing, and forceful men lay hold of it.

13 But if you read the books of the Prophets and God's Law closely, you will see them culminate in John, teaming up with him in preparing the way for the Messiah of the kingdom.

13 For all the Prophets and the Law prophesied until John.

14 Looked at in this way, John is the 'Elijah' you've all been expecting to arrive and introduce the Messiah.

14 And if you are willing to accept it, he is the Elijah who was to come.

15 "Are you listening to me? Really listening?

15 He who has ears, let him hear.

16 "How can I account for this generation? The people have been like spoiled children whining to their parents,

16 To what can I compare this generation? They are like children sitting in the marketplaces and calling out to others:

17 'We wanted to skip rope, and you were always too tired; we wanted to talk, but you were always too busy.'

17 'We played the flute for you, and you did not dance; we sang a dirge, and you did not mourn.'

18 John came fasting and they called him crazy.

18 For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, 'He has a demon.'

19 I came feasting and they called me a lush, a friend of the riff-raff. Opinion polls don't count for much, do they? The proof of the pudding is in the eating."

19 The Son of Man came eating and drinking, and they say, 'Here is a glutton and a drunkard, a friend of tax collectors and "sinners." ' But wisdom is proved right by her actions."

20 Next Jesus let fly on the cities where he had worked the hardest but whose people had responded the least, shrugging their shoulders and going their own way.

20 Then Jesus began to denounce the cities in which most of his miracles had been performed, because they did not repent.

- 21 "Doom to you, Chorazin! Doom, Bethsaida! If Tyre and Sidon had seen half of the powerful miracles you have seen, they would have been on their knees in a minute.
- 21 Woe to you, Korazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida! If the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes.
- 22 At Judgment Day they'll get off easy compared to you.
- 22 But I tell you, it will be more bearable for Tyre and Sidon on the day of judgment than for you.
- 23 And Capernaum! With all your peacock strutting, you are going to end up in the abyss. If the people of Sodom had had your chances, the city would still be around.
- 23 And you, Capernaum, will you be lifted up to the skies? No, you will go down to the depths. If the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Sodom, it would have remained to this day.
- 24 At Judgment Day they'll get off easy compared to you."
- 24 But I tell you that it will be more bearable for Sodom on the day of judgment than for you."
- 25 Abruptly Jesus broke into prayer: "Thank you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth. You've concealed your ways from sophisticates and know-it-alls, but spelled them out clearly to ordinary people.
- 25 At that time Jesus said, "I praise you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because you have hidden these things from the wise and learned, and revealed them to little children.
- 26 Yes, Father, that's the way you like to work."
- 26 Yes, Father, for this was your good pleasure.
- 27 Jesus resumed talking to the people, but now tenderly. "The Father has given me all these things to do and say. This is a unique Father-Son operation, coming out of Father and Son intimacies and knowledge. No one knows the Son the way the Father does, nor the Father the way the Son does. But I'm not keeping it to myself; I'm ready to go over it line by line with anyone willing to listen.
- 27 All things have been committed to me by my Father. No one knows the Son except the Father, and no one knows the Father except the Son and those to whom the Son chooses to reveal him.

- 28 "Are you tired? Worn out? Burned out on religion? Come to me. Get away with me and you'll recover your life. I'll show you how to take a real rest.
- 28 Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.
- 29 Walk with me and work with me--watch how I do it. Learn the unforced rhythms of grace. I won't lay anything heavy or ill-fitting on you.
- 29 Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.
- 30 Keep company with me and you'll learn to live freely and lightly."
- 30 For my yoke is easy and my burden is light."

Matthew 12

MSG

NIV

- 1 One Sabbath, Jesus was strolling with his disciples through a field of ripe grain. Hungry, the disciples were pulling off the heads of grain and munching on them.
- 1 At that time Jesus went through the grainfields on the Sabbath. His disciples were hungry and began to pick some heads of grain and eat them.
- 2 Some Pharisees reported them to Jesus: "Your disciples are breaking the Sabbath rules!"
- 2 When the Pharisees saw this, they said to him, "Look! Your disciples are doing what is unlawful on the Sabbath."
- 3 Jesus said, "Really? Didn't you ever read what David and his companions did when they were hungry,
- 3 He answered, "Haven't you read what David did when he and his companions were hungry?
- 4 how they entered the sanctuary and ate fresh bread off the altar, bread that no one but priests were allowed to eat?
- 4 He entered the house of God, and he and his companions ate the consecrated bread--which was not lawful for them to do, but only for the priests.

- 5 And didn't you ever read in God's Law that priests carrying out their Temple duties break Sabbath rules all the time and it's not held against them?
- 5 Or haven't you read in the Law that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple desecrate the day and yet are innocent?
- 6 "There is far more at stake here than religion.
- 6 I tell you that one greater than the temple is here.
- 7 If you had any idea what this Scripture meant--'I prefer a flexible heart to an inflexible ritual'--you wouldn't be nitpicking like this.
- 7 If you had known what these words mean, 'I desire mercy, not sacrifice,' you would not have condemned the innocent.
- 8 The Son of Man is no lackey to the Sabbath; he's in charge."
- 8 For the Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath."
- 9 When Jesus left the field, he entered their meeting place.
- 9 Going on from that place, he went into their synagogue,
- 10 There was a man there with a crippled hand. They said to Jesus, "Is it legal to heal on the Sabbath?" They were baiting him.
- 10 and a man with a shriveled hand was there. Looking for a reason to accuse Jesus, they asked him, "Is it lawful to heal on the Sabbath?"
- 11 He replied, "Is there a person here who, finding one of your lambs fallen into a ravine, wouldn't, even though it was a Sabbath, pull it out?
- 11 He said to them, "If any of you has a sheep and it falls into a pit on the Sabbath, will you not take hold of it and lift it out?
- 12 Surely kindness to people is as legal as kindness to animals!"
- 12 How much more valuable is a man than a sheep! Therefore it is lawful to do good on the Sabbath."
- 13 Then he said to the man, "Hold out your hand." He held it out and it was healed.
- 13 Then he said to the man, "Stretch out your hand." So he stretched it out and it was completely restored, just as sound as the other.
- 14 The Pharisees walked out furious, sputtering about how they were going to ruin Jesus.
- 14 But the Pharisees went out and plotted how they might kill Jesus.
- 15 Jesus, knowing they were out to get him, moved on. A lot of people followed him, and he healed them all

15 Aware of this, Jesus withdrew from that place. Many followed him, and he healed all their sick,

16 . He also cautioned them to keep it quiet,

16 warning them not to tell who he was.

17 following guidelines set down by Isaiah:

17 This was to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet Isaiah:

18 Look well at my handpicked servant; I love him so much, take such delight in him. I've placed my Spirit on him; he'll decree justice to the nations.

18 Here is my servant whom I have chosen, the one I love, in whom I delight; I will put my Spirit on him, and he will proclaim justice to the nations.

19 But he won't yell, won't raise his voice; there'll be no commotion in the streets.

19 He will not quarrel or cry out; no one will hear his voice in the streets.

20 He won't walk over anyone's feelings, won't push you into a corner. Before you know it, his justice will triumph;

20 A bruised reed he will not break, and a smoldering wick he will not snuff out, till he leads justice to victory.

21 the mere sound of his name will signal hope, even among far-off unbelievers.

21 In his name the nations will put their hope."

22 Next a poor demon-afflicted wretch, both blind and deaf, was set down before him. Jesus healed him, gave him his sight and hearing.

22 Then they brought him a demon-possessed man who was blind and mute, and Jesus healed him, so that he could both talk and see.

23 The people who saw it were impressed--"This has to be the Son of David!"

23 All the people were astonished and said, "Could this be the Son of David?"

24 But the Pharisees, when they heard the report, were cynical. "Black magic," they said. "Some devil trick he's pulled from his sleeve."

24 But when the Pharisees heard this, they said, "It is only by Beelzebub, the prince of demons, that this fellow drives out demons."

25 Jesus confronted their slander. "A judge who gives opposite verdicts on the same person cancels himself out; a family that's in a constant

squabble disintegrates;

25 Jesus knew their thoughts and said to them, "Every kingdom divided against itself will be ruined, and every city or household divided against itself will not stand.

26 if Satan banishes Satan, is there any Satan left?

26 If Satan drives out Satan, he is divided against himself. How then can his kingdom stand?

27 If you're slinging devil mud at me, calling me a devil kicking out devils, doesn't the same mud stick to your own exorcists?

27 And if I drive out demons by Beelzebub, by whom do your people drive them out? So then, they will be your judges.

28 "But if it's by God's power that I am sending the evil spirits packing, then God's kingdom is here for sure.

28 But if I drive out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom of God has come upon you.

29 How in the world do you think it's possible in broad daylight to enter the house of an awake, able-bodied man and walk off with his possessions unless you tie him up first? Tie him up, though, and you can clean him out.

29 Or again, how can anyone enter a strong man's house and carry off his possessions unless he first ties up the strong man? Then he can rob his house.

30 "This is war, and there is no neutral ground. If you're not on my side, you're the enemy; if you're not helping, you're making things worse.

30 He who is not with me is against me, and he who does not gather with me scatters.

31 "There's nothing done or said that can't be forgiven. But if you deliberately persist in your slanders against God's Spirit, you are repudiating the very One who forgives.

31 And so I tell you, every sin and blasphemy will be forgiven men, but the blasphemy against the Spirit will not be forgiven.

32 If you reject the Son of Man out of some misunderstanding, the Holy Spirit can forgive you, but when you reject the Holy Spirit, you're sawing off the branch on which you're sitting, severing by your own perversity all connection with the One who forgives.

- 32 Anyone who speaks a word against the Son of Man will be forgiven, but anyone who speaks against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven, either in this age or in the age to come.
- 33 "If you grow a healthy tree, you'll pick healthy fruit. If you grow a diseased tree, you'll pick worm-eaten fruit. The fruit tells you about the tree.
- 33 Make a tree good and its fruit will be good, or make a tree bad and its fruit will be bad, for a tree is recognized by its fruit.
- 34 "You have minds like a snake pit! How do you suppose what you say is worth anything when you are so foul-minded? It's your heart, not the dictionary, that gives meaning to your words.
- 34 You brood of vipers, how can you who are evil say anything good? For out of the overflow of the heart the mouth speaks.
- 35 A good person produces good deeds and words season after season. An evil person is a blight on the orchard.
- 35 The good man brings good things out of the good stored up in him, and the evil man brings evil things out of the evil stored up in him.
- 36 Let me tell you something: Every one of these careless words is going to come back to haunt you. There will be a time of Reckoning. Words are powerful; take them seriously.
- 36 But I tell you that men will have to give account on the day of judgment for every careless word they have spoken.
- 37 Words can be your salvation. Words can also be your damnation."
- 37 For by your words you will be acquitted, and by your words you will be condemned."
- 38 Later a few religion scholars and Pharisees got on him. "Teacher, we want to see your credentials. Give us some hard evidence that God is in this. How about a miracle?"
- 38 Then some of the Pharisees and teachers of the law said to him, "Teacher, we want to see a miraculous sign from you."
- 39 Jesus said, "You're looking for proof, but you're looking for the wrong kind. All you want is something to titillate your curiosity, satisfy your lust for miracles. The only proof you're going to get is what looks like the absence of proof: Jonah-evidence.
- 39 He answered, "A wicked and adulterous generation asks for a miraculous sign! But none will be given it except the sign of the prophet

Jonah.

- 40 Like Jonah, three days and nights in the fish's belly, the Son of Man will be gone three days and nights in a deep grave.
- 40 For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of a huge fish, so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.
- 41 "On Judgment Day, the Ninevites will stand up and give evidence that will condemn this generation, because when Jonah preached to them they changed their lives. A far greater preacher than Jonah is here, and you squabble about 'proofs.'
- 41 The men of Nineveh will stand up at the judgment with this generation and condemn it; for they repented at the preaching of Jonah, and now one greater than Jonah is here.
- 42 On Judgment Day, the Queen of Sheba will come forward and bring evidence that will condemn this generation, because she traveled from a far corner of the earth to listen to wise Solomon. Wisdom far greater than Solomon's is right in front of you, and you quibble over 'evidence.'
- 42 The Queen of the South will rise at the judgment with this generation and condemn it; for she came from the ends of the earth to listen to Solomon's wisdom, and now one greater than Solomon is here.
- 43 "When a defiling evil spirit is expelled from someone, it drifts along through the desert looking for an oasis, some unsuspecting soul it can bedevil. When it doesn't find anyone,
- 43 When an evil spirit comes out of a man, it goes through arid places seeking rest and does not find it.
- 44 it says, 'I'll go back to my old haunt.' On return it finds the person spotlessly clean, but vacant.
- 44 Then it says, 'I will return to the house I left.' When it arrives, it finds the house unoccupied, swept clean and put in order.
- 45 It then runs out and rounds up seven other spirits more evil than itself and they all move in, whooping it up. That person ends up far worse off than if he'd never gotten cleaned up in the first place. "That's what this generation is like: You may think you have cleaned out the junk from your lives and gotten ready for God, but you weren't hospitable to my kingdom message, and now all the devils are moving back in."

- 45 Then it goes and takes with it seven other spirits more wicked than itself, and they go in and live there. And the final condition of that man is worse than the first. That is how it will be with this wicked generation."
- 46 While he was still talking to the crowd, his mother and brothers showed up. They were outside trying to get a message to him.
- 46 While Jesus was still talking to the crowd, his mother and brothers stood outside, wanting to speak to him.
- 47 Someone told Jesus, "Your mother and brothers are out here, wanting to speak with you."
- 47 Someone told him, "Your mother and brothers are standing outside, wanting to speak to you."
- 48 Jesus didn't respond directly, but said, "Who do you think my mother and brothers are?"
- 48 He replied to him, "Who is my mother, and who are my brothers?"
- 49 He then stretched out his hand toward his disciples. "Look closely. These are my mother and brothers.
- 49 Pointing to his disciples, he said, "Here are my mother and my brothers.
- 50 Obedience is thicker than blood. The person who obeys my heavenly Father's will is my brother and sister and mother."
- 50 For whoever does the will of my Father in heaven is my brother and sister and mother."

Matthew 13

MSG

NIV

- 1 At about that same time Jesus left the house and sat on the beach.
- 1 That same day Jesus went out of the house and sat by the lake.
- 2 In no time at all a crowd gathered along the shoreline, forcing him to get into a boat.
- 2 Such large crowds gathered around him that he got into a boat and sat in it, while all the people stood on the shore.
- 3 Using the boat as a pulpit, he addressed his congregation, telling stories. "What do you make of this? A farmer planted seed.

- 3 Then he told them many things in parables, saying: "A farmer went out to sow his seed.
- 4 As he scattered the seed, some of it fell on the road, and birds ate it.
- 4 As he was scattering the seed, some fell along the path, and the birds came and ate it up.
- 5 Some fell in the gravel; it sprouted quickly but didn't put down roots,
- 5 Some fell on rocky places, where it did not have much soil. It sprang up quickly, because the soil was shallow.
- 6 so when the sun came up it withered just as quickly.
- 6 But when the sun came up, the plants were scorched, and they withered because they had no root.
- 7 Some fell in the weeds; as it came up, it was strangled by the weeds.
- 7 Other seed fell among thorns, which grew up and choked the plants.
- 8 Some fell on good earth, and produced a harvest beyond his wildest dreams.
- 8 Still other seed fell on good soil, where it produced a crop--a hundred, sixty or thirty times what was sown.
- 9 "Are you listening to this? Really listening?"
- 9 He who has ears, let him hear."
- 10 The disciples came up and asked, "Why do you tell stories?"
- 10 The disciples came to him and asked, "Why do you speak to the people in parables?"
- 11 He replied, "You've been given insight into God's kingdom. You know how it works. Not everybody has this gift, this insight; it hasn't been given to them.
- 11 He replied, "The knowledge of the secrets of the kingdom of heaven has been given to you, but not to them.
- 12 Whenever someone has a ready heart for this, the insights and understandings flow freely. But if there is no readiness, any trace of receptivity soon disappears.
- 12 Whoever has will be given more, and he will have an abundance. Whoever does not have, even what he has will be taken from him.
- 13 That's why I tell stories: to create readiness, to nudge the people toward receptive insight. In their present state they can stare till doomsday and not see it, listen till they're blue in the face and not get it.

- 13 This is why I speak to them in parables: "Though seeing, they do not see; though hearing, they do not hear or understand.
- 14 I don't want Isaiah's forecast repeated all over again: Your ears are open but you don't hear a thing. Your eyes are awake but you don't see a thing.
- 14 In them is fulfilled the prophecy of Isaiah: " 'You will be ever hearing but never understanding; you will be ever seeing but never perceiving.
- 15 The people are blockheads! They stick their fingers in their ears so they won't have to listen; They screw their eyes shut so they won't have to look, so they won't have to deal with me face-to-face and let me heal them.
- 15 For this people's heart has become calloused; they hardly hear with their ears, and they have closed their eyes. Otherwise they might see with their eyes, hear with their ears, understand with their hearts and turn, and I would heal them.'
- 16 "But you have God-blessed eyes--eyes that see! And God-blessed ears--ears that hear!
- 16 But blessed are your eyes because they see, and your ears because they hear.
- 17 A lot of people, prophets and humble believers among them, would have given anything to see what you are seeing, to hear what you are hearing, but never had the chance.
- 17 For I tell you the truth, many prophets and righteous men longed to see what you see but did not see it, and to hear what you hear but did not hear it.
- 18 "Study this story of the farmer planting seed.
- 18 Listen then to what the parable of the sower means:
- 19 When anyone hears news of the kingdom and doesn't take it in, it just remains on the surface, and so the Evil One comes along and plucks it right out of that person's heart. This is the seed the farmer scatters on the road.
- 19 When anyone hears the message about the kingdom and does not understand it, the evil one comes and snatches away what was sown in his heart. This is the seed sown along the path.
- 20 "The seed cast in the gravel--this is the person who hears and instantly responds with enthusiasm.

- 20 The one who received the seed that fell on rocky places is the man who hears the word and at once receives it with joy.
- 21 But there is no soil of character, and so when the emotions wear off and some difficulty arrives, there is nothing to show for it.
- 21 But since he has no root, he lasts only a short time. When trouble or persecution comes because of the word, he quickly falls away.
- 22 "The seed cast in the weeds is the person who hears the kingdom news, but weeds of worry and illusions about getting more and wanting everything under the sun strangle what was heard, and nothing comes of it.
- 22 The one who received the seed that fell among the thorns is the man who hears the word, but the worries of this life and the deceitfulness of wealth choke it, making it unfruitful.
- 23 "The seed cast on good earth is the person who hears and takes in the News, and then produces a harvest beyond his wildest dreams."
- 23 But the one who received the seed that fell on good soil is the man who hears the word and understands it. He produces a crop, yielding a hundred, sixty or thirty times what was sown."
- 24 He told another story. "God's kingdom is like a farmer who planted good seed in his field.
- 24 Jesus told them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like a man who sowed good seed in his field.
- 25 That night, while his hired men were asleep, his enemy sowed thistles all through the wheat and slipped away before dawn.
- 25 But while everyone was sleeping, his enemy came and sowed weeds among the wheat, and went away.
- 26 When the first green shoots appeared and the grain began to form, the thistles showed up, too.
- 26 When the wheat sprouted and formed heads, then the weeds also appeared.
- 27 "The farmhands came to the farmer and said, 'Master, that was clean seed you planted, wasn't it? Where did these thistles come from?'
- 27 The owner's servants came to him and said, 'Sir, didn't you sow good seed in your field? Where then did the weeds come from?'
- 28 "He answered, 'Some enemy did this.' "The farmhands asked, 'Should we weed out the thistles?'

- 28 'An enemy did this,' he replied. The servants asked him, 'Do you want us to go and pull them up?'
- 29 "He said, 'No, if you weed the thistles, you'll pull up the wheat, too.
- 29 'No,' he answered, 'because while you are pulling the weeds, you may root up the wheat with them.
- 30 Let them grow together until harvest time. Then I'll instruct the harvesters to pull up the thistles and tie them in bundles for the fire, then gather the wheat and put it in the barn."
- 30 Let both grow together until the harvest. At that time I will tell the harvesters: First collect the weeds and tie them in bundles to be burned; then gather the wheat and bring it into my barn.' "
- 31 Another story. "God's kingdom is like a pine nut that a farmer plants.
- 31 He told them another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed, which a man took and planted in his field.
- 32 It is quite small as seeds go, but in the course of years it grows into a huge pine tree, and eagles build nests in it."
- 32 Though it is the smallest of all your seeds, yet when it grows, it is the largest of garden plants and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and perch in its branches."
- 33 Another story. "God's kingdom is like yeast that a woman works into the dough for dozens of loaves of barley bread--and waits while the dough rises."
- 33 He told them still another parable: "The kingdom of heaven is like yeast that a woman took and mixed into a large amount of flour until it worked all through the dough."
- 34 All Jesus did that day was tell stories--a long storytelling afternoon.
- 34 Jesus spoke all these things to the crowd in parables; he did not say anything to them without using a parable.
- 35 His storytelling fulfilled the prophecy: I will open my mouth and tell stories; I will bring out into the open things hidden since the world's first day.
- 35 So was fulfilled what was spoken through the prophet: "I will open my mouth in parables, I will utter things hidden since the creation of the world."
- 36 Jesus dismissed the congregation and went into the house. His disciples came in and said, "Explain to us that story of the thistles in the field."

36 Then he left the crowd and went into the house. His disciples came to him and said, "Explain to us the parable of the weeds in the field."

37 So he explained. "The farmer who sows the pure seed is the Son of Man.

37 He answered, "The one who sowed the good seed is the Son of Man.

38 The field is the world, the pure seeds are subjects of the kingdom, the thistles are subjects of the Devil,

38 The field is the world, and the good seed stands for the sons of the kingdom. The weeds are the sons of the evil one,

39 and the enemy who sows them is the Devil. The harvest is the end of the age, the curtain of history. The harvest hands are angels.

39 and the enemy who sows them is the devil. The harvest is the end of the age, and the harvesters are angels.

40 "The picture of thistles pulled up and burned is a scene from the final act.

40 As the weeds are pulled up and burned in the fire, so it will be at the end of the age.

41 The Son of Man will send his angels, weed out the thistles from his kingdom,

41 The Son of Man will send out his angels, and they will weed out of his kingdom everything that causes sin and all who do evil.

42 pitch them in the trash, and be done with them. They are going to complain to high heaven, but nobody is going to listen.

42 They will throw them into the fiery furnace, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

43 At the same time, ripe, holy lives will mature and adorn the kingdom of their Father. "Are you listening to this? Really listening?

43 Then the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father. He who has ears, let him hear.

44 "God's kingdom is like a treasure hidden in a field for years and then accidentally found by a trespasser. The finder is ecstatic--what a find!--and proceeds to sell everything he owns to raise money and buy that field.

44 The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field. When a man found it, he hid it again, and then in his joy went and sold all he had and bought that field.

45 "Or, God's kingdom is like a jewel merchant on the hunt for excellent pearls.

45 Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant looking for fine pearls.

46 Finding one that is flawless, he immediately sells everything and buys it.

46 When he found one of great value, he went away and sold everything he had and bought it.

47 "Or, God's kingdom is like a fishnet cast into the sea, catching all kinds of fish.

47 Once again, the kingdom of heaven is like a net that was let down into the lake and caught all kinds of fish.

48 When it is full, it is hauled onto the beach. The good fish are picked out and put in a tub; those unfit to eat are thrown away.

48 When it was full, the fishermen pulled it up on the shore. Then they sat down and collected the good fish in baskets, but threw the bad away.

49 That's how it will be when the curtain comes down on history. The angels will come and cull the bad fish

49 This is how it will be at the end of the age. The angels will come and separate the wicked from the righteous

50 and throw them in the garbage. There will be a lot of desperate complaining, but it won't do any good."

50 and throw them into the fiery furnace, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

51 Jesus asked, "Are you starting to get a handle on all this?" They answered, "Yes."

51 Have you understood all these things? Jesus asked. "Yes," they replied.

52 He said, "Then you see how every student well-trained in God's kingdom is like the owner of a general store who can put his hands on anything you need, old or new, exactly when you need it."

52 He said to them, "Therefore every teacher of the law who has been instructed about the kingdom of heaven is like the owner of a house who brings out of his storeroom new treasures as well as old."

53 When Jesus finished telling these stories, he left there,

53 When Jesus had finished these parables, he moved on from there.

54 returned to his hometown, and gave a lecture in the meetinghouse. He made a real hit, impressing everyone. "We had no idea he was this

- good!" they said. "How did he get so wise, get such ability?"
- 54 Coming to his hometown, he began teaching the people in their synagogue, and they were amazed. "Where did this man get this wisdom and these miraculous powers?" they asked.
- 55 But in the next breath they were cutting him down: "We've known him since he was a kid; he's the carpenter's son. We know his mother, Mary. We know his brothers James and Joseph, Simon and Judas.
- 55 Isn't this the carpenter's son? Isn't his mother's name Mary, and aren't his brothers James, Joseph, Simon and Judas?
- 56 All his sisters live here. Who does he think he is?"
- 56 Aren't all his sisters with us? Where then did this man get all these things?"
- 57 They got their noses all out of joint.
- 57 And they took offense at him. But Jesus said to them, "Only in his hometown and in his own house is a prophet without honor."
- 58 But Jesus said, "A prophet is taken for granted in his hometown and his family." He didn't do many miracles there because of their hostile indifference.
- 58 And he did not do many miracles there because of their lack of faith.

Matthew 14

MSG

NIV

- 1 At about this time, Herod, the regional ruler, heard what was being said about Jesus.
- 1 At that time Herod the tetrarch heard the reports about Jesus,
- 2 He said to his servants, "This has to be John the Baptizer come back from the dead. That's why he's able to work miracles!"
- 2 and he said to his attendants, "This is John the Baptist; he has risen from the dead! That is why miraculous powers are at work in him."
- 3 Herod had arrested John, put him in chains, and sent him to prison to placate Herodias, his brother Philip's wife.
- 3 Now Herod had arrested John and bound him and put him in prison because of Herodias, his brother Philip's wife,

4 John had provoked Herod by naming his relationship with Herodias "adultery."

4 for John had been saying to him: "It is not lawful for you to have her."

5 Herod wanted to kill him, but he was afraid because so many people revered John as a prophet of God.

5 Herod wanted to kill John, but he was afraid of the people, because they considered him a prophet.

6 But at his birthday celebration, he got his chance. Herodias's daughter provided the entertainment, dancing for the guests. She swept Herod away.

6 On Herod's birthday the daughter of Herodias danced for them and pleased Herod so much

7 In his drunken enthusiasm, he promised her on oath anything she wanted.

7 that he promised with an oath to give her whatever she asked.

8 Already coached by her mother, she was ready: "Give me, served up on a platter, the head of John the Baptizer."

8 Prompted by her mother, she said, "Give me here on a platter the head of John the Baptist."

9 That sobered the king up fast. Unwilling to lose face with his guests, he did it--

9 The king was distressed, but because of his oaths and his dinner guests, he ordered that her request be granted

10 ordered John's head cut off

10 and had John beheaded in the prison.

11 and presented to the girl on a platter. She in turn gave it to her mother.

11 His head was brought in on a platter and given to the girl, who carried it to her mother.

12 Later, John's disciples got the body, gave it a reverent burial, and reported to Jesus.

12 John's disciples came and took his body and buried it. Then they went and told Jesus.

13 When Jesus got the news, he slipped away by boat to an out-of-the-way place by himself. But unsuccessfully--someone saw him and the word got around. Soon a lot of people from the nearby villages walked around the lake to where he was.

- 13 When Jesus heard what had happened, he withdrew by boat privately to a solitary place. Hearing of this, the crowds followed him on foot from the towns.
- 14 When he saw them coming, he was overcome with pity and healed their sick.
- 14 When Jesus landed and saw a large crowd, he had compassion on them and healed their sick.
- 15 Toward evening the disciples approached him. "We're out in the country and it's getting late. Dismiss the people so they can go to the villages and get some supper."
- 15 As evening approached, the disciples came to him and said, "This is a remote place, and it's already getting late. Send the crowds away, so they can go to the villages and buy themselves some food."
- 16 But Jesus said, "There is no need to dismiss them. You give them supper."
- 16 Jesus replied, "They do not need to go away. You give them something to eat."
- 17 "All we have are five loaves of bread and two fish," they said.
- 17 We have here only five loaves of bread and two fish, they answered.
- 18 Jesus said, "Bring them here."
- 18 Bring them here to me, he said.
- 19 Then he had the people sit on the grass. He took the five loaves and two fish, lifted his face to heaven in prayer, blessed, broke, and gave the bread to the disciples. The disciples then gave the food to the congregation.
- 19 And he directed the people to sit down on the grass. Taking the five loaves and the two fish and looking up to heaven, he gave thanks and broke the loaves. Then he gave them to the disciples, and the disciples gave them to the people.
- 20 They all ate their fill. They gathered twelve baskets of leftovers.
- 20 They all ate and were satisfied, and the disciples picked up twelve basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over.
- 21 About five thousand were fed.
- 21 The number of those who ate was about five thousand men, besides women and children.

22 As soon as the meal was finished, he insisted that the disciples get in the boat and go on ahead to the other side while he dismissed the people.

22 Immediately Jesus made the disciples get into the boat and go on ahead of him to the other side, while he dismissed the crowd.

23 With the crowd dispersed, he climbed the mountain so he could be by himself and pray. He stayed there alone, late into the night.

23 After he had dismissed them, he went up on a mountainside by himself to pray. When evening came, he was there alone,

24 Meanwhile, the boat was far out to sea when the wind came up against them and they were battered by the waves.

24 but the boat was already a considerable distance from land, buffeted by the waves because the wind was against it.

25 At about four o'clock in the morning, Jesus came toward them walking on the water.

25 During the fourth watch of the night Jesus went out to them, walking on the lake.

26 They were scared out of their wits. "A ghost!" they said, crying out in terror.

26 When the disciples saw him walking on the lake, they were terrified. "It's a ghost," they said, and cried out in fear.

27 But Jesus was quick to comfort them. "Courage, it's me. Don't be afraid."

27 But Jesus immediately said to them: "Take courage! It is I. Don't be afraid."

28 Peter, suddenly bold, said, "Master, if it's really you, call me to come to you on the water."

28 Lord, if it's you, Peter replied, "tell me to come to you on the water."

29 He said, "Come ahead." Jumping out of the boat, Peter walked on the water to Jesus.

29 Come, he said. Then Peter got down out of the boat, walked on the water and came toward Jesus.

30 But when he looked down at the waves churning beneath his feet, he lost his nerve and started to sink. He cried, "Master, save me!"

30 But when he saw the wind, he was afraid and, beginning to sink, cried out, "Lord, save me!"

31 Jesus didn't hesitate. He reached down and grabbed his hand. Then he said, "Faint-heart, what got into you?"

31 Immediately Jesus reached out his hand and caught him. "You of little faith," he said, "why did you doubt?"

32 The two of them climbed into the boat, and the wind died down.

32 And when they climbed into the boat, the wind died down.

33 The disciples in the boat, having watched the whole thing, worshiped Jesus, saying, "This is it! You are God's Son for sure!"

33 Then those who were in the boat worshiped him, saying, "Truly you are the Son of God."

34 On return, they beached the boat at Gennesaret.

34 When they had crossed over, they landed at Gennesaret.

35 When the people got wind that he was back, they sent out word through the neighborhood and rounded up all the sick,

35 And when the men of that place recognized Jesus, they sent word to all the surrounding country. People brought all their sick to him

36 who asked for permission to touch the edge of his coat. And whoever touched him was healed.

36 and begged him to let the sick just touch the edge of his cloak, and all who touched him were healed.

Matthew 15

MSG

NIV

- 1 After that, Pharisees and religion scholars came to Jesus all the way from Jerusalem, criticizing,
- 1 Then some Pharisees and teachers of the law came to Jesus from Jerusalem and asked,
- 2 "Why do your disciples play fast and loose with the rules?"
- 2 Why do your disciples break the tradition of the elders? They don't wash their hands before they eat!
- 3 But Jesus put it right back on them. "Why do you use your rules to play fast and loose with God's commands?"
- 3 Jesus replied, "And why do you break the command of God for the sake of your tradition?"
- 4 God clearly says, 'Respect your father and mother,' and, 'Anyone denouncing father or mother should be killed.'
- 4 For God said, 'Honor your father and mother' and 'Anyone who curses his father or mother must be put to death.'
- 5 But you weasel around that by saying, 'Whoever wants to, can say to father and mother, What I owed to you I've given to God.'
- 5 But you say that if a man says to his father or mother, 'Whatever help you might otherwise have received from me is a gift devoted to God,'
- 6 That can hardly be called respecting a parent. You cancel God's command by your rules.
- 6 he is not to 'honor his father' with it. Thus you nullify the word of God for the sake of your tradition.
- 7 Frauds! Isaiah's prophecy of you hit the bull's-eye:
- 7 You hypocrites! Isaiah was right when he prophesied about you:
- 8 These people make a big show of saying the right thing, but their heart isn't in it.
- 8 'These people honor me with their lips, but their hearts are far from me.
- 9 They act like they're worshiping me, but they don't mean it. They just use me as a cover for teaching whatever suits their fancy."
- 9 They worship me in vain; their teachings are but rules taught by men.' "

- 10 He then called the crowd together and said, "Listen, and take this to heart.
- 10 Jesus called the crowd to him and said, "Listen and understand.
- 11 It's not what you swallow that pollutes your life, but what you vomit up."
- 11 What goes into a man's mouth does not make him 'unclean,' but what comes out of his mouth, that is what makes him 'unclean.' "
- 12 Later his disciples came and told him, "Did you know how upset the Pharisees were when they heard what you said?"
- 12 Then the disciples came to him and asked, "Do you know that the Pharisees were offended when they heard this?"
- 13 Jesus shrugged it off. "Every tree that wasn't planted by my Father in heaven will be pulled up by its roots.
- 13 He replied, "Every plant that my heavenly Father has not planted will be pulled up by the roots.
- 14 Forget them. They are blind men leading blind men. When a blind man leads a blind man, they both end up in the ditch."
- 14 Leave them; they are blind guides. If a blind man leads a blind man, both will fall into a pit."
- 15 Peter said, "I don't get it. Put it in plain language."
- 15 Peter said, "Explain the parable to us."
- 16 Jesus replied, "You too? Are you being willfully stupid?"
- 16 Are you still so dull? Jesus asked them.
- 17 Don't you know that anything that is swallowed works its way through the intestines and is finally defecated?
- 17 Don't you see that whatever enters the mouth goes into the stomach and then out of the body?
- 18 But what comes out of the mouth gets its start in the heart.
- 18 But the things that come out of the mouth come from the heart, and these make a man 'unclean.'
- 19 It's from the heart that we vomit up evil arguments, murders, adulteries, fornications, thefts, lies, and cussing.
- 19 For out of the heart come evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, theft, false testimony, slander.
- 20 That's what pollutes. Eating or not eating certain foods, washing or not washing your hands--that's neither here nor there."

20 These are what make a man 'unclean'; but eating with unwashed hands does not make him 'unclean.' "

21 From there Jesus took a trip to Tyre and Sidon.

21 Leaving that place, Jesus withdrew to the region of Tyre and Sidon.

22 They had hardly arrived when a Canaanite woman came down from the hills and pleaded, "Mercy, Master, Son of David! My daughter is cruelly afflicted by an evil spirit."

22 A Canaanite woman from that vicinity came to him, crying out, "Lord, Son of David, have mercy on me! My daughter is suffering terribly from demon-possession."

23 Jesus ignored her. The disciples came and complained, "Now she's bothering us. Would you please take care of her? She's driving us crazy."

23 Jesus did not answer a word. So his disciples came to him and urged him, "Send her away, for she keeps crying out after us."

24 Jesus refused, telling them, "I've got my hands full dealing with the lost sheep of Israel."

24 He answered, "I was sent only to the lost sheep of Israel."

25 Then the woman came back to Jesus, went to her knees, and begged. "Master, help me."

25 The woman came and knelt before him. "Lord, help me!" she said.

26 He said, "It's not right to take bread out of children's mouths and throw it to dogs."

26 He replied, "It is not right to take the children's bread and toss it to their dogs."

27 She was quick: "You're right, Master, but beggar dogs do get scraps from the master's table."

27 Yes, Lord, she said, "but even the dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their masters' table."

28 Jesus gave in. "Oh, woman, your faith is something else. What you want is what you get!" Right then her daughter became well.

28 Then Jesus answered, "Woman, you have great faith! Your request is granted." And her daughter was healed from that very hour.

29 After Jesus returned, he walked along Lake Galilee and then climbed a mountain and took his place, ready to receive visitors.

29 Jesus left there and went along the Sea of Galilee. Then he went up on a mountainside and sat down.

- 30 They came, tons of them, bringing along the paraplegic, the blind, the maimed, the mute--all sorts of people in need--and more or less threw them down at Jesus' feet to see what he would do with them. He healed them.
- 30 Great crowds came to him, bringing the lame, the blind, the crippled, the mute and many others, and laid them at his feet; and he healed them.
- 31 When the people saw the mutes speaking, the maimed healthy, the paraplegics walking around, the blind looking around, they were astonished and let everyone know that God was blazingly alive among them.
- 31 The people were amazed when they saw the mute speaking, the crippled made well, the lame walking and the blind seeing. And they praised the God of Israel.
- 32 But Jesus wasn't finished with them. He called his disciples and said, "I hurt for these people. For three days now they've been with me, and now they have nothing to eat. I can't send them away without a meal--they'd probably collapse on the road."
- 32 Jesus called his disciples to him and said, "I have compassion for these people; they have already been with me three days and have nothing to eat. I do not want to send them away hungry, or they may collapse on the way."
- 33 His disciples said, "But where in this deserted place are you going to dig up enough food for a meal?"
- 33 His disciples answered, "Where could we get enough bread in this remote place to feed such a crowd?"
- 34 Jesus asked, "How much bread do you have?" "Seven loaves," they said, "plus a few fish."
- 34 How many loaves do you have? Jesus asked. "Seven," they replied, "and a few small fish."
- 35 At that, Jesus directed the people to sit down.
- 35 He told the crowd to sit down on the ground.
- 36 He took the seven loaves and the fish. After giving thanks, he divided it up and gave it to the people.
- 36 Then he took the seven loaves and the fish, and when he had given thanks, he broke them and gave them to the disciples, and they in turn to the people.

- 37 Everyone ate. They had all they wanted. It took seven large baskets to collect the leftovers.
- 37 They all ate and were satisfied. Afterward the disciples picked up seven basketfuls of broken pieces that were left over.
- 38 Over four thousand people ate their fill at that meal.
- 38 The number of those who ate was four thousand, besides women and children.
- 39 After Jesus sent them away, he climbed in the boat and crossed over to the Magadan hills.
- 39 After Jesus had sent the crowd away, he got into the boat and went to the vicinity of Magadan.

Matthew 16

MSG

NIV

- 1 Some Pharisees and Sadducees were on him again, pressing him to prove himself to them.
- 1 The Pharisees and Sadducees came to Jesus and tested him by asking him to show them a sign from heaven.
- 2 He told them, "You have a saying that goes, 'Red sky at night, sailor's delight;
- 2 He replied, "When evening comes, you say, 'It will be fair weather, for the sky is red,'
- 3 red sky at morning, sailors take warning.' You find it easy enough to forecast the weather--why can't you read the signs of the times?
- 3 and in the morning, 'Today it will be stormy, for the sky is red and overcast.' You know how to interpret the appearance of the sky, but you cannot interpret the signs of the times.
- 4 An evil and wanton generation is always wanting signs and wonders. The only sign you'll get is the Jonah sign." Then he turned on his heel and walked away.
- 4 A wicked and adulterous generation looks for a miraculous sign, but none will be given it except the sign of Jonah." Jesus then left them and went away.

- 5 On their way to the other side of the lake, the disciples discovered they had forgotten to bring along bread.
- 5 When they went across the lake, the disciples forgot to take bread.
- 6 In the meantime, Jesus said to them, "Keep a sharp eye out for Pharisee-Sadducee yeast."
- 6 Be careful, Jesus said to them. "Be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees."
- 7 Thinking he was scolding them for forgetting bread, they discussed in whispers what to do.
- 7 They discussed this among themselves and said, "It is because we didn't bring any bread."
- 8 Jesus knew what they were doing and said, "Why all these worried whispers about forgetting the bread? Runt believers!
- 8 Aware of their discussion, Jesus asked, "You of little faith, why are you talking among yourselves about having no bread?
- 9 Haven't you caught on yet? Don't you remember the five loaves of bread and the five thousand people, and how many baskets of fragments you picked up?
- 9 Do you still not understand? Don't you remember the five loaves for the five thousand, and how many basketfuls you gathered?
- 10 Or the seven loaves that fed four thousand, and how many baskets of leftovers you collected?
- 10 Or the seven loaves for the four thousand, and how many basketfuls you gathered?
- 11 Haven't you realized yet that bread isn't the problem? The problem is yeast, Pharisee-Sadducee yeast."
- 11 How is it you don't understand that I was not talking to you about bread? But be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees."
- 12 Then they got it: that he wasn't concerned about eating, but teaching--the Pharisee-Sadducee kind of teaching.
- 12 Then they understood that he was not telling them to guard against the yeast used in bread, but against the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.
- 13 When Jesus arrived in the villages of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, "What are people saying about who the Son of Man is?"

- 13 When Jesus came to the region of Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, "Who do people say the Son of Man is?"
- 14 They replied, "Some think he is John the Baptizer, some say Elijah, some Jeremiah or one of the other prophets."
- 14 They replied, "Some say John the Baptist; others say Elijah; and still others, Jeremiah or one of the prophets."
- 15 He pressed them, "And how about you? Who do you say I am?"
- 15 But what about you? he asked. "Who do you say I am?"
- 16 Simon Peter said, "You're the Christ, the Messiah, the Son of the living God."
- 16 Simon Peter answered, "You are the Christ, the Son of the living God."
- 17 Jesus came back, "God bless you, Simon, son of Jonah! You didn't get that answer out of books or from teachers. My Father in heaven, God himself, let you in on this secret of who I really am."
- 17 Jesus replied, "Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, for this was not revealed to you by man, but by my Father in heaven."
- 18 And now I'm going to tell you who you are, really are. You are Peter, a rock. This is the rock on which I will put together my church, a church so expansive with energy that not even the gates of hell will be able to keep it out.
- 18 And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it.
- 19 "And that's not all. You will have complete and free access to God's kingdom, keys to open any and every door: no more barriers between heaven and earth, earth and heaven. A yes on earth is yes in heaven. A no on earth is no in heaven."
- 19 I will give you the keys of the kingdom of heaven; whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven."
- 20 He swore the disciples to secrecy. He made them promise they would tell no one that he was the Messiah.
- 20 Then he warned his disciples not to tell anyone that he was the Christ.
- 21 Then Jesus made it clear to his disciples that it was now necessary for him to go to Jerusalem, submit to an ordeal of suffering at the hands of the religious leaders, be killed, and then on the third day be raised up alive.

- 21 From that time on Jesus began to explain to his disciples that he must go to Jerusalem and suffer many things at the hands of the elders, chief priests and teachers of the law, and that he must be killed and on the third day be raised to life.
- 22 Peter took him in hand, protesting, "Impossible, Master! That can never be!"
- 22 Peter took him aside and began to rebuke him. "Never, Lord!" he said. "This shall never happen to you!"
- 23 But Jesus didn't swerve. "Peter, get out of my way. Satan, get lost. You have no idea how God works."
- 23 Jesus turned and said to Peter, "Get behind me, Satan! You are a stumbling block to me; you do not have in mind the things of God, but the things of men."
- 24 Then Jesus went to work on his disciples. "Anyone who intends to come with me has to let me lead. You're not in the driver's seat; I am. Don't run from suffering; embrace it. Follow me and I'll show you how.
- 24 Then Jesus said to his disciples, "If anyone would come after me, he must deny himself and take up his cross and follow me.
- 25 Self-help is no help at all. Self-sacrifice is the way, my way, to finding yourself, your true self.
- 25 For whoever wants to save his life will lose it, but whoever loses his life for me will find it.
- 26 What kind of deal is it to get everything you want but lose yourself? What could you ever trade your soul for?
- 26 What good will it be for a man if he gains the whole world, yet forfeits his soul? Or what can a man give in exchange for his soul?
- 27 "Don't be in such a hurry to go into business for yourself. Before you know it the Son of Man will arrive with all the splendor of his Father, accompanied by an army of angels. You'll get everything you have coming to you, a personal gift.
- 27 For the Son of Man is going to come in his Father's glory with his angels, and then he will reward each person according to what he has done.
- 28 This isn't pie in the sky by and by. Some of you standing here are going to see it take place, see the Son of Man in kingdom glory."

28 I tell you the truth, some who are standing here will not taste death before they see the Son of Man coming in his kingdom."

Matthew 17

MSG

NIV

- 1 Six days later, three of them saw that glory. Jesus took Peter and the brothers, James and John, and led them up a high mountain.
- 1 After six days Jesus took with him Peter, James and John the brother of James, and led them up a high mountain by themselves.
- 2 His appearance changed from the inside out, right before their eyes. Sunlight poured from his face. His clothes were filled with light.
- 2 There he was transfigured before them. His face shone like the sun, and his clothes became as white as the light.
- 3 Then they realized that Moses and Elijah were also there in deep conversation with him.
- 3 Just then there appeared before them Moses and Elijah, talking with Jesus.
- 4 Peter broke in, "Master, this is a great moment! What would you think if I built three memorials here on the mountain--one for you, one for Moses, one for Elijah?"
- 4 Peter said to Jesus, "Lord, it is good for us to be here. If you wish, I will put up three shelters--one for you, one for Moses and one for Elijah."
- 5 While he was going on like this, babbling, a light-radiant cloud enveloped them, and sounding from deep in the cloud a voice: "This is my Son, marked by my love, focus of my delight. Listen to him."
- 5 While he was still speaking, a bright cloud enveloped them, and a voice from the cloud said, "This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased. Listen to him!"
- 6 When the disciples heard it, they fell flat on their faces, scared to death.
- 6 When the disciples heard this, they fell facedown to the ground, terrified.
- 7 But Jesus came over and touched them. "Don't be afraid."
- 7 But Jesus came and touched them. "Get up," he said. "Don't be afraid."
- 8 When they opened their eyes and looked around all they saw was Jesus, only Jesus.

- 8 When they looked up, they saw no one except Jesus.
- 9 Coming down the mountain, Jesus swore them to secrecy. "Don't breathe a word of what you've seen. After the Son of Man is raised from the dead, you are free to talk."
- 9 As they were coming down the mountain, Jesus instructed them, "Don't tell anyone what you have seen, until the Son of Man has been raised from the dead."
- 10 The disciples, meanwhile, were asking questions. "Why do the religion scholars say that Elijah has to come first?"
- 10 The disciples asked him, "Why then do the teachers of the law say that Elijah must come first?"
- 11 Jesus answered, "Elijah does come and get everything ready.
- 11 Jesus replied, "To be sure, Elijah comes and will restore all things.
- 12 I'm telling you, Elijah has already come but they didn't know him when they saw him. They treated him like dirt, the same way they are about to treat the Son of Man."
- 12 But I tell you, Elijah has already come, and they did not recognize him, but have done to him everything they wished. In the same way the Son of Man is going to suffer at their hands."
- 13 That's when the disciples realized that all along he had been talking about John the Baptizer.
- 13 Then the disciples understood that he was talking to them about John the Baptist.
- 14 At the bottom of the mountain, they were met by a crowd of waiting people. As they approached, a man came out of the crowd and fell to his knees begging,
- 14 When they came to the crowd, a man approached Jesus and knelt before him.
- 15 "Master, have mercy on my son. He goes out of his mind and suffers terribly, falling into seizures. Frequently he is pitched into the fire, other times into the river.
- 15 Lord, have mercy on my son, he said. "He has seizures and is suffering greatly. He often falls into the fire or into the water.
- 16 I brought him to your disciples, but they could do nothing for him."
- 16 I brought him to your disciples, but they could not heal him."

- 17 Jesus said, "What a generation! No sense of God! No focus to your lives! How many times do I have to go over these things? How much longer do I have to put up with this? Bring the boy here."
- 17 O unbelieving and perverse generation, Jesus replied, "how long shall I stay with you? How long shall I put up with you? Bring the boy here to me."
- 18 He ordered the afflicting demon out--and it was out, gone. From that moment on the boy was well.
- 18 Jesus rebuked the demon, and it came out of the boy, and he was healed from that moment.
- 19 When the disciples had Jesus off to themselves, they asked, "Why couldn't we throw it out?"
- 19 Then the disciples came to Jesus in private and asked, "Why couldn't we drive it out?"
- 20 "Because you're not yet taking God seriously," said Jesus. "The simple truth is that if you had a mere kernel of faith, a poppy seed, say, you would tell this mountain, 'Move!' and it would move. There is nothing you wouldn't be able to tackle."
- 20 He replied, "Because you have so little faith. I tell you the truth, if you have faith as small as a mustard seed, you can say to this mountain, 'Move from here to there' and it will move. Nothing will be impossible for you. "
- 21 (OMITTED TEXT)
- 22 As they were regrouping in Galilee, Jesus told them, "The Son of Man is about to be betrayed to some people who want nothing to do with God.
- 22 When they came together in Galilee, he said to them, "The Son of Man is going to be betrayed into the hands of men.
- 23 They will murder him--and three days later he will be raised alive." The disciples felt terrible.
- 23 They will kill him, and on the third day he will be raised to life." And the disciples were filled with grief.
- 24 When they arrived at Capernaum, the tax men came to Peter and asked, "Does your teacher pay taxes?"

- 24 After Jesus and his disciples arrived in Capernaum, the collectors of the two-drachma tax came to Peter and asked, "Doesn't your teacher pay the temple tax?"
- 25 Peter said, "Of course." But as soon as they were in the house, Jesus confronted him. "Simon, what do you think? When a king levies taxes, who pays--his children or his subjects?"
- 25 Yes, he does, he replied. When Peter came into the house, Jesus was the first to speak. "What do you think, Simon?" he asked. "From whom do the kings of the earth collect duty and taxes--from their own sons or from others?"
- 26 He answered, "His subjects." Jesus said, "Then the children get off free, right?"
- 26 From others, Peter answered. "Then the sons are exempt," Jesus said to him.
- 27 But so we don't upset them needlessly, go down to the lake, cast a hook, and pull in the first fish that bites. Open its mouth and you'll find a coin. Take it and give it to the tax men. It will be enough for both of us."
- 27 But so that we may not offend them, go to the lake and throw out your line. Take the first fish you catch; open its mouth and you will find a four-drachma coin. Take it and give it to them for my tax and yours.

Matthew 18

MSG

NIV

- 1 At about the same time, the disciples came to Jesus asking, "Who gets the highest rank in God's kingdom?"
- 1 At that time the disciples came to Jesus and asked, "Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?"
- 2 For an answer Jesus called over a child, whom he stood in the middle of the room,
- 2 He called a little child and had him stand among them.
- 3 and said, "I'm telling you, once and for all, that unless you return to square one and start over like children, you're not even going to get a look at the kingdom, let alone get in.

- 3 And he said: "I tell you the truth, unless you change and become like little children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven.
- 4 Whoever becomes simple and elemental again, like this child, will rank high in God's kingdom.
- 4 Therefore, whoever humbles himself like this child is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.
- 5 What's more, when you receive the childlike on my account, it's the same as receiving me.
- 5 And whoever welcomes a little child like this in my name welcomes me.
- 6 "But if you give them a hard time, bullying or taking advantage of their simple trust, you'll soon wish you hadn't. You'd be better off dropped in the middle of the lake with a millstone around your neck.
- 6 But if anyone causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him to have a large millstone hung around his neck and to be drowned in the depths of the sea.
- 7 Doom to the world for giving these God-believing children a hard time! Hard times are inevitable, but you don't have to make it worse--and it's doomsday to you if you do.
- 7 Woe to the world because of the things that cause people to sin! Such things must come, but woe to the man through whom they come!
- 8 "If your hand or your foot gets in the way of God, chop it off and throw it away. You're better off maimed or lame and alive than the proud owners of two hands and two feet, godless in a furnace of eternal fire.
- 8 If your hand or your foot causes you to sin cut it off and throw it away. It is better for you to enter life maimed or crippled than to have two hands or two feet and be thrown into eternal fire.
- 9 And if your eye distracts you from God, pull it out and throw it away. You're better off one-eyed and alive than exercising your twenty-twenty vision from inside the fire of hell.
- 9 And if your eye causes you to sin, gouge it out and throw it away. It is better for you to enter life with one eye than to have two eyes and be thrown into the fire of hell.
- 10 "Watch that you don't treat a single one of these childlike believers arrogantly. You realize, don't you, that their personal angels are constantly in touch with my Father in heaven?

10 See that you do not look down on one of these little ones. For I tell you that their angels in heaven always see the face of my Father in heaven.

11 (OMITTED TEXT)

12 "Look at it this way. If someone has a hundred sheep and one of them wanders off, doesn't he leave the ninety-nine and go after the one?

12 What do you think? If a man owns a hundred sheep, and one of them wanders away, will he not leave the ninety-nine on the hills and go to look for the one that wandered off?

13 And if he finds it, doesn't he make far more over it than over the ninety-nine who stay put?

13 And if he finds it, I tell you the truth, he is happier about that one sheep than about the ninety-nine that did not wander off.

14 Your Father in heaven feels the same way. He doesn't want to lose even one of these simple believers.

14 In the same way your Father in heaven is not willing that any of these little ones should be lost.

15 "If a fellow believer hurts you, go and tell him--work it out between the two of you. If he listens, you've made a friend.

15 If your brother sins against you, go and show him his fault, just between the two of you. If he listens to you, you have won your brother over.

16 If he won't listen, take one or two others along so that the presence of witnesses will keep things honest, and try again.

16 But if he will not listen, take one or two others along, so that 'every matter may be established by the testimony of two or three witnesses.'

17 If he still won't listen, tell the church. If he won't listen to the church, you'll have to start over from scratch, confront him with the need for repentance, and offer again God's forgiving love.

17 If he refuses to listen to them, tell it to the church; and if he refuses to listen even to the church, treat him as you would a pagan or a tax collector.

18 "Take this most seriously: A yes on earth is yes in heaven; a no on earth is no in heaven. What you say to one another is eternal. I mean this.

18 I tell you the truth, whatever you bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven.

19 When two of you get together on anything at all on earth and make a prayer of it, my Father in heaven goes into action.

19 Again, I tell you that if two of you on earth agree about anything you ask for, it will be done for you by my Father in heaven.

20 And when two or three of you are together because of me, you can be sure that I'll be there."

20 For where two or three come together in my name, there am I with them."

21 At that point Peter got up the nerve to ask, "Master, how many times do I forgive a brother or sister who hurts me? Seven?"

21 Then Peter came to Jesus and asked, "Lord, how many times shall I forgive my brother when he sins against me? Up to seven times?"

22 Jesus replied, "Seven! Hardly. Try seventy times seven.

22 Jesus answered, "I tell you, not seven times, but seventy-seven times.

23 "The kingdom of God is like a king who decided to square accounts with his servants.

23 Therefore, the kingdom of heaven is like a king who wanted to settle accounts with his servants.

24 As he got under way, one servant was brought before him who had run up a debt of a hundred thousand dollars.

24 As he began the settlement, a man who owed him ten thousand talents was brought to him.

25 He couldn't pay up, so the king ordered the man, along with his wife, children, and goods, to be auctioned off at the slave market.

25 Since he was not able to pay, the master ordered that he and his wife and his children and all that he had be sold to repay the debt.

26 "The poor wretch threw himself at the king's feet and begged, 'Give me a chance and I'll pay it all back.'

26 The servant fell on his knees before him. 'Be patient with me,' he begged, 'and I will pay back everything.'

27 Touched by his plea, the king let him off, erasing the debt.

27 The servant's master took pity on him, canceled the debt and let him go.

28 "The servant was no sooner out of the room when he came upon one of his fellow servants who owed him ten dollars. He seized him by the throat and demanded, 'Pay up. Now!'

- 28 But when that servant went out, he found one of his fellow servants who owed him a hundred denarii. He grabbed him and began to choke him. 'Pay back what you owe me!' he demanded.
- 29 "The poor wretch threw himself down and begged, 'Give me a chance and I'll pay it all back.'
- 29 His fellow servant fell to his knees and begged him, 'Be patient with me, and I will pay you back.'
- 30 But he wouldn't do it. He had him arrested and put in jail until the debt was paid.
- 30 But he refused. Instead, he went off and had the man thrown into prison until he could pay the debt.
- 31 When the other servants saw this going on, they were outraged and brought a detailed report to the king.
- 31 When the other servants saw what had happened, they were greatly distressed and went and told their master everything that had happened.
- 32 "The king summoned the man and said, 'You evil servant! I forgave your entire debt when you begged me for mercy.
- 32 Then the master called the servant in. 'You wicked servant,' he said, 'I canceled all that debt of yours because you begged me to.
- 33 Shouldn't you be compelled to be merciful to your fellow servant who asked for mercy?'
- 33 Shouldn't you have had mercy on your fellow servant just as I had on you?'
- 34 The king was furious and put the screws to the man until he paid back his entire debt.
- 34 In anger his master turned him over to the jailers to be tortured, until he should pay back all he owed.
- 35 And that's exactly what my Father in heaven is going to do to each one of you who doesn't forgive unconditionally anyone who asks for mercy."
- 35 This is how my heavenly Father will treat each of you unless you forgive your brother from your heart.

Matthew 19

MSG

NIV

- 1 When Jesus had completed these teachings, he left Galilee and crossed the region of Judea on the other side of the Jordan.
- 1 When Jesus had finished saying these things, he left Galilee and went into the region of Judea to the other side of the Jordan.
- 2 Great crowds followed him there, and he healed them.
- 2 Large crowds followed him, and he healed them there.
- 3 One day the Pharisees were badgering him: "Is it legal for a man to divorce his wife for any reason?"
- 3 Some Pharisees came to him to test him. They asked, "Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife for any and every reason?"
- 4 He answered, "Haven't you read in your Bible that the Creator originally made man and woman for each other, male and female?"
- 4 Haven't you read, he replied, "that at the beginning the Creator 'made them male and female,'
- 5 And because of this, a man leaves father and mother and is firmly bonded to his wife, becoming one flesh--no longer two bodies but one.
- 5 and said, 'For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh' ?
- 6 Because God created this organic union of the two sexes, no one should desecrate his art by cutting them apart."
- 6 So they are no longer two, but one. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate."
- 7 They shot back in rebuttal, "If that's so, why did Moses give instructions for divorce papers and divorce procedures?"
- 7 Why then, they asked, "did Moses command that a man give his wife a certificate of divorce and send her away?"
- 8 Jesus said, "Moses provided for divorce as a concession to your hardheartedness, but it is not part of God's original plan.
- 8 Jesus replied, "Moses permitted you to divorce your wives because your hearts were hard. But it was not this way from the beginning.
- 9 I'm holding you to the original plan, and holding you liable for adultery if you divorce your faithful wife and then marry someone else. I make an exception in cases where the spouse has committed adultery."
- 9 I tell you that anyone who divorces his wife, except for marital unfaithfulness, and marries another woman commits adultery."

- 10 Jesus' disciples objected, "If those are the terms of marriage, we're stuck. Why get married?"
- 10 The disciples said to him, "If this is the situation between a husband and wife, it is better not to marry."
- 11 But Jesus said, "Not everyone is mature enough to live a married life. It requires a certain aptitude and grace. Marriage isn't for everyone."
- 11 Jesus replied, "Not everyone can accept this word, but only those to whom it has been given."
- 12 Some, from birth seemingly, never give marriage a thought. Others never get asked--or accepted. And some decide not to get married for kingdom reasons. But if you're capable of growing into the largeness of marriage, do it."
- 12 For some are eunuchs because they were born that way; others were made that way by men; and others have renounced marriage because of the kingdom of heaven. The one who can accept this should accept it."
- 13 One day children were brought to Jesus in the hope that he would lay hands on them and pray over them. The disciples shooed them off.
- 13 Then little children were brought to Jesus for him to place his hands on them and pray for them. But the disciples rebuked those who brought them.
- 14 But Jesus intervened: "Let the children alone, don't prevent them from coming to me. God's kingdom is made up of people like these."
- 14 Jesus said, "Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them, for the kingdom of heaven belongs to such as these."
- 15 After laying hands on them, he left.
- 15 When he had placed his hands on them, he went on from there.
- 16 Another day, a man stopped Jesus and asked, "Teacher, what good thing must I do to get eternal life?"
- 16 Now a man came up to Jesus and asked, "Teacher, what good thing must I do to get eternal life?"
- 17 Jesus said, "Why do you question me about what's good? God is the One who is good. If you want to enter the life of God, just do what he tells you."
- 17 Why do you ask me about what is good? Jesus replied. "There is only One who is good. If you want to enter life, obey the commandments."

18 The man asked, "What in particular?" Jesus said, "Don't murder, don't commit adultery, don't steal, don't lie,
18 Which ones? the man inquired. Jesus replied, " 'Do not murder, do not commit adultery, do not steal, do not give false testimony,
19 honor your father and mother, and love your neighbor as you do yourself."
19 honor your father and mother,' and 'love your neighbor as yourself.' "
20 The young man said, "I've done all that. What's left?"
20 All these I have kept, the young man said. "What do I still lack?"
21 "If you want to give it all you've got," Jesus replied, "go sell your possessions; give everything to the poor. All your wealth will then be in heaven. Then come follow me."
21 Jesus answered, "If you want to be perfect, go, sell your possessions and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven. Then come, follow me."
22 That was the last thing the young man expected to hear. And so, crestfallen, he walked away. He was holding on tight to a lot of things, and he couldn't bear to let go.
22 When the young man heard this, he went away sad, because he had great wealth.
23 As he watched him go, Jesus told his disciples, "Do you have any idea how difficult it is for the rich to enter God's kingdom?
23 Then Jesus said to his disciples, "I tell you the truth, it is hard for a rich man to enter the kingdom of heaven.
24 Let me tell you, it's easier to gallop a camel through a needle's eye than for the rich to enter God's kingdom."
24 Again I tell you, it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God."
25 The disciples were staggered. "Then who has any chance at all?"
25 When the disciples heard this, they were greatly astonished and asked, "Who then can be saved?"
26 Jesus looked hard at them and said, "No chance at all if you think you can pull it off yourself. Every chance in the world if you trust God to do it."
26 Jesus looked at them and said, "With man this is impossible, but with God all things are possible."

- 27 Then Peter chimed in, "We left everything and followed you. What do we get out of it?"
- 27 Peter answered him, "We have left everything to follow you! What then will there be for us?"
- 28 Jesus replied, "Yes, you have followed me. In the re-creation of the world, when the Son of Man will rule gloriously, you who have followed me will also rule, starting with the twelve tribes of Israel.
- 28 Jesus said to them, "I tell you the truth, at the renewal of all things, when the Son of Man sits on his glorious throne, you who have followed me will also sit on twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.
- 29 And not only you, but anyone who sacrifices home, family, fields--whatever--because of me will get it all back a hundred times over, not to mention the considerable bonus of eternal life.
- 29 And everyone who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or children or fields for my sake will receive a hundred times as much and will inherit eternal life.
- 30 This is the Great Reversal: many of the first ending up last, and the last first.
- 30 But many who are first will be last, and many who are last will be first.

Matthew 20

MSG

NIV

- 1 "God's kingdom is like an estate manager who went out early in the morning to hire workers for his vineyard.
- 1 For the kingdom of heaven is like a landowner who went out early in the morning to hire men to work in his vineyard.
- 2 They agreed on a wage of a dollar a day, and went to work.
- 2 He agreed to pay them a denarius for the day and sent them into his vineyard.
- 3 "Later, about nine o'clock, the manager saw some other men hanging around the town square unemployed.
- 3 About the third hour he went out and saw others standing in the marketplace doing nothing.

- 4 He told them to go to work in his vineyard and he would pay them a fair wage.
- 4 He told them, 'You also go and work in my vineyard, and I will pay you whatever is right.'
- 5 They went. "He did the same thing at noon, and again at three o'clock.
- 5 So they went. "He went out again about the sixth hour and the ninth hour and did the same thing.
- 6 At five o'clock he went back and found still others standing around. He said, 'Why are you standing around all day doing nothing?'
- 6 About the eleventh hour he went out and found still others standing around. He asked them, 'Why have you been standing here all day long doing nothing?'
- 7 ' "They said, 'Because no one hired us.' "He told them to go to work in his vineyard.
- 7 'Because no one has hired us,' they answered. He said to them, 'You also go and work in my vineyard.'
- 8 "When the day's work was over, the owner of the vineyard instructed his foreman, 'Call the workers in and pay them their wages. Start with the last hired and go on to the first.'
- 8 When evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to his foreman, 'Call the workers and pay them their wages, beginning with the last ones hired and going on to the first.'
- 9 "Those hired at five o'clock came up and were each given a dollar.
- 9 The workers who were hired about the eleventh hour came and each received a denarius.
- 10 When those who were hired first saw that, they assumed they would get far more. But they got the same, each of them one dollar.
- 10 So when those came who were hired first, they expected to receive more. But each one of them also received a denarius.
- 11 Taking the dollar, they groused angrily to the manager,
- 11 When they received it, they began to grumble against the landowner.
- 12 'These last workers put in only one easy hour, and you just made them equal to us, who slaved all day under a scorching sun.'
- 12 'These men who were hired last worked only one hour,' they said, 'and you have made them equal to us who have borne the burden of the work and the heat of the day.'

- 13 "He replied to the one speaking for the rest, 'Friend, I haven't been unfair. We agreed on the wage of a dollar, didn't we?
- 13 But he answered one of them, 'Friend, I am not being unfair to you. Didn't you agree to work for a denarius?
- 14 So take it and go. I decided to give to the one who came last the same as you.
- 14 Take your pay and go. I want to give the man who was hired last the same as I gave you.
- 15 Can't I do what I want with my own money? Are you going to get stingy because I am generous?'
- 15 Don't I have the right to do what I want with my own money? Or are you envious because I am generous?'
- 16 "Here it is again, the Great Reversal: many of the first ending up last, and the last first."
- 16 So the last will be first, and the first will be last.
- 17 Jesus, now well on the way up to Jerusalem, took the Twelve off to the side of the road and said,
- 17 Now as Jesus was going up to Jerusalem, he took the twelve disciples aside and said to them,
- 18 "Listen to me carefully. We are on our way up to Jerusalem. When we get there, the Son of Man will be betrayed to the religious leaders and scholars. They will sentence him to death.
- 18 We are going up to Jerusalem, and the Son of Man will be betrayed to the chief priests and the teachers of the law. They will condemn him to death
- 19 They will then hand him over to the Romans for mockery and torture and crucifixion. On the third day he will be raised up alive."
- 19 and will turn him over to the Gentiles to be mocked and flogged and crucified. On the third day he will be raised to life!"
- 20 It was about that time that the mother of the Zebedee brothers came with her two sons and knelt before Jesus with a request.
- 20 Then the mother of Zebedee's sons came to Jesus with her sons and, kneeling down, asked a favor of him.
- 21 "What do you want?" Jesus asked. She said, "Give your word that these two sons of mine will be awarded the highest places of honor in your kingdom, one at your right hand, one at your left hand."

- 21 What is it you want? he asked. She said, "Grant that one of these two sons of mine may sit at your right and the other at your left in your kingdom."
- 22 Jesus responded, "You have no idea what you're asking." And he said to James and John, "Are you capable of drinking the cup that I'm about to drink?" They said, "Sure, why not?"
- 22 You don't know what you are asking, Jesus said to them. "Can you drink the cup I am going to drink?" "We can," they answered.
- 23 Jesus said, "Come to think of it, you are going to drink my cup. But as to awarding places of honor, that's not my business. My Father is taking care of that."
- 23 Jesus said to them, "You will indeed drink from my cup, but to sit at my right or left is not for me to grant. These places belong to those for whom they have been prepared by my Father."
- 24 When the ten others heard about this, they lost their tempers, thoroughly disgusted with the two brothers.
- 24 When the ten heard about this, they were indignant with the two brothers.
- 25 So Jesus got them together to settle things down. He said, "You've observed how godless rulers throw their weight around, how quickly a little power goes to their heads.
- 25 Jesus called them together and said, "You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and their high officials exercise authority over them.
- 26 It's not going to be that way with you. Whoever wants to be great must become a servant.
- 26 Not so with you. Instead, whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant,
- 27 Whoever wants to be first among you must be your slave.
- 27 and whoever wants to be first must be your slave--
- 28 That is what the Son of Man has done: He came to serve, not be served--and then to give away his life in exchange for the many who are held hostage."
- 28 just as the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."
- 29 As they were leaving Jericho, a huge crowd followed.

- 29 As Jesus and his disciples were leaving Jericho, a large crowd followed him.
- 30 Suddenly they came upon two blind men sitting alongside the road. When they heard it was Jesus passing, they cried out, "Master, have mercy on us! Mercy, Son of David!"
- 30 Two blind men were sitting by the roadside, and when they heard that Jesus was going by, they shouted, "Lord, Son of David, have mercy on us!"
- 31 The crowd tried to hush them up, but they got all the louder, crying, "Master, have mercy on us! Mercy, Son of David!"
- 31 The crowd rebuked them and told them to be quiet, but they shouted all the louder, "Lord, Son of David, have mercy on us!"
- 32 Jesus stopped and called over, "What do you want from me?"
- 32 Jesus stopped and called them. "What do you want me to do for you?" he asked.
- 33 They said, "Master, we want our eyes opened. We want to see!"
- 33 Lord, they answered, "we want our sight."
- 34 Deeply moved, Jesus touched their eyes. They had their sight back that very instant, and joined the procession.
- 34 Jesus had compassion on them and touched their eyes. Immediately they received their sight and followed him.

Matthew 21

MSG

NIV

- 1 When they neared Jerusalem, having arrived at Bethphage on Mount Olives, Jesus sent two disciples
- 1 As they approached Jerusalem and came to Bethphage on the Mount of Olives, Jesus sent two disciples,
- 2 with these instructions: "Go over to the village across from you. You'll find a donkey tethered there, her colt with her. Untie her and bring them to me.
- 2 saying to them, "Go to the village ahead of you, and at once you will find a donkey tied there, with her colt by her. Untie them and bring them to me.

- 3 If anyone asks what you're doing, say, 'The Master needs them!' He will send them with you."
- 3 If anyone says anything to you, tell him that the Lord needs them, and he will send them right away."
- 4 This is the full story of what was sketched earlier by the prophet:
- 4 This took place to fulfill what was spoken through the prophet:
- 5 Tell Zion's daughter, "Look, your king's on his way, poised and ready, mounted On a donkey, on a colt, foal of a pack animal."
- 5 Say to the Daughter of Zion, 'See, your king comes to you, gentle and riding on a donkey, on a colt, the foal of a donkey.'
- 6 The disciples went and did exactly what Jesus told them to do.
- 6 The disciples went and did as Jesus had instructed them.
- 7 They led the donkey and colt out, laid some of their clothes on them, and Jesus mounted.
- 7 They brought the donkey and the colt, placed their cloaks on them, and Jesus sat on them.
- 8 Nearly all the people in the crowd threw their garments down on the road, giving him a royal welcome. Others cut branches from the trees and threw them down as a welcome mat.
- 8 A very large crowd spread their cloaks on the road, while others cut branches from the trees and spread them on the road.
- 9 Crowds went ahead and crowds followed, all of them calling out, "Hosanna to David's son!" "Blessed is he who comes in God's name!" "Hosanna in highest heaven!"
- 9 The crowds that went ahead of him and those that followed shouted, "Hosanna to the Son of David!" "Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!" "Hosanna in the highest!"
- 10 As he made his entrance into Jerusalem, the whole city was shaken. Unnerved, people were asking, "What's going on here? Who is this?"
- 10 When Jesus entered Jerusalem, the whole city was stirred and asked, "Who is this?"
- 11 The parade crowd answered, "This is the prophet Jesus, the one from Nazareth in Galilee."
- 11 The crowds answered, "This is Jesus, the prophet from Nazareth in Galilee."

- 12 Jesus went straight to the Temple and threw out everyone who had set up shop, buying and selling. He kicked over the tables of loan sharks and the stalls of dove merchants.
- 12 Jesus entered the temple area and drove out all who were buying and selling there. He overturned the tables of the money changers and the benches of those selling doves.
- 13 He quoted this text: My house was designated a house of prayer; You have made it a hangout for thieves.
- 13 It is written, he said to them, " 'My house will be called a house of prayer,' but you are making it a 'den of robbers.' "
- 14 Now there was room for the blind and crippled to get in. They came to Jesus and he healed them.
- 14 The blind and the lame came to him at the temple, and he healed them.
- 15 When the religious leaders saw the outrageous things he was doing, and heard all the children running and shouting through the Temple, "Hosanna to David's Son!" they were up in arms and took him to task.
- 15 But when the chief priests and the teachers of the law saw the wonderful things he did and the children shouting in the temple area, "Hosanna to the Son of David," they were indignant.
- 16 "Do you hear what these children are saying?" Jesus said, "Yes, I hear them. And haven't you read in God's Word, 'From the mouths of children and babies I'll furnish a place of praise'?"
- 16 Do you hear what these children are saying? they asked him. "Yes," replied Jesus, "have you never read, " 'From the lips of children and infants you have ordained praise' ?"
- 17 Fed up, Jesus turned on his heel and left the city for Bethany, where he spent the night.
- 17 And he left them and went out of the city to Bethany, where he spent the night.
- 18 Early the next morning Jesus was returning to the city. He was hungry.
- 18 Early in the morning, as he was on his way back to the city, he was hungry.
- 19 Seeing a lone fig tree alongside the road, he approached it anticipating a breakfast of figs. When he got to the tree, there was nothing but fig leaves. He said, "No more figs from this tree--ever!" The fig tree withered on the spot, a dry stick.

- 19 Seeing a fig tree by the road, he went up to it but found nothing on it except leaves. Then he said to it, "May you never bear fruit again!" Immediately the tree withered.
- 20 The disciples saw it happen. They rubbed their eyes, saying, "Did we really see this? A leafy tree one minute, a dry stick the next?"
- 20 When the disciples saw this, they were amazed. "How did the fig tree wither so quickly?" they asked.
- 21 But Jesus was matter-of-fact: "Yes--and if you embrace this kingdom life and don't doubt God, you'll not only do minor feats like I did to the fig tree, but also triumph over huge obstacles. This mountain, for instance, you'll tell, 'Go jump in the lake,' and it will jump.
- 21 Jesus replied, "I tell you the truth, if you have faith and do not doubt, not only can you do what was done to the fig tree, but also you can say to this mountain, 'Go, throw yourself into the sea,' and it will be done.
- 22 Absolutely everything, ranging from small to large, as you make it a part of your believing prayer, gets included as you lay hold of God."
- 22 If you believe, you will receive whatever you ask for in prayer."
- 23 Then he was back in the Temple, teaching. The high priests and leaders of the people came up and demanded, "Show us your credentials. Who authorized you to teach here?"
- 23 Jesus entered the temple courts, and, while he was teaching, the chief priests and the elders of the people came to him. "By what authority are you doing these things?" they asked. "And who gave you this authority?"
- 24 Jesus responded, "First let me ask you a question. You answer my question and I'll answer yours.
- 24 Jesus replied, "I will also ask you one question. If you answer me, I will tell you by what authority I am doing these things.
- 25 About the baptism of John--who authorized it: heaven or humans?" They were on the spot and knew it. They pulled back into a huddle and whispered, "If we say 'heaven,' he'll ask us why we didn't believe him;
- 25 John's baptism--where did it come from? Was it from heaven, or from men?" They discussed it among themselves and said, "If we say, 'From heaven,' he will ask, 'Then why didn't you believe him?'
- 26 if we say 'humans,' we're up against it with the people because they all hold John up as a prophet."

26 But if we say, 'From men'--we are afraid of the people, for they all hold that John was a prophet."

27 They decided to concede that round to Jesus. "We don't know," they answered. Jesus said, "Then neither will I answer your question."

27 So they answered Jesus, "We don't know." Then he said, "Neither will I tell you by what authority I am doing these things."

28 "Tell me what you think of this story: A man had two sons. He went up to the first and said, 'Son, go out for the day and work in the vineyard.'

28 What do you think? There was a man who had two sons. He went to the first and said, 'Son, go and work today in the vineyard.'

29 "The son answered, 'I don't want to.' Later on he thought better of it and went.

29 'I will not,' he answered, but later he changed his mind and went.

30 "The father gave the same command to the second son. He answered, 'Sure, glad to.' But he never went.

30 Then the father went to the other son and said the same thing. He answered, 'I will, sir,' but he did not go.

31 "Which of the two sons did what the father asked?" They said, "The first." Jesus said, "Yes, and I tell you that crooks and whores are going to precede you into God's kingdom."

31 Which of the two did what his father wanted? "The first," they answered. Jesus said to them, "I tell you the truth, the tax collectors and the prostitutes are entering the kingdom of God ahead of you."

32 John came to you showing you the right road. You turned up your noses at him, but the crooks and whores believed him. Even when you saw their changed lives, you didn't care enough to change and believe him.

32 For John came to you to show you the way of righteousness, and you did not believe him, but the tax collectors and the prostitutes did. And even after you saw this, you did not repent and believe him.

33 "Here's another story. Listen closely. There was once a man, a wealthy farmer, who planted a vineyard. He fenced it, dug a winepress, put up a watchtower, then turned it over to the farmhands and went off on a trip."

33 Listen to another parable: There was a landowner who planted a vineyard. He put a wall around it, dug a winepress in it and built a watchtower. Then he rented the vineyard to some farmers and went away on a journey.

- 34 When it was time to harvest the grapes, he sent his servants back to collect his profits.
- 34 When the harvest time approached, he sent his servants to the tenants to collect his fruit.
- 35 "The farmhands grabbed the first servant and beat him up. The next one they murdered. They threw stones at the third but he got away.
- 35 The tenants seized his servants; they beat one, killed another, and stoned a third.
- 36 The owner tried again, sending more servants. They got the same treatment.
- 36 Then he sent other servants to them, more than the first time, and the tenants treated them the same way.
- 37 The owner was at the end of his rope. He decided to send his son. 'Surely,' he thought, 'they will respect my son.'
- 37 Last of all, he sent his son to them. 'They will respect my son,' he said.
- 38 "But when the farmhands saw the son arrive, they rubbed their hands in greed. 'This is the heir! Let's kill him and have it all for ourselves.'
- 38 But when the tenants saw the son, they said to each other, 'This is the heir. Come, let's kill him and take his inheritance.'
- 39 They grabbed him, threw him out, and killed him.
- 39 So they took him and threw him out of the vineyard and killed him.
- 40 "Now, when the owner of the vineyard arrives home from his trip, what do you think he will do to the farmhands?"
- 40 Therefore, when the owner of the vineyard comes, what will he do to those tenants?
- 41 "He'll kill them--a rotten bunch, and good riddance," they answered. "Then he'll assign the vineyard to farmhands who will hand over the profits when it's time."
- 41 He will bring those wretches to a wretched end, they replied, "and he will rent the vineyard to other tenants, who will give him his share of the crop at harvest time."
- 42 Jesus said, "Right--and you can read it for yourselves in your Bibles: The stone the masons threw out is now the cornerstone. This is God's work; we rub our eyes, we can hardly believe it!
- 42 Jesus said to them, "Have you never read in the Scriptures: " 'The stone the builders rejected has become the capstone; the Lord has done this,

and it is marvelous in our eyes' ?

43 "This is the way it is with you. God's kingdom will be taken back from you and handed over to a people who will live out a kingdom life.

43 Therefore I tell you that the kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a people who will produce its fruit.

44 Whoever stumbles on this Stone gets shattered; whoever the Stone falls on gets smashed."

44 He who falls on this stone will be broken to pieces, but he on whom it falls will be crushed."

45 When the religious leaders heard this story, they knew it was aimed at them.

45 When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard Jesus' parables, they knew he was talking about them.

46 They wanted to arrest Jesus and put him in jail, but, intimidated by public opinion, they held back. Most people held him to be a prophet of God.

46 They looked for a way to arrest him, but they were afraid of the crowd because the people held that he was a prophet.

Matthew 22

MSG

NIV

1 Jesus responded by telling still more stories.

1 Jesus spoke to them again in parables, saying:

2 "God's kingdom," he said, "is like a king who threw a wedding banquet for his son.

2 The kingdom of heaven is like a king who prepared a wedding banquet for his son.

3 He sent out servants to call in all the invited guests. And they wouldn't come!

3 He sent his servants to those who had been invited to the banquet to tell them to come, but they refused to come.

4 "He sent out another round of servants, instructing them to tell the guests, 'Look, everything is on the table, the prime rib is ready for carving. Come to the feast!'

- 4 Then he sent some more servants and said, 'Tell those who have been invited that I have prepared my dinner: My oxen and fattened cattle have been butchered, and everything is ready. Come to the wedding banquet.'
- 5 "They only shrugged their shoulders and went off, one to weed his garden, another to work in his shop.
- 5 But they paid no attention and went off--one to his field, another to his business.
- 6 The rest, with nothing better to do, beat up on the messengers and then killed them.
- 6 The rest seized his servants, mistreated them and killed them.
- 7 The king was outraged and sent his soldiers to destroy those thugs and level their city.
- 7 The king was enraged. He sent his army and destroyed those murderers and burned their city.
- 8 "Then he told his servants, 'We have a wedding banquet all prepared but no guests. The ones I invited weren't up to it.
- 8 Then he said to his servants, 'The wedding banquet is ready, but those I invited did not deserve to come.
- 9 Go out into the busiest intersections in town and invite anyone you find to the banquet.'
- 9 Go to the street corners and invite to the banquet anyone you find.'
- 10 The servants went out on the streets and rounded up everyone they laid eyes on, good and bad, regardless. And so the banquet was on--every place filled.
- 10 So the servants went out into the streets and gathered all the people they could find, both good and bad, and the wedding hall was filled with guests.
- 11 "When the king entered and looked over the scene, he spotted a man who wasn't properly dressed.
- 11 But when the king came in to see the guests, he noticed a man there who was not wearing wedding clothes.
- 12 He said to him, 'Friend, how dare you come in here looking like that!' The man was speechless.
- 12 'Friend,' he asked, 'how did you get in here without wedding clothes?' The man was speechless.

- 13 Then the king told his servants, 'Get him out of here--fast. Tie him up and ship him to hell. And make sure he doesn't get back in.'
- 13 Then the king told the attendants, 'Tie him hand and foot, and throw him outside, into the darkness, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.'
- 14 "That's what I mean when I say, 'Many get invited; only a few make it.'"
- 14 For many are invited, but few are chosen.
- 15 That's when the Pharisees plotted a way to trap him into saying something damaging.
- 15 Then the Pharisees went out and laid plans to trap him in his words.
- 16 They sent their disciples, with a few of Herod's followers mixed in, to ask, "Teacher, we know you have integrity, teach the way of God accurately, are indifferent to popular opinion, and don't pander to your students.
- 16 They sent their disciples to him along with the Herodians. "Teacher," they said, "we know you are a man of integrity and that you teach the way of God in accordance with the truth. You aren't swayed by men, because you pay no attention to who they are.
- 17 So tell us honestly: Is it right to pay taxes to Caesar or not?"
- 17 Tell us then, what is your opinion? Is it right to pay taxes to Caesar or not?"
- 18 Jesus knew they were up to no good. He said, "Why are you playing these games with me? Why are you trying to trap me?"
- 18 But Jesus, knowing their evil intent, said, "You hypocrites, why are you trying to trap me?"
- 19 Do you have a coin? Let me see it." They handed him a silver piece.
- 19 Show me the coin used for paying the tax." They brought him a denarius,
- 20 "This engraving--who does it look like? And whose name is on it?"
- 20 and he asked them, "Whose portrait is this? And whose inscription?"
- 21 They said, "Caesar." "Then give Caesar what is his, and give God what is his."
- 21 Caesar's, they replied. Then he said to them, "Give to Caesar what is Caesar's, and to God what is God's."
- 22 The Pharisees were speechless. They went off shaking their heads.

22 When they heard this, they were amazed. So they left him and went away.

23 That same day, Sadducees approached him. This is the party that denies any possibility of resurrection.

23 That same day the Sadducees, who say there is no resurrection, came to him with a question.

24 They asked, "Teacher, Moses said that if a man dies childless, his brother is obligated to marry his widow and get her with child.

24 Teacher, they said, "Moses told us that if a man dies without having children, his brother must marry the widow and have children for him.

25 Here's a case where there were seven brothers. The first brother married and died, leaving no child, and his wife passed to his brother.

25 Now there were seven brothers among us. The first one married and died, and since he had no children, he left his wife to his brother.

26 The second brother also left her childless, then the third--and on and on, all seven.

26 The same thing happened to the second and third brother, right on down to the seventh.

27 Eventually the wife died.

27 Finally, the woman died.

28 Now here's our question: At the resurrection, whose wife is she? She was a wife to each of them."

28 Now then, at the resurrection, whose wife will she be of the seven, since all of them were married to her?"

29 Jesus answered, "You're off base on two counts: You don't know your Bibles, and you don't know how God works.

29 Jesus replied, "You are in error because you do not know the Scriptures or the power of God.

30 At the resurrection we're beyond marriage. As with the angels, all our ecstasies and intimacies then will be with God.

30 At the resurrection people will neither marry nor be given in marriage; they will be like the angels in heaven.

31 And regarding your speculation on whether the dead are raised or not, don't you read your Bibles? The grammar is clear: God says,

31 But about the resurrection of the dead--have you not read what God said to you,

32 'I am--not was--the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, the God of Jacob.' The living God defines himself not as the God of dead men, but of the living."

32 'I am the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob' ? He is not the God of the dead but of the living."

33 Hearing this exchange the crowd was much impressed.

33 When the crowds heard this, they were astonished at his teaching.

34 When the Pharisees heard how he had bested the Sadducees, they gathered their forces for an assault.

34 Hearing that Jesus had silenced the Sadducees, the Pharisees got together.

35 One of their religion scholars spoke for them, posing a question they hoped would show him up:

35 One of them, an expert in the law, tested him with this question:

36 "Teacher, which command in God's Law is the most important?"

36 Teacher, which is the greatest commandment in the Law?

37 Jesus said, "'Love the Lord your God with all your passion and prayer and intelligence.'

37 Jesus replied: " 'Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.'

38 This is the most important, the first on any list.

38 This is the first and greatest commandment.

39 But there is a second to set alongside it: 'Love others as well as you love yourself.'

39 And the second is like it: 'Love your neighbor as yourself.'

40 These two commands are pegs; everything in God's Law and the Prophets hangs from them."

40 All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments."

41 As the Pharisees were regrouping, Jesus caught them off balance with his own test question:

41 While the Pharisees were gathered together, Jesus asked them,

42 "What do you think about the Christ? Whose son is he?" They said, "David's son."

42 What do you think about the Christ? Whose son is he? "The son of David," they replied.

- 43 Jesus replied, "Well, if the Christ is David's son, how do you explain that David, under inspiration, named Christ his 'Master'?"
- 43 He said to them, "How is it then that David, speaking by the Spirit, calls him 'Lord'? For he says,
- 44 God said to my Master, "Sit here at my right hand until I make your enemies your footstool."
- 44 'The Lord said to my Lord: Sit at my right hand until I put your enemies under your feet.' "
- 45 "Now if David calls him 'Master,' how can he at the same time be his son?"
- 45 If then David calls him 'Lord,' how can he be his son?"
- 46 That stumped them, literalists that they were. Unwilling to risk losing face again in one of these public verbal exchanges, they quit asking questions for good.
- 46 No one could say a word in reply, and from that day on no one dared to ask him any more questions.

Matthew 23

MSG

NIV

- 1 Now Jesus turned to address his disciples, along with the crowd that had gathered with them.
- 1 Then Jesus said to the crowds and to his disciples:
- 2 "The religion scholars and Pharisees are competent teachers in God's Law.
- 2 The teachers of the law and the Pharisees sit in Moses' seat.
- 3 You won't go wrong in following their teachings on Moses. But be careful about following them. They talk a good line, but they don't live it. They don't take it into their hearts and live it out in their behavior. It's all spit-and-polish veneer.
- 3 So you must obey them and do everything they tell you. But do not do what they do, for they do not practice what they preach.
- 4 "Instead of giving you God's Law as food and drink by which you can banquet on God, they package it in bundles of rules, loading you down

- like pack animals. They seem to take pleasure in watching you stagger under these loads, and wouldn't think of lifting a finger to help.
- 4 They tie up heavy loads and put them on men's shoulders, but they themselves are not willing to lift a finger to move them.
- 5 Their lives are perpetual fashion shows, embroidered prayer shawls one day and flowery prayers the next.
- 5 Everything they do is done for men to see: They make their phylacteries wide and the tassels on their garments long;
- 6 They love to sit at the head table at church dinners, basking in the most prominent positions,
- 6 they love the place of honor at banquets and the most important seats in the synagogues;
- 7 preening in the radiance of public flattery, receiving honorary degrees, and getting called 'Doctor' and 'Reverend.'
- 7 they love to be greeted in the marketplaces and to have men call them 'Rabbi.'
- 8 "Don't let people do that to you, put you on a pedestal like that. You all have a single Teacher, and you are all classmates.
- 8 But you are not to be called 'Rabbi,' for you have only one Master and you are all brothers.
- 9 Don't set people up as experts over your life, letting them tell you what to do. Save that authority for God; let him tell you what to do. No one else should carry the title of 'Father'; you have only one Father, and he's in heaven.
- 9 And do not call anyone on earth 'father,' for you have one Father, and he is in heaven.
- 10 And don't let people maneuver you into taking charge of them. There is only one Life-Leader for you and them--Christ.
- 10 Nor are you to be called 'teacher,' for you have one Teacher, the Christ.
- 11 "Do you want to stand out? Then step down. Be a servant.
- 11 The greatest among you will be your servant.
- 12 If you puff yourself up, you'll get the wind knocked out of you. But if you're content to simply be yourself, your life will count for plenty.
- 12 For whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted.

- 13 "I've had it with you! You're hopeless, you religion scholars, you Pharisees! Frauds! Your lives are roadblocks to God's kingdom. You refuse to enter, and won't let anyone else in either.
- 13 Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You shut the kingdom of heaven in men's faces. You yourselves do not enter, nor will you let those enter who are trying to.
- 14 (OMITTED TEXT)
- 15 "You're hopeless, you religion scholars and Pharisees! Frauds! You go halfway around the world to make a convert, but once you get him you make him into a replica of yourselves, double-damned.
- 15 Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You travel over land and sea to win a single convert, and when he becomes one, you make him twice as much a son of hell as you are.
- 16 "You're hopeless! What arrogant stupidity! You say, 'If someone makes a promise with his fingers crossed, that's nothing; but if he swears with his hand on the Bible, that's serious.'
- 16 Woe to you, blind guides! You say, 'If anyone swears by the temple, it means nothing; but if anyone swears by the gold of the temple, he is bound by his oath.'
- 17 What ignorance! Does the leather on the Bible carry more weight than the skin on your hands?
- 17 You blind fools! Which is greater: the gold, or the temple that makes the gold sacred?
- 18 And what about this piece of trivia: 'If you shake hands on a promise, that's nothing; but if you raise your hand that God is your witness, that's serious'?
- 18 You also say, 'If anyone swears by the altar, it means nothing; but if anyone swears by the gift on it, he is bound by his oath.'
- 19 What ridiculous hairsplitting! What difference does it make whether you shake hands or raise hands?
- 19 You blind men! Which is greater: the gift, or the altar that makes the gift sacred?
- 20 A promise is a promise. What difference does it make if you make your promise inside or outside a house of worship? A promise is a promise. God is present, watching and holding you to account regardless.

- 20 Therefore, he who swears by the altar swears by it and by everything on it.
- 21 (SEE 23:20)
- 21 And he who swears by the temple swears by it and by the one who dwells in it.
- 22 (SEE 23:20)
- 22 And he who swears by heaven swears by God's throne and by the one who sits on it.
- 23 "You're hopeless, you religion scholars and Pharisees! Frauds! You keep meticulous account books, tithing on every nickel and dime you get, but on the meat of God's Law, things like fairness and compassion and commitment--the absolute basics!--you carelessly take it or leave it. Careful bookkeeping is commendable, but the basics are required.
- 23 Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You give a tenth of your spices--mint, dill and cummin. But you have neglected the more important matters of the law--justice, mercy and faithfulness. You should have practiced the latter, without neglecting the former.
- 24 Do you have any idea how silly you look, writing a life story that's wrong from start to finish, nitpicking over commas and semicolons?
- 24 You blind guides! You strain out a gnat but swallow a camel.
- 25 "You're hopeless, you religion scholars and Pharisees! Frauds! You burnish the surface of your cups and bowls so they sparkle in the sun, while the insides are maggoty with your greed and gluttony.
- 25 Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You clean the outside of the cup and dish, but inside they are full of greed and self-indulgence.
- 26 Stupid Pharisee! Scour the insides, and then the gleaming surface will mean something.
- 26 Blind Pharisee! First clean the inside of the cup and dish, and then the outside also will be clean.
- 27 "You're hopeless, you religion scholars and Pharisees! Frauds! You're like manicured grave plots, grass clipped and the flowers bright, but six feet down it's all rotting bones and worm-eaten flesh.
- 27 Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You are like whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside but on the inside are full of dead men's bones and everything unclean.

- 28 People look at you and think you're saints, but beneath the skin you're total frauds.
- 28 In the same way, on the outside you appear to people as righteous but on the inside you are full of hypocrisy and wickedness.
- 29 "You're hopeless, you religion scholars and Pharisees! Frauds! You build granite tombs for your prophets and marble monuments for your saints.
- 29 Woe to you, teachers of the law and Pharisees, you hypocrites! You build tombs for the prophets and decorate the graves of the righteous.
- 30 And you say that if you had lived in the days of your ancestors, no blood would have been on your hands.
- 30 And you say, 'If we had lived in the days of our forefathers, we would not have taken part with them in shedding the blood of the prophets.'
- 31 You protest too much! You're cut from the same cloth as those murderers,
- 31 So you testify against yourselves that you are the descendants of those who murdered the prophets.
- 32 and daily add to the death count.
- 32 Fill up, then, the measure of the sin of your forefathers!
- 33 "Snakes! Reptilian sneaks! Do you think you can worm your way out of this? Never have to pay the piper?
- 33 You snakes! You brood of vipers! How will you escape being condemned to hell?
- 34 It's on account of people like you that I send prophets and wise guides and scholars generation after generation--and generation after generation you treat them like dirt, greeting them with lynch mobs, hounding them with abuse.
- 34 Therefore I am sending you prophets and wise men and teachers. Some of them you will kill and crucify; others you will flog in your synagogues and pursue from town to town.
- 35 "You can't squirm out of this: Every drop of righteous blood ever spilled on this earth, beginning with the blood of that good man Abel right down to the blood of Zechariah, Barachiah's son, whom you murdered at his prayers, is on your head.
- 35 And so upon you will come all the righteous blood that has been shed on earth, from the blood of righteous Abel to the blood of Zechariah son

- of Berekiah, whom you murdered between the temple and the altar.
- 36 All this, I'm telling you, is coming down on you, on your generation.
- 36 I tell you the truth, all this will come upon this generation.
- 37 "Jerusalem! Jerusalem! Murderer of prophets! Killer of the ones who brought you God's news! How often I've ached to embrace your children, the way a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you wouldn't let me.
- 37 O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, you who kill the prophets and stone those sent to you, how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you were not willing.
- 38 And now you're so desolate, nothing but a ghost town.
- 38 Look, your house is left to you desolate.
- 39 What is there left to say? Only this: I'm out of here soon. The next time you see me you'll say, 'Oh, God has blessed him! He's come, bringing God's rule!'"
- 39 For I tell you, you will not see me again until you say, 'Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord.' "

Matthew 24

MSG

NIV

- 1 Jesus then left the Temple. As he walked away, his disciples pointed out how very impressive the Temple architecture was.
- 1 Jesus left the temple and was walking away when his disciples came up to him to call his attention to its buildings.
- 2 Jesus said, "You're not impressed by all this sheer size, are you? The truth of the matter is that there's not a stone in that building that is not going to end up in a pile of rubble."
- 2 Do you see all these things? he asked. "I tell you the truth, not one stone here will be left on another; every one will be thrown down."
- 3 Later as he was sitting on Mount Olives, his disciples approached and asked him, "Tell us, when are these things going to happen? What will be the sign of your coming, that the time's up?"
- 3 As Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives, the disciples came to him privately. "Tell us," they said, "when will this happen, and what will be

- the sign of your coming and of the end of the age?"
- 4 Jesus said, "Watch out for doomsday deceivers.
 - 4 Jesus answered: "Watch out that no one deceives you.
 - 5 Many leaders are going to show up with forged identities, claiming, 'I am Christ, the Messiah.' They will deceive a lot of people.
 - 5 For many will come in my name, claiming, 'I am the Christ, ' and will deceive many.
 - 6 When reports come in of wars and rumored wars, keep your head and don't panic. This is routine history; this is no sign of the end.
 - 6 You will hear of wars and rumors of wars, but see to it that you are not alarmed. Such things must happen, but the end is still to come.
 - 7 Nation will fight nation and ruler fight ruler, over and over. Famines and earthquakes will occur in various places.
 - 7 Nation will rise against nation, and kingdom against kingdom. There will be famines and earthquakes in various places.
 - 8 This is nothing compared to what is coming.
 - 8 All these are the beginning of birth pains.
 - 9 "They are going to throw you to the wolves and kill you, everyone hating you because you carry my name.
 - 9 Then you will be handed over to be persecuted and put to death, and you will be hated by all nations because of me.
 - 10 And then, going from bad to worse, it will be dog-eat-dog, everyone at each other's throat, everyone hating each other.
 - 10 At that time many will turn away from the faith and will betray and hate each other,
 - 11 "In the confusion, lying preachers will come forward and deceive a lot of people.
 - 11 and many false prophets will appear and deceive many people.
 - 12 For many others, the overwhelming spread of evil will do them in--nothing left of their love but a mound of ashes.
 - 12 Because of the increase of wickedness, the love of most will grow cold,
 - 13 "Staying with it--that's what God requires. Stay with it to the end. You won't be sorry, and you'll be saved.
 - 13 but he who stands firm to the end will be saved.
 - 14 All during this time, the good news--the Message of the kingdom--will be preached all over the world, a witness staked out in every country.

And then the end will come.

- 14 And this gospel of the kingdom will be preached in the whole world as a testimony to all nations, and then the end will come.
- 15 "But be ready to run for it when you see the monster of desecration set up in the Temple sanctuary. The prophet Daniel described this. If you've read Daniel, you'll know what I'm talking about.
- 15 So when you see standing in the holy place 'the abomination that causes desolation,' spoken of through the prophet Daniel--let the reader understand--
- 16 If you're living in Judea at the time, run for the hills;
- 16 then let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains.
- 17 if you're working in the yard, don't return to the house to get anything;
- 17 Let no one on the roof of his house go down to take anything out of the house.
- 18 if you're out in the field, don't go back and get your coat.
- 18 Let no one in the field go back to get his cloak.
- 19 Pregnant and nursing mothers will have it especially hard.
- 19 How dreadful it will be in those days for pregnant women and nursing mothers!
- 20 Hope and pray this won't happen during the winter or on a Sabbath.
- 20 Pray that your flight will not take place in winter or on the Sabbath.
- 21 "This is going to be trouble on a scale beyond what the world has ever seen, or will see again.
- 21 For then there will be great distress, unequaled from the beginning of the world until now-- and never to be equaled again.
- 22 If these days of trouble were left to run their course, nobody would make it. But on account of God's chosen people, the trouble will be cut short.
- 22 If those days had not been cut short, no one would survive, but for the sake of the elect those days will be shortened.
- 23 "If anyone tries to flag you down, calling out, 'Here's the Messiah!' or points, 'There he is!' don't fall for it.
- 23 At that time if anyone says to you, 'Look, here is the Christ!' or, 'There he is!' do not believe it.
- 24 Fake Messiahs and lying preachers are going to pop up everywhere. Their impressive credentials and dazzling performances will pull the

- wool over the eyes of even those who ought to know better.
- 24 For false Christs and false prophets will appear and perform great signs and miracles to deceive even the elect--if that were possible.
- 25 But I've given you fair warning.
- 25 See, I have told you ahead of time.
- 26 "So if they say, 'Run to the country and see him arrive!' or, 'Quick, get downtown, see him come!' don't give them the time of day.
- 26 So if anyone tells you, 'There he is, out in the desert,' do not go out; or, 'Here he is, in the inner rooms,' do not believe it.
- 27 The Arrival of the Son of Man isn't something you go to see. He comes like swift lightning to you!
- 27 For as lightning that comes from the east is visible even in the west, so will be the coming of the Son of Man.
- 28 Whenever you see crowds gathering, think of carrion vultures circling, moving in, hovering over a rotting carcass. You can be quite sure that it's not the living Son of Man pulling in those crowds.
- 28 Wherever there is a carcass, there the vultures will gather.
- 29 "Following those hard times, Sun will fade out, moon cloud over, Stars fall out of the sky, cosmic powers tremble.
- 29 Immediately after the distress of those days 'the sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light; the stars will fall from the sky, and the heavenly bodies will be shaken.'
- 30 "Then, the Arrival of the Son of Man! It will fill the skies--no one will miss it. Unready people all over the world, outsiders to the splendor and power, will raise a huge lament as they watch the Son of Man blazing out of heaven.
- 30 At that time the sign of the Son of Man will appear in the sky, and all the nations of the earth will mourn. They will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of the sky, with power and great glory.
- 31 At that same moment, he'll dispatch his angels with a trumpet-blast summons, pulling in God's chosen from the four winds, from pole to pole.
- 31 And he will send his angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather his elect from the four winds, from one end of the heavens to the other.

- 32 "Take a lesson from the fig tree. From the moment you notice its buds form, the merest hint of green, you know summer's just around the corner.
- 32 Now learn this lesson from the fig tree: As soon as its twigs get tender and its leaves come out, you know that summer is near.
- 33 So it is with you: When you see all these things, you'll know he's at the door.
- 33 Even so, when you see all these things, you know that it is near, right at the door.
- 34 Don't take this lightly. I'm not just saying this for some future generation, but for all of you. This age continues until all these things take place.
- 34 I tell you the truth, this generation will certainly not pass away until all these things have happened.
- 35 Sky and earth will wear out; my words won't wear out.
- 35 Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will never pass away.
- 36 "But the exact day and hour? No one knows that, not even heaven's angels, not even the Son. Only the Father knows.
- 36 No one knows about that day or hour, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father.
- 37 "The Arrival of the Son of Man will take place in times like Noah's.
- 37 As it was in the days of Noah, so it will be at the coming of the Son of Man.
- 38 Before the great flood everyone was carrying on as usual, having a good time right up to the day Noah boarded the ark.
- 38 For in the days before the flood, people were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, up to the day Noah entered the ark;
- 39 They knew nothing--until the flood hit and swept everything away. "The Son of Man's Arrival will be like that:
- 39 and they knew nothing about what would happen until the flood came and took them all away. That is how it will be at the coming of the Son of Man.
- 40 Two men will be working in the field--one will be taken, one left behind;
- 40 Two men will be in the field; one will be taken and the other left.

- 41 two women will be grinding at the mill--one will be taken, one left behind.
- 41 Two women will be grinding with a hand mill; one will be taken and the other left.
- 42 So stay awake, alert. You have no idea what day your Master will show up.
- 42 Therefore keep watch, because you do not know on what day your Lord will come.
- 43 But you do know this: You know that if the homeowner had known what time of night the burglar would arrive, he would have been there with his dogs to prevent the break-in.
- 43 But understand this: If the owner of the house had known at what time of night the thief was coming, he would have kept watch and would not have let his house be broken into.
- 44 Be vigilant just like that. You have no idea when the Son of Man is going to show up.
- 44 So you also must be ready, because the Son of Man will come at an hour when you do not expect him.
- 45 "Who here qualifies for the job of overseeing the kitchen? A person the Master can depend on to feed the workers on time each day.
- 45 Who then is the faithful and wise servant, whom the master has put in charge of the servants in his household to give them their food at the proper time?
- 46 Someone the Master can drop in on unannounced and always find him doing his job. A God-blessed man or woman, I tell you.
- 46 It will be good for that servant whose master finds him doing so when he returns.
- 47 It won't be long before the Master will put this person in charge of the whole operation.
- 47 I tell you the truth, he will put him in charge of all his possessions.
- 48 "But if that person only looks out for himself, and the minute the Master is away does what he pleases--
- 48 But suppose that servant is wicked and says to himself, 'My master is staying away a long time,'
- 49 abusing the help and throwing drunken parties for his friends--

49 and he then begins to beat his fellow servants and to eat and drink with drunkards.
50 the Master is going to show up when he least expects it
50 The master of that servant will come on a day when he does not expect him and at an hour he is not aware of.
51 and make hash of him. He'll end up in the dump with the hypocrites, out in the cold shivering, teeth chattering.
51 He will cut him to pieces and assign him a place with the hypocrites, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

Matthew 25

MSG

NIV

- 1 "God's kingdom is like ten young virgins who took oil lamps and went out to greet the bridegroom.
- 1 At that time the kingdom of heaven will be like ten virgins who took their lamps and went out to meet the bridegroom.
- 2 Five were silly and five were smart.
- 2 Five of them were foolish and five were wise.
- 3 The silly virgins took lamps, but no extra oil.
- 3 The foolish ones took their lamps but did not take any oil with them.
- 4 The smart virgins took jars of oil to feed their lamps.
- 4 The wise, however, took oil in jars along with their lamps.
- 5 The bridegroom didn't show up when they expected him, and they all fell asleep.
- 5 The bridegroom was a long time in coming, and they all became drowsy and fell asleep.
- 6 "In the middle of the night someone yelled out, 'He's here! The bridegroom's here! Go out and greet him!'
- 6 At midnight the cry rang out: 'Here's the bridegroom! Come out to meet him!'
- 7 "The ten virgins got up and got their lamps ready.
- 7 Then all the virgins woke up and trimmed their lamps.
- 8 The silly virgins said to the smart ones, 'Our lamps are going out; lend us some of your oil.'

- 8 The foolish ones said to the wise, 'Give us some of your oil; our lamps are going out.'
- 9 "They answered, 'There might not be enough to go around; go buy your own.'
- 9 'No,' they replied, 'there may not be enough for both us and you. Instead, go to those who sell oil and buy some for yourselves.'
- 10 "They did, but while they were out buying oil, the bridegroom arrived. When everyone who was there to greet him had gone into the wedding feast, the door was locked.
- 10 But while they were on their way to buy the oil, the bridegroom arrived. The virgins who were ready went in with him to the wedding banquet. And the door was shut.
- 11 "Much later, the other virgins, the silly ones, showed up and knocked on the door, saying, 'Master, we're here. Let us in.'
- 11 Later the others also came. 'Sir! Sir!' they said. 'Open the door for us!'
- 12 "He answered, 'Do I know you? I don't think I know you.'
- 12 But he replied, 'I tell you the truth, I don't know you.'
- 13 "So stay alert. You have no idea when he might arrive.
- 13 Therefore keep watch, because you do not know the day or the hour.
- 14 "It's also like a man going off on an extended trip. He called his servants together and delegated responsibilities.
- 14 Again, it will be like a man going on a journey, who called his servants and entrusted his property to them.
- 15 To one he gave five thousand dollars, to another two thousand, to a third one thousand, depending on their abilities. Then he left.
- 15 To one he gave five talents of money, to another two talents, and to another one talent, each according to his ability. Then he went on his journey.
- 16 Right off, the first servant went to work and doubled his master's investment.
- 16 The man who had received the five talents went at once and put his money to work and gained five more.
- 17 The second did the same.
- 17 So also, the one with the two talents gained two more.
- 18 But the man with the single thousand dug a hole and carefully buried his master's money.

- 18 But the man who had received the one talent went off, dug a hole in the ground and hid his master's money.
- 19 "After a long absence, the master of those three servants came back and settled up with them.
- 19 After a long time the master of those servants returned and settled accounts with them.
- 20 The one given five thousand dollars showed him how he had doubled his investment.
- 20 The man who had received the five talents brought the other five. 'Master,' he said, 'you entrusted me with five talents. See, I have gained five more.'
- 21 His master commended him: 'Good work! You did your job well. From now on be my partner.'
- 21 His master replied, 'Well done, good and faithful servant! You have been faithful with a few things; I will put you in charge of many things. Come and share your master's happiness!'
- 22 "The servant with the two thousand showed how he also had doubled his master's investment.
- 22 The man with the two talents also came. 'Master,' he said, 'you entrusted me with two talents; see, I have gained two more.'
- 23 His master commended him: 'Good work! You did your job well. From now on be my partner.'
- 23 His master replied, 'Well done, good and faithful servant! You have been faithful with a few things; I will put you in charge of many things. Come and share your master's happiness!'
- 24 "The servant given one thousand said, 'Master, I know you have high standards and hate careless ways, that you demand the best and make no allowances for error.
- 24 Then the man who had received the one talent came. 'Master,' he said, 'I knew that you are a hard man, harvesting where you have not sown and gathering where you have not scattered seed.
- 25 I was afraid I might disappoint you, so I found a good hiding place and secured your money. Here it is, safe and sound down to the last cent.'
- 25 So I was afraid and went out and hid your talent in the ground. See, here is what belongs to you.'

- 26 "The master was furious. 'That's a terrible way to live! It's criminal to live cautiously like that! If you knew I was after the best, why did you do less than the least?
- 26 His master replied, 'You wicked, lazy servant! So you knew that I harvest where I have not sown and gather where I have not scattered seed?
- 27 The least you could have done would have been to invest the sum with the bankers, where at least I would have gotten a little interest.
- 27 Well then, you should have put my money on deposit with the bankers, so that when I returned I would have received it back with interest.
- 28 "'Take the thousand and give it to the one who risked the most. And get rid of this "play-it-safe" who won't go out on a limb.
- 28 'Take the talent from him and give it to the one who has the ten talents.
- 29 (SEE 25:28)
- 29 For everyone who has will be given more, and he will have an abundance. Whoever does not have, even what he has will be taken from him.
- 30 Throw him out into utter darkness.'
- 30 And throw that worthless servant outside, into the darkness, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.'
- 31 "When he finally arrives, blazing in beauty and all his angels with him, the Son of Man will take his place on his glorious throne.
- 31 When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with him, he will sit on his throne in heavenly glory.
- 32 Then all the nations will be arranged before him and he will sort the people out, much as a shepherd sorts out sheep and goats,
- 32 All the nations will be gathered before him, and he will separate the people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats.
- 33 putting sheep to his right and goats to his left.
- 33 He will put the sheep on his right and the goats on his left.
- 34 "Then the King will say to those on his right, 'Enter, you who are blessed by my Father! Take what's coming to you in this kingdom. It's been ready for you since the world's foundation.
- 34 Then the King will say to those on his right, 'Come, you who are blessed by my Father; take your inheritance, the kingdom prepared for

you since the creation of the world.

35 And here's why: I was hungry and you fed me, I was thirsty and you gave me a drink, I was homeless and you gave me a room,

35 For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink, I was a stranger and you invited me in,

36 I was shivering and you gave me clothes, I was sick and you stopped to visit, I was in prison and you came to me.'

36 I needed clothes and you clothed me, I was sick and you looked after me, I was in prison and you came to visit me.'

37 "Then those 'sheep' are going to say, 'Master, what are you talking about? When did we ever see you hungry and feed you, thirsty and give you a drink?

37 Then the righteous will answer him, 'Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you something to drink?

38 And when did we ever see you sick or in prison and come to you?'

38 When did we see you a stranger and invite you in, or needing clothes and clothe you?

39 (SEE 25:38)

39 When did we see you sick or in prison and go to visit you?'

40 Then the King will say, 'I'm telling the solemn truth: Whenever you did one of these things to someone overlooked or ignored, that was me--you did it to me.'

40 The King will reply, 'I tell you the truth, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers of mine, you did for me.'

41 "Then he will turn to the 'goats,' the ones on his left, and say, 'Get out, worthless goats! You're good for nothing but the fires of hell.

41 Then he will say to those on his left, 'Depart from me, you who are cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels.

42 And why? Because-- I was hungry and you gave me no meal, I was thirsty and you gave me no drink,

42 For I was hungry and you gave me nothing to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me nothing to drink,

43 I was homeless and you gave me no bed, I was shivering and you gave me no clothes, Sick and in prison, and you never visited.'

43 I was a stranger and you did not invite me in, I needed clothes and you did not clothe me, I was sick and in prison and you did not look after

me.'

44 "Then those 'goats' are going to say, 'Master, what are you talking about? When did we ever see you hungry or thirsty or homeless or shivering or sick or in prison and didn't help?'

44 They also will answer, 'Lord, when did we see you hungry or thirsty or a stranger or needing clothes or sick or in prison, and did not help you?'

45 "He will answer them, 'I'm telling the solemn truth: Whenever you failed to do one of these things to someone who was being overlooked or ignored, that was me--you failed to do it to me.'

45 He will reply, 'I tell you the truth, whatever you did not do for one of the least of these, you did not do for me.'

46 "Then those 'goats' will be herded to their eternal doom, but the 'sheep' to their eternal reward."

46 Then they will go away to eternal punishment, but the righteous to eternal life.

Matthew 26

MSG

NIV

1 When Jesus finished saying these things, he told his disciples,

1 When Jesus had finished saying all these things, he said to his disciples,

2 "You know that Passover comes in two days. That's when the Son of Man will be betrayed and handed over for crucifixion."

2 As you know, the Passover is two days away--and the Son of Man will be handed over to be crucified.

3 At that very moment, the party of high priests and religious leaders was meeting in the chambers of the Chief Priest named Caiaphas,

3 Then the chief priests and the elders of the people assembled in the palace of the high priest, whose name was Caiaphas,

4 conspiring to seize Jesus by stealth and kill him.

4 and they plotted to arrest Jesus in some sly way and kill him.

5 They agreed that it should not be done during Passover Week. "We don't want a riot on our hands," they said.

5 But not during the Feast, they said, "or there may be a riot among the people."

- 6 When Jesus was at Bethany, a guest of Simon the Leper,
6 While Jesus was in Bethany in the home of a man known as Simon the Leper,
7 a woman came up to him as he was eating dinner and anointed him with a bottle of very expensive perfume.
7 a woman came to him with an alabaster jar of very expensive perfume, which she poured on his head as he was reclining at the table.
8 When the disciples saw what was happening, they were furious. "That's criminal!"
8 When the disciples saw this, they were indignant. "Why this waste?" they asked.
9 This could have been sold for a lot and the money handed out to the poor."
9 This perfume could have been sold at a high price and the money given to the poor.
10 When Jesus realized what was going on, he intervened. "Why are you giving this woman a hard time? She has just done something wonderfully significant for me.
10 Aware of this, Jesus said to them, "Why are you bothering this woman? She has done a beautiful thing to me.
11 You will have the poor with you every day for the rest of your lives, but not me.
11 The poor you will always have with you, but you will not always have me.
12 When she poured this perfume on my body, what she really did was anoint me for burial.
12 When she poured this perfume on my body, she did it to prepare me for burial.
13 You can be sure that wherever in the whole world the Message is preached, what she has just done is going to be remembered and admired."
13 I tell you the truth, wherever this gospel is preached throughout the world, what she has done will also be told, in memory of her."
14 That is when one of the Twelve, the one named Judas Iscariot, went to the cabal of high priests

14 Then one of the Twelve--the one called Judas Iscariot-- went to the chief priests

15 and said, "What will you give me if I hand him over to you?" They settled on thirty silver pieces.

15 and asked, "What are you willing to give me if I hand him over to you?" So they counted out for him thirty silver coins.

16 He began looking for just the right moment to hand him over.

16 From then on Judas watched for an opportunity to hand him over.

17 On the first of the Days of Unleavened Bread, the disciples came to Jesus and said, "Where do you want us to prepare your Passover meal?"

17 On the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread, the disciples came to Jesus and asked, "Where do you want us to make preparations for you to eat the Passover?"

18 He said, "Enter the city. Go up to a certain man and say, 'The Teacher says, My time is near. I and my disciples plan to celebrate the Passover meal at your house.'"

18 He replied, "Go into the city to a certain man and tell him, 'The Teacher says: My appointed time is near. I am going to celebrate the Passover with my disciples at your house.' "

19 The disciples followed Jesus' instructions to the letter, and prepared the Passover meal.

19 So the disciples did as Jesus had directed them and prepared the Passover.

20 After sunset, he and the Twelve were sitting around the table.

20 When evening came, Jesus was reclining at the table with the Twelve.

21 During the meal, he said, "I have something hard but important to say to you: One of you is going to hand me over to the conspirators."

21 And while they were eating, he said, "I tell you the truth, one of you will betray me."

22 They were stunned, and then began to ask, one after another, "It isn't me, is it, Master?"

22 They were very sad and began to say to him one after the other, "Surely not I, Lord?"

23 Jesus answered, "The one who hands me over is someone I eat with daily, one who passes me food at the table."

- 23 Jesus replied, "The one who has dipped his hand into the bowl with me will betray me.
- 24 In one sense the Son of Man is entering into a way of treachery well-marked by the Scriptures--no surprises here. In another sense that man who turns him in, turns traitor to the Son of Man--better never to have been born than do this!"
- 24 The Son of Man will go just as it is written about him. But woe to that man who betrays the Son of Man! It would be better for him if he had not been born."
- 25 Then Judas, already turned traitor, said, "It isn't me, is it, Rabbi?" Jesus said, "Don't play games with me, Judas."
- 25 Then Judas, the one who would betray him, said, "Surely not I, Rabbi?" Jesus answered, "Yes, it is you."
- 26 During the meal, Jesus took and blessed the bread, broke it, and gave it to his disciples: Take, eat. This is my body.
- 26 While they were eating, Jesus took bread, gave thanks and broke it, and gave it to his disciples, saying, "Take and eat; this is my body."
- 27 Taking the cup and thanking God, he gave it to them: Drink this, all of you.
- 27 Then he took the cup, gave thanks and offered it to them, saying, "Drink from it, all of you.
- 28 This is my blood, God's new covenant poured out for many people for the forgiveness of sins.
- 28 This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins.
- 29 "I'll not be drinking wine from this cup again until that new day when I'll drink with you in the kingdom of my Father."
- 29 I tell you, I will not drink of this fruit of the vine from now on until that day when I drink it anew with you in my Father's kingdom."
- 30 They sang a hymn and went directly to Mount Olives.
- 30 When they had sung a hymn, they went out to the Mount of Olives.
- 31 Then Jesus told them, "Before the night's over, you're going to fall to pieces because of what happens to me. There is a Scripture that says, I'll strike the shepherd; helter-skelter the sheep will be scattered.
- 31 Then Jesus told them, "This very night you will all fall away on account of me, for it is written: " 'I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep of the

flock will be scattered.'

32 But after I am raised up, I, your Shepherd, will go ahead of you, leading the way to Galilee."

32 But after I have risen, I will go ahead of you into Galilee."

33 Peter broke in, "Even if everyone else falls to pieces on account of you, I won't."

33 Peter replied, "Even if all fall away on account of you, I never will."

34 "Don't be so sure," Jesus said. "This very night, before the rooster crows up the dawn, you will deny me three times."

34 I tell you the truth, Jesus answered, "this very night, before the rooster crows, you will disown me three times."

35 Peter protested, "Even if I had to die with you, I would never deny you." All the others said the same thing.

35 But Peter declared, "Even if I have to die with you, I will never disown you." And all the other disciples said the same.

36 Then Jesus went with them to a garden called Gethsemane and told his disciples, "Stay here while I go over there and pray."

36 Then Jesus went with his disciples to a place called Gethsemane, and he said to them, "Sit here while I go over there and pray."

37 Taking along Peter and the two sons of Zebedee, he plunged into an agonizing sorrow.

37 He took Peter and the two sons of Zebedee along with him, and he began to be sorrowful and troubled.

38 Then he said, "This sorrow is crushing my life out. Stay here and keep vigil with me."

38 Then he said to them, "My soul is overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death. Stay here and keep watch with me."

39 Going a little ahead, he fell on his face, praying, "My Father, if there is any way, get me out of this. But please, not what I want. You, what do you want?"

39 Going a little farther, he fell with his face to the ground and prayed, "My Father, if it is possible, may this cup be taken from me. Yet not as I will, but as you will."

40 When he came back to his disciples, he found them sound asleep. He said to Peter, "Can't you stick it out with me a single hour?"

- 40 Then he returned to his disciples and found them sleeping. "Could you men not keep watch with me for one hour?" he asked Peter.
- 41 Stay alert; be in prayer so you don't wander into temptation without even knowing you're in danger. There is a part of you that is eager, ready for anything in God. But there's another part that's as lazy as an old dog sleeping by the fire."
- 41 Watch and pray so that you will not fall into temptation. The spirit is willing, but the body is weak.
- 42 He then left them a second time. Again he prayed, "My Father, if there is no other way than this, drinking this cup to the dregs, I'm ready. Do it your way."
- 42 He went away a second time and prayed, "My Father, if it is not possible for this cup to be taken away unless I drink it, may your will be done."
- 43 When he came back, he again found them sound asleep. They simply couldn't keep their eyes open.
- 43 When he came back, he again found them sleeping, because their eyes were heavy.
- 44 This time he let them sleep on, and went back a third time to pray, going over the same ground one last time.
- 44 So he left them and went away once more and prayed the third time, saying the same thing.
- 45 When he came back the next time, he said, "Are you going to sleep on and make a night of it? My time is up, the Son of Man is about to be handed over to the hands of sinners.
- 45 Then he returned to the disciples and said to them, "Are you still sleeping and resting? Look, the hour is near, and the Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners.
- 46 Get up! Let's get going! My betrayer is here."
- 46 Rise, let us go! Here comes my betrayer!"
- 47 The words were barely out of his mouth when Judas (the one from the Twelve) showed up, and with him a gang from the high priests and religious leaders brandishing swords and clubs.
- 47 While he was still speaking, Judas, one of the Twelve, arrived. With him was a large crowd armed with swords and clubs, sent from the chief priests and the elders of the people.

48 The betrayer had worked out a sign with them: "The one I kiss, that's the one--seize him."

48 Now the betrayer had arranged a signal with them: "The one I kiss is the man; arrest him."

49 He went straight to Jesus, greeted him, "How are you, Rabbi?" and kissed him.

49 Going at once to Jesus, Judas said, "Greetings, Rabbi!" and kissed him.

50 Jesus said, "Friend, why this charade?" Then they came on him--grabbed him and roughed him up.

50 Jesus replied, "Friend, do what you came for." Then the men stepped forward, seized Jesus and arrested him.

51 One of those with Jesus pulled his sword and, taking a swing at the Chief Priest's servant, cut off his ear.

51 With that, one of Jesus' companions reached for his sword, drew it out and struck the servant of the high priest, cutting off his ear.

52 Jesus said, "Put your sword back where it belongs. All who use swords are destroyed by swords.

52 Put your sword back in its place, Jesus said to him, "for all who draw the sword will die by the sword.

53 Don't you realize that I am able right now to call to my Father, and twelve companies--more, if I want them--of fighting angels would be here, battle-ready?

53 Do you think I cannot call on my Father, and he will at once put at my disposal more than twelve legions of angels?

54 But if I did that, how would the Scriptures come true that say this is the way it has to be?"

54 But how then would the Scriptures be fulfilled that say it must happen in this way?"

55 Then Jesus addressed the mob: "What is this--coming out after me with swords and clubs as if I were a dangerous criminal? Day after day I have been sitting in the Temple teaching, and you never so much as lifted a hand against me.

55 At that time Jesus said to the crowd, "Am I leading a rebellion, that you have come out with swords and clubs to capture me? Every day I sat in the temple courts teaching, and you did not arrest me.

56 You've done it this way to confirm and fulfill the prophetic writings."
Then all the disciples cut and ran.

56 But this has all taken place that the writings of the prophets might be fulfilled." Then all the disciples deserted him and fled.

57 The gang that had seized Jesus led him before Caiaphas the Chief Priest, where the religion scholars and leaders had assembled.

57 Those who had arrested Jesus took him to Caiaphas, the high priest, where the teachers of the law and the elders had assembled.

58 Peter followed at a safe distance until they got to the Chief Priest's courtyard. Then he slipped in and mingled with the servants, watching to see how things would turn out.

58 But Peter followed him at a distance, right up to the courtyard of the high priest. He entered and sat down with the guards to see the outcome.

59 The high priests, conspiring with the Jewish Council, tried to cook up charges against Jesus in order to sentence him to death.

59 The chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin were looking for false evidence against Jesus so that they could put him to death.

60 But even though many stepped up, making up one false accusation after another, nothing was believable. Finally two men came forward

60 But they did not find any, though many false witnesses came forward. Finally two came forward

61 with this: "He said, 'I can tear down this Temple of God and after three days rebuild it.'"

61 and declared, "This fellow said, 'I am able to destroy the temple of God and rebuild it in three days.' "

62 The Chief Priest stood up and said, "What do you have to say to the accusation?"

62 Then the high priest stood up and said to Jesus, "Are you not going to answer? What is this testimony that these men are bringing against you?"

63 Jesus kept silent. Then the Chief Priest said, "I command you by the authority of the living God to say if you are the Messiah, the Son of God."

63 But Jesus remained silent. The high priest said to him, "I charge you under oath by the living God: Tell us if you are the Christ, the Son of God."

64 Jesus was curt: "You yourself said it. And that's not all. Soon you'll see it for yourself: The Son of Man seated at the right hand of the Mighty One, Arriving on the clouds of heaven."

64 Yes, it is as you say, Jesus replied. "But I say to all of you: In the future you will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of the Mighty One and coming on the clouds of heaven."

65 At that, the Chief Priest lost his temper, ripping his robes, yelling, "He blasphemed! Why do we need witnesses to accuse him? You all heard him blaspheme!"

65 Then the high priest tore his clothes and said, "He has spoken blasphemy! Why do we need any more witnesses? Look, now you have heard the blasphemy."

66 Are you going to stand for such blasphemy?" They all said, "Death! That seals his death sentence."

66 What do you think?" "He is worthy of death," they answered.

67 Then they were spitting in his face and banging him around. They jeered as they slapped him:

67 Then they spit in his face and struck him with their fists. Others slapped him

68 "Prophecy, Messiah: Who hit you that time?"

68 and said, "Prophecy to us, Christ. Who hit you?"

69 All this time, Peter was sitting out in the courtyard. One servant girl came up to him and said, "You were with Jesus the Galilean."

69 Now Peter was sitting out in the courtyard, and a servant girl came to him. "You also were with Jesus of Galilee," she said.

70 In front of everybody there, he denied it. "I don't know what you're talking about."

70 But he denied it before them all. "I don't know what you're talking about," he said.

71 As he moved over toward the gate, someone else said to the people there, "This man was with Jesus the Nazarene."

71 Then he went out to the gateway, where another girl saw him and said to the people there, "This fellow was with Jesus of Nazareth."

72 Again he denied it, salting his denial with an oath: "I swear, I never laid eyes on the man."

72 He denied it again, with an oath: "I don't know the man!"

- 73 Shortly after that, some bystanders approached Peter. "You've got to be one of them. Your accent gives you away."
- 73 After a little while, those standing there went up to Peter and said, "Surely you are one of them, for your accent gives you away."
- 74 Then he got really nervous and swore. "I don't know the man!" Just then a rooster crowed.
- 74 Then he began to call down curses on himself and he swore to them, "I don't know the man!" Immediately a rooster crowed.
- 75 Peter remembered what Jesus had said: "Before the rooster crows, you will deny me three times." He went out and cried and cried and cried.
- 75 Then Peter remembered the word Jesus had spoken: "Before the rooster crows, you will disown me three times." And he went outside and wept bitterly.

Matthew 27

MSG

NIV

- 1 In the first light of dawn, all the high priests and religious leaders met and put the finishing touches on their plot to kill Jesus.
- 1 Early in the morning, all the chief priests and the elders of the people came to the decision to put Jesus to death.
- 2 Then they tied him up and paraded him to Pilate, the governor.
- 2 They bound him, led him away and handed him over to Pilate, the governor.
- 3 Judas, the one who betrayed him, realized that Jesus was doomed. Overcome with remorse, he gave back the thirty silver coins to the high priests,
- 3 When Judas, who had betrayed him, saw that Jesus was condemned, he was seized with remorse and returned the thirty silver coins to the chief priests and the elders.
- 4 saying, "I've sinned. I've betrayed an innocent man." They said, "What do we care? That's your problem!"
- 4 I have sinned, he said, "for I have betrayed innocent blood." "What is that to us?" they replied. "That's your responsibility."

- 5 Judas threw the silver coins into the Temple and left. Then he went out and hung himself.
- 5 So Judas threw the money into the temple and left. Then he went away and hanged himself.
- 6 The high priests picked up the silver pieces, but then didn't know what to do with them. "It wouldn't be right to give this--a payment for murder!--as an offering in the Temple."
- 6 The chief priests picked up the coins and said, "It is against the law to put this into the treasury, since it is blood money."
- 7 They decided to get rid of it by buying the "Potter's Field" and use it as a burial place for the homeless.
- 7 So they decided to use the money to buy the potter's field as a burial place for foreigners.
- 8 That's how the field got called "Murder Meadow," a name that has stuck to this day.
- 8 That is why it has been called the Field of Blood to this day.
- 9 Then Jeremiah's words became history: They took the thirty silver pieces, The price of the one priced by some sons of Israel,
- 9 Then what was spoken by Jeremiah the prophet was fulfilled: "They took the thirty silver coins, the price set on him by the people of Israel,
- 10 And they purchased the potter's field. And so they unwittingly followed the divine instructions to the letter.
- 10 and they used them to buy the potter's field, as the Lord commanded me."
- 11 Jesus was placed before the governor, who questioned him: "Are you the 'King of the Jews'?" Jesus said, "If you say so."
- 11 Meanwhile Jesus stood before the governor, and the governor asked him, "Are you the king of the Jews?" "Yes, it is as you say," Jesus replied.
- 12 But when the accusations rained down hot and heavy from the high priests and religious leaders, he said nothing.
- 12 When he was accused by the chief priests and the elders, he gave no answer.
- 13 Pilate asked him, "Do you hear that long list of accusations? Aren't you going to say something?"

- 13 Then Pilate asked him, "Don't you hear the testimony they are bringing against you?"
- 14 Jesus kept silence--not a word from his mouth. The governor was impressed, really impressed.
- 14 But Jesus made no reply, not even to a single charge--to the great amazement of the governor.
- 15 It was an old custom during the Feast for the governor to pardon a single prisoner named by the crowd.
- 15 Now it was the governor's custom at the Feast to release a prisoner chosen by the crowd.
- 16 At the time, they had the infamous Jesus Barabbas in prison.
- 16 At that time they had a notorious prisoner, called Barabbas.
- 17 With the crowd before him, Pilate said, "Which prisoner do you want me to pardon: Jesus Barabbas, or Jesus the so-called Christ?"
- 17 So when the crowd had gathered, Pilate asked them, "Which one do you want me to release to you: Barabbas, or Jesus who is called Christ?"
- 18 He knew it was through sheer spite that they had turned Jesus over to him.
- 18 For he knew it was out of envy that they had handed Jesus over to him.
- 19 While court was still in session, Pilate's wife sent him a message: "Don't get mixed up in judging this noble man. I've just been through a long and troubled night because of a dream about him."
- 19 While Pilate was sitting on the judge's seat, his wife sent him this message: "Don't have anything to do with that innocent man, for I have suffered a great deal today in a dream because of him."
- 20 Meanwhile, the high priests and religious leaders had talked the crowd into asking for the pardon of Barabbas and the execution of Jesus.
- 20 But the chief priests and the elders persuaded the crowd to ask for Barabbas and to have Jesus executed.
- 21 The governor asked, "Which of the two do you want me to pardon?" They said, "Barabbas!"
- 21 Which of the two do you want me to release to you? asked the governor. "Barabbas," they answered.
- 22 "Then what do I do with Jesus, the so-called Christ?" They all shouted, "Nail him to a cross!"

22 What shall I do, then, with Jesus who is called Christ? Pilate asked. They all answered, "Crucify him!"

23 He objected, "But for what crime?" But they yelled all the louder, "Nail him to a cross!"

23 Why? What crime has he committed? asked Pilate. But they shouted all the louder, "Crucify him!"

24 When Pilate saw that he was getting nowhere and that a riot was imminent, he took a basin of water and washed his hands in full sight of the crowd, saying, "I'm washing my hands of responsibility for this man's death. From now on, it's in your hands. You're judge and jury."

24 When Pilate saw that he was getting nowhere, but that instead an uproar was starting, he took water and washed his hands in front of the crowd. "I am innocent of this man's blood," he said. "It is your responsibility!"

25 The crowd answered, "We'll take the blame, we and our children after us."

25 All the people answered, "Let his blood be on us and on our children!"

26 Then he pardoned Barabbas. But he had Jesus whipped, and then handed over for crucifixion.

26 Then he released Barabbas to them. But he had Jesus flogged, and handed him over to be crucified.

27 The soldiers assigned to the governor took Jesus into the governor's palace and got the entire brigade together for some fun.

27 Then the governor's soldiers took Jesus into the Praetorium and gathered the whole company of soldiers around him.

28 They stripped him and dressed him in a red toga.

28 They stripped him and put a scarlet robe on him,

29 They plaited a crown from branches of a thorn bush and set it on his head. They put a stick in his right hand for a scepter. Then they knelt before him in mocking reverence: "Bravo, King of the Jews!" they said. "Bravo!"

29 and then twisted together a crown of thorns and set it on his head. They put a staff in his right hand and knelt in front of him and mocked him. "Hail, king of the Jews!" they said.

30 Then they spit on him and hit him on the head with the stick.

30 They spit on him, and took the staff and struck him on the head again and again.

- 31 When they had had their fun, they took off the toga and put his own clothes back on him. Then they proceeded out to the crucifixion.
- 31 After they had mocked him, they took off the robe and put his own clothes on him. Then they led him away to crucify him.
- 32 Along the way they came on a man from Cyrene named Simon and made him carry Jesus' cross.
- 32 As they were going out, they met a man from Cyrene, named Simon, and they forced him to carry the cross.
- 33 Arriving at Golgotha, the place they call "Skull Hill,"
- 33 They came to a place called Golgotha (which means The Place of the Skull).
- 34 they offered him a mild painkiller (a mixture of wine and myrrh), but when he tasted it he wouldn't drink it.
- 34 There they offered Jesus wine to drink, mixed with gall; but after tasting it, he refused to drink it.
- 35 After they had finished nailing him to the cross and were waiting for him to die, they whiled away the time by throwing dice for his clothes.
- 35 When they had crucified him, they divided up his clothes by casting lots.
- 36 (SEE 27:35)
- 36 And sitting down, they kept watch over him there.
- 37 Above his head they had posted the criminal charge against him: THIS IS JESUS, THE KING OF THE JEWS.
- 37 Above his head they placed the written charge against him: THIS IS JESUS, THE KING OF THE JEWS.
- 38 Along with him, they also crucified two criminals, one to his right, the other to his left.
- 38 Two robbers were crucified with him, one on his right and one on his left.
- 39 People passing along the road jeered, shaking their heads in mock lament:
- 39 Those who passed by hurled insults at him, shaking their heads
- 40 "You bragged that you could tear down the Temple and then rebuild it in three days--so show us your stuff! Save yourself! If you're really God's Son, come down from that cross!"

- 40 and saying, "You who are going to destroy the temple and build it in three days, save yourself! Come down from the cross, if you are the Son of God!"
- 41 The high priests, along with the religion scholars and leaders, were right there mixing it up with the rest of them, having a great time poking fun at him:
- 41 In the same way the chief priests, the teachers of the law and the elders mocked him.
- 42 "He saved others--he can't save himself! King of Israel, is he? Then let him get down from that cross. We'll all become believers then!"
- 42 He saved others, they said, "but he can't save himself! He's the King of Israel! Let him come down now from the cross, and we will believe in him.
- 43 He was so sure of God--well, let him rescue his 'Son' now--if he wants him! He did claim to be God's Son, didn't he?"
- 43 He trusts in God. Let God rescue him now if he wants him, for he said, 'I am the Son of God.' "
- 44 Even the two criminals crucified next to him joined in the mockery.
- 44 In the same way the robbers who were crucified with him also heaped insults on him.
- 45 From noon to three, the whole earth was dark.
- 45 From the sixth hour until the ninth hour darkness came over all the land.
- 46 Around mid-afternoon Jesus groaned out of the depths, crying loudly, "Eli, Eli, lama sabachthani?" which means, "My God, my God, why have you abandoned me?"
- 46 About the ninth hour Jesus cried out in a loud voice, "Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachthani?"--which means, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?"
- 47 Some bystanders who heard him said, "He's calling for Elijah."
- 47 When some of those standing there heard this, they said, "He's calling Elijah."
- 48 One of them ran and got a sponge soaked in sour wine and lifted it on a stick so he could drink.
- 48 Immediately one of them ran and got a sponge. He filled it with wine vinegar, put it on a stick, and offered it to Jesus to drink.

49 The others joked, "Don't be in such a hurry. Let's see if Elijah comes and saves him."

49 The rest said, "Now leave him alone. Let's see if Elijah comes to save him."

50 But Jesus, again crying out loudly, breathed his last.

50 And when Jesus had cried out again in a loud voice, he gave up his spirit.

51 At that moment, the Temple curtain was ripped in two, top to bottom. There was an earthquake, and rocks were split in pieces.

51 At that moment the curtain of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom. The earth shook and the rocks split.

52 What's more, tombs were opened up, and many bodies of believers asleep in their graves were raised.

52 The tombs broke open and the bodies of many holy people who had died were raised to life.

53 (After Jesus' resurrection, they left the tombs, entered the holy city, and appeared to many.)

53 They came out of the tombs, and after Jesus' resurrection they went into the holy city and appeared to many people.

54 The captain of the guard and those with him, when they saw the earthquake and everything else that was happening, were scared to death. They said, "This has to be the Son of God!"

54 When the centurion and those with him who were guarding Jesus saw the earthquake and all that had happened, they were terrified, and exclaimed, "Surely he was the Son of God!"

55 There were also quite a few women watching from a distance, women who had followed Jesus from Galilee in order to serve him.

55 Many women were there, watching from a distance. They had followed Jesus from Galilee to care for his needs.

56 Among them were Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James and Joseph, and the mother of the Zebedee brothers.

56 Among them were Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James and Joseph, and the mother of Zebedee's sons.

57 Late in the afternoon a wealthy man from Arimathea, a disciple of Jesus, arrived. His name was Joseph.

57 As evening approached, there came a rich man from Arimathea, named Joseph, who had himself become a disciple of Jesus.

58 He went to Pilate and asked for Jesus' body. Pilate granted his request.

58 Going to Pilate, he asked for Jesus' body, and Pilate ordered that it be given to him.

59 Joseph took the body and wrapped it in clean linens,

59 Joseph took the body, wrapped it in a clean linen cloth,

60 put it in his own tomb, a new tomb only recently cut into the rock, and rolled a large stone across the entrance. Then he went off.

60 and placed it in his own new tomb that he had cut out of the rock. He rolled a big stone in front of the entrance to the tomb and went away.

61 But Mary Magdalene and the other Mary stayed, sitting in plain view of the tomb.

61 Mary Magdalene and the other Mary were sitting there opposite the tomb.

62 After sundown, the high priests and Pharisees arranged a meeting with Pilate.

62 The next day, the one after Preparation Day, the chief priests and the Pharisees went to Pilate.

63 They said, "Sir, we just remembered that that liar announced while he was still alive, 'After three days I will be raised.'

63 Sir, they said, "we remember that while he was still alive that deceiver said, 'After three days I will rise again.'

64 We've got to get that tomb sealed until the third day. There's a good chance his disciples will come and steal the corpse and then go around saying, 'He's risen from the dead.' Then we'll be worse off than before, the final deceit surpassing the first."

64 So give the order for the tomb to be made secure until the third day. Otherwise, his disciples may come and steal the body and tell the people that he has been raised from the dead. This last deception will be worse than the first."

65 Pilate told them, "You will have a guard. Go ahead and secure it the best you can."

65 Take a guard, Pilate answered. "Go, make the tomb as secure as you know how."

66 So they went out and secured the tomb, sealing the stone and posting guards.

66 So they went and made the tomb secure by putting a seal on the stone and posting the guard.

Matthew 28

MSG

NIV

1 After the Sabbath, as the first light of the new week dawned, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came to keep vigil at the tomb.

1 After the Sabbath, at dawn on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene and the other Mary went to look at the tomb.

2 Suddenly the earth reeled and rocked under their feet as God's angel came down from heaven, came right up to where they were standing. He rolled back the stone and then sat on it.

2 There was a violent earthquake, for an angel of the Lord came down from heaven and, going to the tomb, rolled back the stone and sat on it.

3 Shafts of lightning blazed from him. His garments shimmered snow-white.

3 His appearance was like lightning, and his clothes were white as snow.

4 The guards at the tomb were scared to death. They were so frightened, they couldn't move.

4 The guards were so afraid of him that they shook and became like dead men.

5 The angel spoke to the women: "There is nothing to fear here. I know you're looking for Jesus, the One they nailed to the cross.

5 The angel said to the women, "Do not be afraid, for I know that you are looking for Jesus, who was crucified.

6 He is not here. He was raised, just as he said. Come and look at the place where he was placed.

6 He is not here; he has risen, just as he said. Come and see the place where he lay.

7 "Now, get on your way quickly and tell his disciples, 'He is risen from the dead. He is going on ahead of you to Galilee. You will see him there.' That's the message."

- 7 Then go quickly and tell his disciples: 'He has risen from the dead and is going ahead of you into Galilee. There you will see him.' Now I have told you."
- 8 The women, deep in wonder and full of joy, lost no time in leaving the tomb. They ran to tell the disciples.
- 8 So the women hurried away from the tomb, afraid yet filled with joy, and ran to tell his disciples.
- 9 Then Jesus met them, stopping them in their tracks. "Good morning!" he said. They fell to their knees, embraced his feet, and worshiped him.
- 9 Suddenly Jesus met them. "Greetings," he said. They came to him, clasped his feet and worshiped him.
- 10 Jesus said, "You're holding on to me for dear life! Don't be frightened like that. Go tell my brothers that they are to go to Galilee, and that I'll meet them there."
- 10 Then Jesus said to them, "Do not be afraid. Go and tell my brothers to go to Galilee; there they will see me."
- 11 Meanwhile, the guards had scattered, but a few of them went into the city and told the high priests everything that had happened.
- 11 While the women were on their way, some of the guards went into the city and reported to the chief priests everything that had happened.
- 12 They called a meeting of the religious leaders and came up with a plan: They took a large sum of money and gave it to the soldiers,
- 12 When the chief priests had met with the elders and devised a plan, they gave the soldiers a large sum of money,
- 13 bribing them to say, "His disciples came in the night and stole the body while we were sleeping."
- 13 telling them, "You are to say, 'His disciples came during the night and stole him away while we were asleep.'"
- 14 They assured them, "If the governor hears about your sleeping on duty, we will make sure you don't get blamed."
- 14 If this report gets to the governor, we will satisfy him and keep you out of trouble."
- 15 The soldiers took the bribe and did as they were told. That story, cooked up in the Jewish High Council, is still going around.
- 15 So the soldiers took the money and did as they were instructed. And this story has been widely circulated among the Jews to this very day.

- 16 Meanwhile, the eleven disciples were on their way to Galilee, headed for the mountain Jesus had set for their reunion.
- 16 Then the eleven disciples went to Galilee, to the mountain where Jesus had told them to go.
- 17 The moment they saw him they worshiped him. Some, though, held back, not sure about worship, about risking themselves totally.
- 17 When they saw him, they worshiped him; but some doubted.
- 18 Jesus, undeterred, went right ahead and gave his charge: "God authorized and commanded me to commission you:
- 18 Then Jesus came to them and said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.
- 19 Go out and train everyone you meet, far and near, in this way of life, marking them by baptism in the threefold name: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.
- 19 Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,
- 20 Then instruct them in the practice of all I have commanded you. I'll be with you as you do this, day after day after day, right up to the end of the age."
- 20 and teaching them to obey everything I have commanded you. And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."